

80/20 JAPANESE

*Learn smarter, start
speaking today, and get to
fluency fast!*

RICHARD WEBB

Romaji Edition

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Introduction

Japanese is often considered one of the most difficult languages to learn. I thought this too, once upon a time, but now I know better. Yes, it is very different from English and pretty much every other language, but it is incredibly logical, flexible and has very few irregularities. With the right approach, I believe it is possible to learn to speak fluent Japanese in a very short period of time.

That's why I've written this book. I want to share with you the knowledge I have accumulated through years of formal study, over six years of living in Japan, and countless hours spent contemplating the finer points of Japanese and English linguistics.

When I first learned Japanese, I struggled with all kinds of concepts that, in retrospect, aren't very difficult at all. The problem was that I didn't know what I was doing, or what I should be learning. I had textbooks and teachers that taught me all the basic grammar and sentence patterns, and I could even put some decent sentences together, but it wasn't until I studied in Japan that I finally "got it".

The reason for that is simple - I spent a lot of time learning what to say, without properly understanding how Japanese really works. I had to figure a lot out on my own, which only came after being exposed to Japanese almost exclusively for months on end. If I had just had a better grasp of how languages work in general, and the specific things that make Japanese and English so different, I could have saved myself a lot of time and confusion.

This book is designed to give you the head start I didn't have. Wherever you are, if you want to learn to speak Japanese, this book will help you learn smarter, start speaking today, and get to fluency fast!

The 80/20 Approach

If you haven't heard of the 80/20 rule, or Pareto Principle, it suggests that in any endeavor, 80% of the results come from 20% of the input. For a company, 80% of revenue usually comes from around 20% of its customers. In many sports, approximately 80% of the goals are scored by 20% of the players. The ratios won't always be 20% and 80%, but the point is that in anything you do, there are a few things that matter far more than everything else.

When it comes to languages, one of the most oft-cited examples of the 80/20 principle relates to vocabulary. In just about any language, the most common 1500 words or so usually account for 80% of the spoken or written language. For Japanese, the first 1000 words account for roughly 76% of the words that appear in novels.¹ Although this is good to know, it is somewhat misleading, and misses the point of language learning.

Firstly, many of the most common words have very little meaning on their own, like the English words “it”, “the” and “of”. These words are essential, but they mostly just supplement other, less common words that have more meaning.

Secondly, the most common words overall will not necessarily be the most useful words for you. If your goal is to discuss politics in Japanese, you'll need a very different set of vocabulary to somebody who wants to understand anime. You're much better off learning the words you need over the ones you're told you “should” know.

More importantly though, a language is not merely a collection of vocabulary. A language is a skill, or more accurately, a group of skills that you use to communicate. The most important 20% of the Japanese language is therefore not a list of the most common words, but rather the knowledge and understanding that will allow you to practice and develop these skills most efficiently and effectively. Vocabulary is of course necessary, but it is only one piece of the puzzle.

To speak fluent Japanese, the most important skill you need is the ability to understand how sentences are formed, and how the words in a sentence relate to each other. You need to develop this skill above all others because it applies to everything, and because it is the single aspect that is most different to what you already know, making it the most difficult to master.

Despite this, the usual way people are taught Japanese essentially equates to being made to remember and practice lots of different sentence patterns that apply to specific situations. This works for a while, but it is severely limiting and leads to a lot of confusion. I

1 The Most Commonly Used Japanese Words by Frequency: <http://www.offbeatband.com/2010/12/the-most-commonly-used-japanese-words-by-frequency/>

experienced this myself, and wish I had started with a proper understanding of sentence formation, rather than having to figure it out for myself.

That's why after introducing the sounds of Japanese, this book focuses first and foremost on giving you a proper understanding of Japanese sentence structure. It does this using simple examples and highlighting the important differences between Japanese and English. This teaches you to think differently, and lays the foundation that will allow you to say anything. It's the 20% of the language that will get you 80% of the way to speaking fluent Japanese.

One more application of the 80/20 rule in this book is to ignore written Japanese. Learning to read and write Japanese requires a lot of memorization and additional practice. I encourage you to learn these skills when you are ready, but at the beginning stages of learning a new language, an entirely new writing system is a distraction that slows you down and causes added frustration, making you more likely to quit. Instead, it's better to focus on understanding the language first. That is the most important 20%.

Deconstructing Japanese

The skill of speaking Japanese can be broken down broadly into four pieces - pronunciation, listening, vocabulary and sentence building. The sounds of Japanese, which are relevant to both pronunciation and listening, are covered in Chapter 1, while the remainder of the book focuses on sentence building. In doing so, it also includes a variety of useful vocabulary.

Here is a brief introduction to each of the building blocks of spoken Japanese.

Pronunciation

This is really important, and people often don't spend enough time on this. There's no point being able to speak Japanese correctly if nobody can understand what you say. You don't need to be perfect, but good pronunciation will make communication much smoother and more enjoyable, while also improving your listening skills. In the beginning especially, you should dedicate time every day just to practicing pronunciation. It takes time for the muscles in your mouth to develop the ability to make the new sounds accurately and efficiently, just like any other physical skill. The more you do it, the easier it will become.

Listening

Listening is a skill in itself that takes practice. In addition to learning to recognize all the different sounds and sound combinations, it is important to get used to the natural

flow of a language, and practice listening to it being spoken at a natural pace. So often, people will learn all the basics of a language, but can't keep up when they hear it spoken naturally. Focused practice on listening to naturally spoken Japanese is essential. The sooner you start, and the more you do, the better.

Vocabulary

This is obviously important, but it's more than just memorization. If you ever studied a language at school, you no doubt had vocabulary tests that required you to memorize the meanings of individual words. You also no doubt forgot most of those words as soon as the test was over.

Instead of this, try to learn words that matter to you, and learn them in context. The majority of my vocabulary has come from hearing or seeing a word in the real world and making the effort to learn its meaning. This works extremely well because it lets your environment tell you which words to learn and how to use them. This doesn't mean you can't learn vocabulary through study; just be sure that when you do so, you learn words that are relevant to you, and learn them in context.

Sentence Building

In order to communicate in any language, you need to be able to build and understand sentences. A solid understanding of grammar makes this process much less random and confusing. Grammar is often seen as boring, but it helps you make sense of new concepts, allows you to expand the range of ideas you can express, and if you learn the basics well, it gives you the power to self-correct and experience rapid improvement.

If you think grammar is unnecessary, and simply listening to and immersing yourself in a language is the most effective way to learn it because that's how children do it, consider this - when you learned your first language, you were constantly surrounded by it and had no way to escape, even in your thoughts. You had a fundamental need for language, a rapidly developing brain, and people around you that actively encouraged you at every step. Even so, it took you several years before you could put a coherent sentence together, let alone have an intelligent conversation.

The fact is, you can't simulate a child's circumstances, and nor do you want to. You're smarter now and your brain is more powerful. As an adult, you possess the ability to dissect and analyze new information far better than any child. Learning grammar allows you to leverage that superior analytical ability to great effect.

na-line

な na
に ni
ぬ nu
ね ne
の no

Here, there are no exceptions, and there is also no altered version.

ha-line

は ha
ひ hi
ふ fu
へ he
ほ ho

The third sound here is not a “hu” sound but a “fu” sound, as in Mt. Fuji. It is, however, a lighter sound than the English “f”, similar to the sound made when unsuccessfully attempting to whistle. Your bottom lip should not touch your teeth.

The ha-line is unique in that it has two alternatives - a “b” sound and a “p” sound. Firstly, the “b” sound is made by adding two lines like the others:

ば ba
び bi
ぶ bu
べ be
ぼ bo

The “p” sound is achieved by adding a small circle instead of two lines, as follows:

ぱ pa
ぴ pi
ぷ pu
ぺ pe
ぽ po

Both the “b” and “p” variations of the ha-line are straightforward and without exceptions.

ma-line

ま ma
み mi
む mu
め me
も mo

ya-line

や ya
ゆ yu
よ yo

The ya-line only has the “a”, “u”, and “o” sounds, but is otherwise quite straightforward. The “yi” and “ye” sounds died out of the language long ago. As a result of this, the Japanese currency today is pronounced “en” in Japanese, not “yen”.

ra-line

ら ra
り ri
る ru
れ re
ろ ro

Although there are no exceptions in the ra-line, this is unquestionably the hardest sound for native English speakers to master. It is mostly written as an “R”, but the sound itself is much lighter than the English “R”, somewhere between an “R” sound and an “L” sound, and is achieved by flicking your tongue lightly against the roof of your mouth. This is why Japanese people often struggle to distinguish between “R” and “L” when learning English - they use the same sound to cover both letters when speaking English.

Like all other sounds, the best way to learn to pronounce the ra-line correctly is to listen and practice repeatedly until your tongue builds up the necessary muscles to make the sound effortlessly.

wa-line

わ wa

を wo

This line only has the “a” and “o” variations, and the “w” sound is effectively silent in the case of “wo”. The “wo” therefore sounds the same as the “o” from the a-line, but they are used differently in writing and not interchangeable. This will become much more apparent when we start to discuss grammar.

n

ん n

This “n” is the only consonant that stands alone without a vowel sound attached. It is slightly different to the “n” sound produced in the na-line, although you can get away with a regular “n” sound in most cases. To get the correct sound, open your mouth slightly and say “ah”, like at the doctor’s office but not as wide, then use your tongue to close off the flow of air at the back of your throat. Doing this, you should be able to produce an “n”-like sound, almost like a humming sound. This is different from the English “n” sound and the na-line sounds, which are produced with the tongue closer to the front of your mouth.

It is important to note that this “n” sound should always be pronounced as its own syllable, and not blended into other sounds. For example, the name “Shinichi” is actually made up of the sounds shi-n-i-chi (しんいち), with the “n” sound being the lone “n”, not a part of “ni”. This name should therefore be pronounced with a distinct separation of “shin” and “ichi”. Throughout this book, this “n” sound will be written as “n” (“n” followed by an apostrophe) whenever it is necessary to distinguish it from a na-line sound.

Also, when “n” is followed by a na-line character, it will be written as “nna”, “nni”, etc., to show that there is an “n” sound followed by a separate na-line sound. For example, the commonly know Japanese word for “hello”, “konichiwa”, actually contains this “n” followed by “ni”, so should therefore be written as “konnichiwa”.

We have now covered all of the basic sounds as they appear in the syllabary. Remembering that we don’t include the altered sounds, the complete syllabary appears as follows:

あいうえお

a i u e o

かきくけこ

ka ki ku ke ko

さしすせそ	sa shi su se so
たちつてと	ta chi tsu te to
なにぬねの	na ni nu ne no
はひふへほ	ha hi fu he ho
まみむめも	ma mi mu me mo
や ゆ よ	ya yu yo
らりるれろ	ra ri ru re ro
わ を	wa (w)o
ん	n

In addition, we have the altered sounds:

がぎぐげご	ga gi gu ge go
ざじずぜぞ	za ji zu ze zo
だぢづでど	da ji dzu de do
ばびぶべぼ	ba bi bu be bo
ぱぴぷぺぽ	pa pi pu pe po

There are, however, a couple more things to cover.

Small “ya”, “yu” and “yo”

i + small ya, i + small yu, i + small yo

The three ya-line sounds can be combined with any of the “i” characters (except for “i” itself from the “a-line”) to produce another variation of sounds. When written, the ya-line sounds are written smaller than regular characters. For example, “ki” + “small ya” would become “kya”, as if you were saying “ki” and then “ya” but without the “i” sound. In the case of the sa-line, “shi” is the character with the “i” sound, so instead of “sya”, “syu” and “syo”, combining “shi” with the small ya-line characters produces the sounds “sha”, “shu” and “sho”. This idea also applies to some other sounds, as you will see below.

The full list of these is as follows:

きゃきゅきょ	kya kyu kyo
ぎゃぎゅぎょ	gya gyu gyo
しゃしゅしょ	sha shu sho
じゃじゅじょ	ja ju jo

ちやちゅちよ	cha chu cho
ぢやぢゅぢよ	ja ju jo
にやにゅによ	nya nyu nyo
ひやひゅひよ	hya hyu hyo
びやびゅびよ	bya byu byo
ぴやぴゅぴよ	pya pyu pyo
りゃりゅりよ	rya ryu ryo

Note that when a lone “n” sound is followed by a ya-line sound, it will be written as “n’ya”, “n’yu” or “n’yo”. These should be pronounced as two separate sounds, and not joined together like the “nya”, “nyu” and “nyo” sounds above.

Small “tsu” (double consonants)

Some words, when written in Japanese, contain a small “tsu” inserted between other characters. When this is done, the word is pronounced with a tiny pause where the small “tsu” occurs, followed by an accentuation of the sound that follows the small “tsu”. This must always be a consonant sound, and usually a hard, unvoiced sound (k, s, t, p). When written using English letters, the small “tsu” is instead written as a double letter. Examples include Sapporo, Hokkaido, Nissan, and Nippon (an alternative to the word “Nihon”, meaning “Japan”, and often chanted by fans at international sporting events).

Even weighting of sounds, and no accents

When spoken, each kana character is given the same weighting, or an equal amount of time, and there is no accent placed on any of the characters. To demonstrate this, consider the city of Osaka. Many English speakers will naturally put the accent on the first “a” and draw out this sound, so it sounds something like “Osaaka”. In fact, when written in Japanese, Osaka is actually “おおさか” (“oosaka”). Since each kana character is given equal time, Osaka is actually a four character word pronounced “o-o-sa-ka”, with no accent anywhere, and the “o” sound making up half of the word.

The Japanese word for “hello” is similar. As mentioned earlier, this should actually be pronounced “ko-n-ni-chi-wa”, with a longer “n” sound than most English speakers normally say, and no accent on the first “i” (or anywhere else).

Another example might be “karate”. Like Osaka, the second syllable is usually accented by English speakers, but in fact equal time and weight should be given to each of “ka”, “ra” and “te”: ka-ra-te.

Elongated vowel sounds

When a sound is followed immediately by the same vowel sound, it is usually elongated as in the above example of “Osaka”. This applies whether the first of the repeated vowel sounds is paired with a consonant or not. For example, “toori”, meaning “street”, has an elongated “o” sound just the same as that in “Osaka”. When written in Japanese, there are other ways that elongated vowel sounds can be expressed, but since we are focusing on spoken Japanese in this book and not covering writing, all elongated sounds will be written with a line on the top of the vowel like this: ōsaka.

Cities with elongated vowel sounds

The three most well-known cities in Japan - Tokyo, Osaka and Kyoto - all have elongated vowel sounds, and as such are usually pronounced incorrectly by English speakers. The correct pronunciation of these is actually Tōkyō, Ōsaka and Kyōto.

Vowel sounds followed by “i”

When the vowel sounds “a”, “e” and “o” are followed immediately by “i”, these two sounds are often blended together into one sound, resulting in something like this:

あい	“ai”, like the “i” in “kite”
えい	“ei”, like the “ay” in “say”
おい	“oi”, like the “oy” in “boy”

This also applies to any sounds that start with a consonant, so “kai” would sound like the “ki” in “kite”, and “sei” and “boi” would sound like “say” and “boy” respectively.

Note, however, that they only tend to sound like this, and will often have a faint but distinct “i” sound towards the end of the blended sound. As a pair, they are also still given the weighting of two sounds, so in the word “eigo” (meaning “English language”) for example, the “ay” sound accounts for ⅔ of the word: e-i-go.

Spaces

Japanese is always written without spaces between words or letters. Since this book will be using English lettering, or “Rōmaji”, instead of Japanese characters, spaces will be used in various places for the sake of readability.

RICHARD WEBB

Colors	
Black	ku-ro-i
White	shi-ro-i
Red	a-ka-i
Green	mi-do-ri
Blue	a-o-i
Yellow	kī-ro-i

Days of the week	
Monday	ge-tsu-yō-bi
Tuesday	ka-yō-bi
Wednesday	su-i-yō-bi
Thursday	mo-ku-yō-bi
Friday	ki-n'-yō-bi
Saturday	do-yō-bi
Sunday	ni-chi-yō-bi

Months of the year	
January	i-chi-ga-tsu
February	ni-ga-tsu
March	sa-n-ga-tsu
April	shi-ga-tsu
May	go-ga-tsu
June	ro-ku-ga-tsu
July	shi-chi-ga-tsu
August	ha-chi-ga-tsu
September	ku-ga-tsu
October	jū-ga-tsu
November	jū-i-chi-ga-tsu
December	jū-ni-ga-tsu

Chapter 2

Introduction to Japanese Grammar

The purpose of this chapter is to help you understand how the Japanese language is structured. Sentence structure in any language determines how words are used together to form meaning. The content in this chapter is quite heavy, but once you overcome the extreme differences between English and Japanese sentence structure, the language becomes much easier.

2.1 Basic Japanese sentence structure

New vocabulary

to be (am/are/is)	desu*
this	kore
that	sore
car	kuruma
red	akai
I/me	watashi
person	hito

* In the word “desu”, the “u” is usually not voiced, hence this should be pronounced “dess”.

Let's start with some basic sentences.

1. I am a person watashi wa hito desu
2. This is a car kore wa kuruma desu
3. My car is red watashi no kuruma wa akai desu
4. That is Taro's car sore wa Tarō no kuruma desu

Looking at these sentences, you may notice that:

- Every sentence ends in “desu” (pronounced “dess”)
- Every sentence contains a “wa”

“Desu” is effectively the verb “to be”, which in the above cases takes the form “is” or “am”. In Japanese, **the verb always comes at the end of the sentence.**

“Wa” is what is known as a particle (particles will be explained in greater detail later). Its purpose is to identify the topic of the sentence. In English, the topic (or subject) of a sentence is whatever comes before the main verb, which in the above cases is either “is” or “am”. In Japanese, the topic of a sentence is whatever comes before “wa”.

Now that we know this, let's take another look at sentences one and two. Text with the same formatting has the same meaning.

1. I *am* a person **watashi** wa hito desu
2. **This** *is* a car **kore** wa kuruma desu

First of all, we can see that “wa” has no English equivalent. This is because its entire purpose is to show that “watashi” or “kore” is the topic of these sentences. There is no English equivalent because in English, word order alone is enough to determine the subject of a sentence.

Secondly, since “hito” means person and “kuruma” means car, we can see that there is no Japanese equivalent of “a”. The articles “a”, “an” and “the” simply do not exist in Japanese. This makes things simpler in some ways, but can be hard to get used to for someone used to English or similar languages, as not having these words can sometimes make a sentence feel as though it is lacking somehow.

Now let's look at sentences 3 and 4.

3. My **car** *is* red **watashi no kuruma** wa akai desu
4. **That** *is* Taro's car **sore** wa Tarō no kuruma desu

Here we can see that:

- “watashi no kuruma” = “my car”, and
- “Tarō no kuruma” = “Taro’s car”

Adding “no”, another particle, indicates possession. It converts “I”, “you”, “he”, “she” and “they” into “my”, “your”, “his”, “her” and “their”, respectively. For other things like people’s names, animals, places and objects, it has the same effect as adding “s” (apostrophe s).

The one-size-fits-all way of defining “no” would be to say it is equal to English “of”. For example, instead of “Taro’s car”, “Tarō no kuruma” could be thought of as “the car of Taro”. This is more versatile as there are plenty of situations in English where “s” is not normally appropriate. “No” can be used to connect just about any two things, where one of the two things belongs to the other in some way, such as “the back of the door”, “the color of your eyes” or even “the rain of yesterday”.

To summarize what we have learned about Japanese sentence structure so far:

- The verb comes at the end of the sentence
- The particle “wa” defines the topic of the sentence, and has no English equivalent
- There is no “a”, “an” or “the”
- The particle “no” indicates possession

2.2 Introduction to particles

Now that you have a basic understanding of some simple sentences, we will look at the most important concept relating to Japanese sentence structure - particles. Particles are like small words that go in between other words to help a sentence make sense. They are somewhat like prepositions in English (in, at, on, from, to etc.), but only in some cases, and thinking of them as the equivalent of prepositions will likely cause you unnecessary confusion.

Put simply, **particles determine the role of each word relative to the verb.**

Understanding what this really means will make learning Japanese grammar much, much easier.

To illustrate what is meant by “the role of each word”, let’s first consider how the English language works. In English, the role of words in a sentence is determined primarily by word order. Take the following example:

John saw Jane.

From the word order, we know:

- a) John was the person who did the seeing
- b) Jane was the person who was seen

If we change the word order, it changes the meaning of the sentence. We can say “Jane saw John”, and it makes grammatical sense, but it does not mean the same thing. This is because English sentences always follow the pattern [subject] + [verb] + [object].

The *subject* of a sentence is the person/animal/thing that is performing the action described by the verb. In this case, “John” is the subject because John is the one performing the act of seeing. We know this because “John” comes before the verb “saw”.

The *object* of a sentence is the person/animal/thing that the action is performed on. In this case, “Jane” is the object because she is the one who was seen by John, and we know this because “Jane” comes after the verb “saw”.

As you can see, in English, *word order* determines the role of each word in the sentence and, in particular, how each word relates to the *verb*.

In Japanese, instead of word order, particles determine the role of each word and how they relate to the verb. Word order is important too, but not to the same extent. Word order in Japanese mainly influences the natural flow, and has more of an effect on where the emphasis lies within a sentence than on its literal meaning. Don't worry about this too much for now - the important thing to know is that particles, not word order, determine how all the words in a sentence relate to each other.

The simple sentence “John saw Jane” could be written in Japanese as follows:

John wa Jane wo mimashita

Firstly, as you may have guessed, “mimashita” is the verb “to see” in the past tense. Note that for verbs in the past tense, the “i” after the “sh” is usually silent, hence this would be read as “mimashta”.

Also in this sentence are the two particles, “wa” and “wo”. Like all particles, these ones define the role of the words that come *before* them.

In general terms:

- “wa” defines the topic of the sentence, as we discussed earlier.

- “wo” defines the object of the verb. Recall from chapter one that the “w” in “wo” is silent, and is therefore simply pronounced “o”.

So in the above sentence:

- “wa” defines “John” as the topic of the sentence, meaning John is the person who performed the act of seeing
- “wo” defines “Jane” as the object of the verb “saw”, meaning Jane is the person who was seen

By putting this together, we can see that:

John wa Jane wo mimashita = John saw Jane

Exercise

So far, we have seen the particles “wa”, “no” and “wo”. Recall that:

- “wa” defines the topic of a sentence or clause
 - “wo” defines the object of the verb
 - “no” indicates possession
1. Identify the topic of each of the following sentences. Keep in mind that the topic is one ‘thing’ and can be more than one word.
 - a) I watched the baseball game
 - b) This apple is green
 - c) My sister is listening to music
 - d) The red bike is faster than the blue one
 - e) The quick brown fox jumped over the lazy dog
 2. Identify the object of the verb in each of the following sentences. Like the topic, the object can also be more than one word.
 - a) He ate a hamburger
 - b) Alan watched TV
 - c) I read a fascinating book
 - d) Her older brother bought a mobile phone
 - e) My grandfather drank a big glass of water

3.7 Particle omission

As discussed in the previous chapter, particles are an integral part of the Japanese language. The truth is, however, that in spoken language, particles are often left out. How does this work? Just as with other words that are left out of sentences, it is only done when it is obvious which particle would otherwise be used. Take the following example:

I bought a book
watashi wa hon wo kaimashita

This could be changed to:

hon kaimashita

The “watashi wa” can be removed because, as discussed previously, it is clear the speaker is talking about themselves. In addition, the “wo” can be left out because it is clear that the book is what was bought. In other words, the role of “hon” is obvious. We are not going to get confused and think that the particle should be “wa”, because that would make “hon” the topic of the sentence and imply that the book went and bought something, which makes no sense. The role of “hon” is obvious, and since particles define the role of the words they follow, they become somewhat unnecessary when that role is easily identified.

Although particle omission is possible, until you can speak Japanese more fluently, try to always include all the necessary particles so as to avoid omitting the wrong ones. Just be aware that when a Japanese person is speaking, they may leave some of the particles out, and that’s fine - they probably won’t even realize they’re doing it.

3.8 Loanwords

Japanese contains a lot of words that have been imported from other languages, especially English. These are known as loanwords, or “gairaigo”, and are written using katakana instead of the hiragana and kanji (Chinese characters) used for other words. The number of these words in common use is constantly increasing. Young people are using loanwords more and more, and business people will sometimes use them in order to sound more educated, even when there is a perfectly appropriate pre-existing Japanese word they could use instead.

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The prevalence of these words can make it easier to learn a lot of new words quickly, but there is one hurdle - you need to get used to the Japanese pronunciation of these words. Loanwords are, for the most part, limited to the same sounds that exist in regular Japanese, so all of the vowel and consonant sounds that don't exist in Japanese have to be approximated with sounds that do exist.

There are some exceptions, though, which relate to the consonant/vowel combinations not present in Japanese. For example, since “fu” is the only “f” sound, loanwords will sometimes combine this with other vowels like “a” or “e” to make “fa” and “fe” sounds, which normally don't exist. This can be seen in words like “sofa” (sofa) and “fēsubukku” (Facebook). When these are written in Japanese, they are written as “fu” followed by a small “a” or “e”, similar to the small “ya”, “yu”, “yo” and “tsu” described in chapter one.

Other sounds that are produced like this include “she” (“shi” + small “e”), such as in the word “mirukushēku” (milkshake), or “wi” (“u” + small “i”), which can be seen in words like “wisukī” (whiskey). Throughout this book, sounds like these will be written as they are pronounced, so just be sure to use the correct *Japanese* vowel sound (a, i, u, e, o) as it is written.

Here are some common loanwords:

restaurant	resutoran
pizza	piza
hamburger	hanbāgā
sandwich	sandoicchi
ice cream	aisu kurīmu
cake	kēki
hot dog	hotto doggu
cola	kōra
coffee	kōhī
beer	bīru
bread	pan (Spanish)
television	terebi
computer	konpyūtā
Internet	intānetto
camera	kamera
email	mēru
bus	basu

motorbike	baiku
hotel	hoteru
supermarket	sūpā
convenience store	konbini
part-time job	arubaito (German)
ball	bōru
sports	supōtsu
basketball	basuke
soccer	sakkā
tennis	tenisu
volleyball	barē (bōru)
golf	gorufu
passport	pasupōto
visa	biza
pen	pen
a swing	buranko (Portugese)

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There are no set rules for how loanwords are adapted and pronounced in Japanese, but there is a general pattern that is fairly consistent throughout all such words. Below is a list of general guidelines. There is certainly no need to remember these, but you may find them useful as a point of reference.

One last thing to keep in mind is that a loanword in Japanese may not have the exact same meaning as that of the word it was derived from. For example, while English speakers will usually use the word “bike” to refer to a bicycle, “baiku” in Japanese means “motorbike” (the word for bicycle is “jitensha”). Another example is “poteto”, which usually means “french fries”. There are many more words like these, and in some cases the Japanese meaning is almost nothing like the original English meaning, but for most loanwords this isn’t a problem.

Guidelines for the pronunciation of loanwords

- The sound is what matters most, not the English spelling. For example, the vowel in “ball” is an “a”, but the sound is closest to the Japanese “o” sound, hence it is pronounced “bōru”.
- “R” and “L” sounds both use the ra-line
- “B” and “V” sounds both use the ba-line
- “Th” sounds usually use the sa-line
- Long words are often shortened, eg. sūpā (supermarket), terebi (television)
- When a word contains a hard sound like “t” or “p” it is often turned into a double consonant (a small “tsu” when written in Japanese), followed by either “u” or “o”, eg. **hotto doggu** (hot dog), **intānetto** (Internet), **hippu hoppu** (hip hop).
- If a consonant sound does not have a vowel sound immediately following it, it will usually have an “u” sound added after it. This includes:
 - ▷ Words that have two different consonant sounds in a row. For example, the “c” in “ice cream” is followed by an “r”, so the “k” sound becomes “ku”. This makes the full word “aisu **kurīmu**”.
 - ▷ Words that end in a consonant. For example, “ice cream” ends in “m”, and therefore becomes “aisu **kurīmu**”.

Note that although written with an “u” sound, the “u” in “su” is usually silent when it comes immediately before a consonant sound. For example, “**supōtsu**” (sport/s) would be pronounced “spōtsu”, and “**resutoran**” would be pronounced “restoran”.

The general exceptions to this “u” rule are:

- ▷ “n” and “m” sounds often use “n”, since it exists as a consonant on its own and is close enough to “m”, eg. **pan** (bread), **konpyūta** (computer)
- ▷ “t” and “d” use an “o” sound instead of “u”, eg. **pasupōto** (passport)
- ▷ a “t” followed by an “s” at the end of a word will use “tsu”, eg. **dōnatsu** (donut/s)

Chapter 4

The essentials

In this chapter, you will learn the most useful words, phrases and grammar rules that you can apply to quickly expand the range of ideas you are able to express in Japanese.

4.1 More useful particles

Japanese has quite a large number of particles, a few of which we have already covered. We will now look at few more particles that are also very common. There are no exercises to be completed for this section, but more examples that use these particles can be found throughout this chapter and beyond.

New vocabulary

Nouns	
here	koko
library	toshokan
park	kōen
pencil	enpitsu
ramen	rāmen
sea, beach	umi
shop, store	mise

Verbs (polite past tense)	
did, played	shimashita
sold	urimashita
spoke, talked	hanashimashita
swam	oyogimashita

What did you do yesterday?
kinō, **nani wo** shimashita ka

Where will they go?
karera wa **doko ni** ikimasu ka

Who will you go with?
dare to ikimasu ka

When shall we eat lunch?
itsu hirugohan wo tabemashō ka

Why did you open the window?
dōshite mado wo akemashita ka

How did he fix the TV?
kare wa **dōyatte** terebi wo naoshimashita ka

These sentences all use a verb *other than* “desu”. When the main verb is not “desu”, some question words require a particle to follow them, while others do not. Determining whether or not a particle is needed comes down to this:

Does the role of the thing that the question word refers to need defining?

For example, when asking “who”, “what” or “where”, the question word is referring to someone, something or somewhere that is involved in the action, so the role of that person, thing or place needs to be defined by a particle. Are you asking who did the action (dare ga), who it was done with (dare to), or who it was done to (dare wo)? Are you asking where the action took place (doko de), where it began (doko kara), or where the destination was (doko ni)? Generally, if the question word represents *something*, whether it be physical, digital or abstract, a particle is normally needed.

Other words like “when”, “how” and “why”, on the other hand, refer to the timing, the method, or the reason for the action. They do not really affect the action itself, hence they do not have a role and no particle is necessary.

The only exception to this might be for “when”. If instead of asking when something takes place, you are asking when it begins (itsu kara) or when it ends (itsu made), a

particle would be needed. Words relating to time, including the particles “kara” and “made”, will be explained in detail in Chapter 6.

One last thing - since a question word cannot be used before “wa”, you may be wondering how you ask about the person, animal or object performing the action, such as in the question, “Who ate my bacon?”.

To ask who or what performed the action, put “ga” after the question word.

To ask the question, “Who ate my bacon?”, you could say, “**dare ga** watashi no bēkon wo tabemashita ka”. The basic order of the words is the same for both statements and questions, but while statements would normally use “wa” to mark the person or thing performing the action, questions use “ga” instead.

Exercise

1. Translate each of the following questions into Japanese. Write down and say aloud each of your answers.
 - a) What did he buy?
 - b) What do you want to eat?
 - c) Where did she go?
 - d) Where will they play baseball?
 - e) Who will you watch the movie with?
 - f) Who used my mobile phone?
 - g) When will you return home?
 - h) When do you want to go to Fukuoka?
 - i) Why did you turn off the TV?
 - j) Why did you sleep on the sofa?
 - k) How shall we go to Kyoto?
 - l) How did he break the chair?

Answers

1.
 - a) kare wa nani wo kaimashita ka
 - b) (anata wa) nani ga tabetai desu ka

- c) kanojo wa doko ni ikimashita ka
- d) karera wa doko de yakyū wo shimasu ka
- e) (anata wa) dare to eiga wo mimasu ka
- f) dare ga watashi no keitai wo tsukaimashita ka
- g) (anata wa) itsu ie ni kaerimasu ka
- h) (anata wa) itsu fukuoka ni ikitai desu ka
- i) (anata wa) dōshite/nande terebi wo keshimashita ka
- j) (anata wa) dōshite/nande sofa de nemashita ka
- k) dōyatte kyōto ni ikimashō ka
- l) kare wa dōyatte isu wo kowashimashita ka

The word “ask”

One potentially confusing word that relates to questions is the word “ask” itself. The Japanese word for “ask” is actually “kikimasu”, which is the same as the word for “listen”. Even when written in Japanese, these two verbs use the same kanji. The main method of differentiating between someone saying “ask” and someone saying “listen” is in the particles. Compare the following example sentences:

He listened to her
kare wa kanojo **wo** kikimashita

He asked her a question
kare wa kanojo **ni** shitsumon wo kikimashita

With “listen”, the particles are simple, with the person thing being listened to being marked as the object with the particle “wo”. In the case of the word “ask”, however, the person being asked is the destination of the question, and are therefore marked by the particle “ni”. What they are asking then becomes the object of the sentence, as marked by the particle “wo”. Although it may be confusing that these two English words are expressed using the same verb in Japanese, the presence or absence of the particle “ni” tells us which action is being described.

4.6 Other sentence-ending particles

In addition to the particle “ka” explained above, there is another group of particles that are often used at the end of sentences known as Interjectory Particles. These particles do not really change the meaning of a sentence, but are used to add emotion or emphasis to an otherwise straightforward statement. Some of these are unique to certain dialects within Japan, but there are two main ones that are extremely common and used (or at least understood) everywhere.

With both of the particles below, you will probably need to hear them a lot before you can fully understand when it is appropriate to use them. Don't worry though - these are incredibly common, so if you listen to native Japanese speakers, either in person, in movies, on TV or on the radio, you will hear them all the time and will quickly get a sense of how to use them correctly.

New vocabulary

Adjectives	
boring	tsumaranai
delicious	oishī
expensive	takai
good	ī
hot	atsui
interesting, funny	omoshiroi

Verbs (polite present tense)	
close, shut	shimemasu
understand	wakarimasu

Other words	
no	iya
wallet	saifu

Yo

This is used to make assertions, and adds a moderate level of emphasis to a sentence. It is often used when the speaker is providing new information (example 1 below), confirming that something has or will be done (2), giving an opinion, especially one of surprise (3), or expressing disagreement (4). Note that this is not an exhaustive list of possible uses.

1. I bought tickets
chiketto wo kaimashita **yo**
2. Did you close the window?
mado wo shimemashita ka

(Yes), I did
shimemashita **yo**

3. That's expensive!
(sore wa) takai desu **yo!**

4. Japanese TV is boring
nihon no terebi wa tsumaranai desu

No, it's interesting/funny!
iya, omoshiroi desu **yo!**

These sentences would all have the same basic meaning if “yo” wasn’t added at the end, but the “yo” makes each statement more assertive.

Ne

This is generally used to express agreement. It is usually used when responding to something that somebody else has said, although sometimes it is used when the speaker just assumes that the listener(s) will agree with them. It also has a kind of softening effect, which in some ways is the opposite of “yo”. Here are some examples:

This is delicious
kore wa oishī desu

Yeah, (I agree,) it is delicious
oishī desu **ne**

—

I want to go to the beach
umi ni ikitai desu

That would be great! / Great idea!
ī desu **ne!**

—

It's so hot...
atsui desu **ne**...

Yo + ne

“Yo” and “ne” are also often used together to form a kind of rhetorical question, where the person speaking is stating something that they believe to be true, while also seeking agreement or confirmation from the listener. This is similar to English sentence-ending expressions like “isn’t it?”, “didn’t you?”, etc.

You like takoyaki, don’t you?
(anata wa) takoyaki ga suki desu **yo ne**?

This is Asada-san’s wallet, isn’t it?
kore wa asada san no saifu desu **yo ne**?

He understands Japanese, right?
kare wa nihongo ga wakarimasu **yo ne**?

4.7 This, that and other variations

The Japanese words for “this” and “that” are very useful, but there are a few variations that you need to know and understand well. In this section, we’ll look at the different words that can be used to say “this” and “that”, as well as some other words that have a similar meaning and form.

New vocabulary

Nouns	
bank	ginkō
chair	isu
coffee	kōhī
desk	tsukue
hotel	hoteru
man	otoko no hito
music	ongaku

Adjectives	
awful (taste)	mazui
blue	aoi
cool, good-looking	kakkoī
heavy	omoi
light	karui
pretty	kirei

Other variations

In addition to the above words for “this”, “that” and “which”, there are actually a few other words starting with “ko”, “so”, “a” and “do” that all use the same underlying principle of being defined by their location relative to the speaker. Here are the main ones:

Meaning	ko	so	a	do
Here/there/over there/where	koko	soko	asoko	doko
In this/that/what way	kō	sō	ā	dō
Polite form	kochira	sochira	achira	dochira
This/that/what kind of	konna	sonna	anna	donna

Let’s take a closer look at each of these.

Koko, soko, asoko, doko

This refers to a place or location, much like “here”, “there”, “over there” and “where” in English. As with other nouns, a particle is normally used to indicate the role of the place or location that is being defined. Here are some examples:

Let’s eat here

koko de tabemashō

I will go there

(watashi wa) **soko** ni ikimasu

There is a bank over there

asoko ni ginkō ga arimasu

Where is the toilet?

toire wa **doko** desu ka

Kō, sō, ā, dō

These words are very useful, but their meaning is difficult to define in English. They generally refer to how something is, what someone has said or how something has been done, with a meaning somewhere along the lines of “in this/that way”, “like this/that”, or “as you say”. “Sō” and “dō” are the two you will hear most. There is no need to use

particles with these words. Here are some examples, many of which you will likely hear very often:

That's right/true/correct
sō desu

Really? / Is that so?
sō desu ka

Yes, it is / Yes, that's right
sō desu yo

Yeah, that's quite true
sō desu ne

Yeah, that's true, isn't it?
sō desu yo ne

Let's do that
sō shimashō

I think so / I think that is true
sō omoimasu

How is the tea?
ocha wa **dō** desu ka

What's the matter?
dō shimashita ka

What shall we do?
dō shimashō ka

What do you think?
dō omoimasu ka

Kochira, sochira, achira, dochira

These are polite, generic words that can be used to mean “this/that/which” or “here/there/where”. Unlike “kore” etc., they can also be used to refer to people, as shown in the first example below.

This is Nakamoto-san
kochira wa nakamoto san desu

There is (some) tea on that table
sochira no tēburu ni ocha ga arimasu

Let’s go that way (over there)
achira ni ikimashō

Which car did you buy?
dochira no kuruma wo kaimashita ka

Konna, sonna, anna, donna

These have a meaning similar to “this kind of...”, “that kind of...”, etc. They are used in sentences before nouns in much the same way as “kono”, “sono”, “ano” and “dono”, albeit with a meaning that is more vague. When pronouncing these words, be sure to apply equal weighting to the “n” sound before ending with “na”.

I like this kind of music too
 watashi mo **konna ongaku** ga suki desu

I want to stay at that kind of hotel
sonna hoteru ni tomaritai desu

I want to become that kind of person
 (watashi wa) **anna** hito ni naritai desu

What kind of movies do you like?
 (anata wa) **donna** eiga ga suki desu ka

4.8 Relative locations

So far, we have learned that “ni” and “de” can be used to define the destination or the location where something exists or takes place. In this section, we will take that a step further by looking at how to say where things are, or where things are happening, relative to something else.

New vocabulary

Nouns	
box	hako
door	doa
hospital	byōin
newspaper	shinbun
refrigerator	reizōko
remote control	rimokon
train	densha

Verbs (polite present tense)	
play, mess around	asobimasu
put, place	okimasu
read	yomimasu

Here are some of the main words that can be used to describe the location of things relative to other things or places.

left	hidari
right	migi
in front	mae
behind	ushiro
next to/beside	tonari
on top of/above	ue
underneath/below	shita
inside	naka
outside	soto

These words can be used on their own, or in combination with other things or places using the particle “no”. Here are some examples:

My left
watashi no **hidari**

In front of the television
terebi no **mae**

Behind the door
doa no **ushiro**

Next to the hospital
byōin no **tonari**

On top of the fridge
reizōko no **ue**

Inside the train
densha no **naka**

As with all other locations, these should be used in sentences with the appropriate particle. Most commonly, the particle to use will be:

- “ni” when it describes the destination
- “ni” when it describes the location that something exists
- “de” when it describes the location that an action takes place

There is a dog to my left
watashi no hidari ni inu ga imasu

The remote control is in front of the TV
rimokon wa **terebi no mae ni** arimasu

There is a ball behind the door
doa no ushiro ni bōru ga arimasu

They will play soccer next to the hospital
karera wa **byōin no tonari de** sakkā wo shimasu

He put the box on top of the refrigerator
kare wa **reizōko no ue ni** hako wo okimashita

I read the paper on (inside) the train
densha no naka de shinbun wo yomimashita

They played outside
 karera wa **soto de** asobimashita

You can, of course, string together multiple locations by using the particle “no”, such as in the example below. Notice that the words describing the location appear in the reverse order to how they appear in English.

The ball is under the chair next to the TV
 bōru wa terebi no tonari no isu no shita ni arimasu
 TV next to chair under

Exercise

1. Look around you and describe where some things are in relation to other things. Write down and say aloud your sentences. Try to use each of: hidari, migi, mae, ushiro, tonari, ue, shita, naka, soto.
2. Pick three activities that you did yesterday, and describe where you did those activities, relative to a fixed location. Write down and say aloud each sentence.

Answers

Your sentences should follow the pattern below:

1. [thing A] wa [thing B] no [relative location word] ni arimasu
2. [fixed location] no [relative location word] de [activity in past tense]

4.9 Other generally useful words

Below are some other common and useful words.

hai - yes

There are two things to be aware of with this word:

1. It doesn't always actually mean "yes", and is often used to simply reassure the speaker that you are listening. This is important because it can easily lead to misunderstandings, so beware.
2. When a yes/no question is asked, saying "hai" means that what the speaker asked is true, even if it is a negative question. For example, if there was a meeting yesterday that you didn't go to, and you are asked the question, "Didn't you go to the meeting?", in English you would normally reply, "No" or "No, I didn't". In Japanese, however, you would need to say "hai", or "hai, ikimasen deshita", because what they asked is true - you didn't go. Unlike English, in Japanese it is perfectly normal to match "hai" with a negative action. The reverse is true for "ie" below.

ie - no

Keep in mind that Japanese people will often find creative and indirect ways of saying "no", since it is not a part of their culture to be direct. As a result, this word is actually not as common as you would expect.

iya - no

This is a stronger word for no that is often used to show disagreement.

etto / anō - Umm / ah

These are used as filler words when thinking about what to say next. Depending on the person, the "e" or "o" in "etto" is sometimes stretched out.

demo - but

Use this at the beginning of a new sentence, as shown in the example:

I want to go to Japan. But, I don't have any money.
(watashi wa) nihon ni ikitai desu. **demo**, okane ga arimasen.

ga / keredomo - but

These have the same meaning as "demo", but while "demo" is usually used at the beginning of a new sentence, "ga" and "keredomo" are generally used in the middle of a sentence to join two contrasting clauses together. Both can be polite, but "keredomo" is more often heard in its shortened and less polite form "kedo".

I want to go to Japan, but I don't have any money.

(watashi wa) nihon ni ikitai desu **ga**, okane ga arimasen.

(watashi wa) nihon ni ikitai desu **kedo**, okane ga arimasen.

kara - because / so

When you want to give a reason for something happening, such as in the sentence, “X happened, so I did Y”, you can use “kara”. Similar to “ga” and “kedo”, this is used to join two independent clauses together into one sentence. The first clause - the one before “kara” - should always contain the reason or cause of the second clause.

I want to eat at that restaurant **so** I made a reservation /

I made a reservation **because** I want to eat at that restaurant

(watashi wa) ano resutoran de tabetai desu **kara** yoyaku wo shimashita

soshite - and then...

This can be used at the beginning of a sentence to link activities together in a chain (another way to do this will be described in Chapter 9.4), as shown in the example:

I went to Tokyo. Then, I went to Sapporo.

tōkyō ni ikimashita. **soshite**, sapporo ni ikimashita.

kudasai - please

If you need to ask for something or make a selection, such as when ordering food or being offered a choice of beverages, you can simply say the ‘thing’ you’re asking for followed by “kudasai”. “Kudasai” is actually a verb meaning “give” in an especially polite form, which is why it fits at the end of the sentence. It’s basically a polite way of saying “Give me ...”. When saying this, the thing you are asking for can be marked with the particle “wo”, although this is often omitted.

(May I have some) tea please

ocha (wo) **kudasai**

daijōbu - okay / fine

This is a very useful word that can be used to say that things are okay, or to ask if they are.

Are you okay? / Is everything okay?

daijōbu desu ka

Yes, I'm fine / Yes, everything's fine

hai, **daijōbu** desu

kekkō - no, thank you / I'm fine

If you want to decline when somebody offers you something, you can just say “kekkō desu”. “Kekkō” literally translates as “fine” or “good”, but when used in response to an offering, a more accurate translation would be, “I’m fine, thank you”.

Would you like tea?

ocha wo nomimasuka [literally: Will you drink tea?]

No, I'm fine, thank you

īe, **kekkō** desu

itai - hurts / ouch

To say something hurts, say the body part followed by “ga itai desu”. Literally, “itai” is an adjective that means “painful”, but it is also the word Japanese people instinctively say when they hurt themselves, like “ouch” in English.

Ouch!

itai!

My hand hurts

te ga **itai** desu

totemo - very

This can be used immediately before any adjective to mean “very”.

This is very expensive

kore wa **totemo** takai desu

takusan - lots, many, much

This can be used immediately before a verb to emphasize that the action was done a great amount. It should generally only be used with verbs in their positive form.

I ate lots of sushi

sushi wo **takusan** tabemashita

There are many people

hito ga **takusan** imasu

800	happyaku	Not “hachi hyaku”
1000	sen / issen	Use “sen” for numbers between 1000 and 1999, but “issen” for higher numbers, such as 21,000 (ni man issen) or 10,000,000 (issen man)
3000	san zen	Not “san sen”
8000	hassen	Not “hachi sen”
10,000	ichi man	Always “ichi man”, not just “man”, even for numbers 10,000 to 19,999

The following four numbers demonstrate all of the above special cases:

1,100	sen hyaku
3,300	san zen san byaku
8,800	hassen happyaku
11,600	ichiman issen roppyaku

Exercise

1. Say the following numbers in Japanese:

- a) 47
- b) 123
- c) 201
- d) 3,960
- e) 4,618
- f) 50,799
- g) 65,536
- h) 701,852
- i) 812,075
- j) 9,078,384

Answers

1.

- a) yonjū nana
- b) hyaku nijū san

- c) nihyaku ichi
- d) sanzen kyūhyaku rokujū
- e) yonsen roppyaku jū hachi
- f) goman nanahyaku kyūjū kyū
- g) rokuman gosen gohyaku sanjū roku
- h) nanajū man issen happyaku gojū ni
- i) hachijū ichi man nisen nanajū go
- j) kyūhyaku nanaman hassen sanbyaku hachijū yon

5.2 Counters

While forming numbers in Japanese is quite straightforward, using them can be a little bit trickier. This is because all numbers used to define a quantity need to be used in the form of a counter, and these counters vary according to what is being counted.

For example, to say “I have two dogs” would require the number two to be used with the counter for small animals. Similarly, “I have two cars” would require the number two to be used with the counter for vehicles.

There are, in fact, a lot of different counters, some with very specific uses. Rather than trying to remember each and every one, there are a few that are more general in meaning and can be used more widely. Although there will sometimes be a more appropriate counter that you could use, it’s better to use a counter that is “close enough” than none at all. The ones listed below will be enough to get you through most situations.

Counter	Usage
en	Yen
sai	Age
ko	General things
tsu	General things, usually small
nin	People
hiki	Animals

For a full list of Japanese counters, see http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Japanese_counter_word

Generally, counters are added after the number to be used, although it’s not always that simple. The following table shows the pronunciation for each of these counters for the numbers one through ten, as well as the associated question word meaning “how much?” or “how many?”. Counters with exceptional pronunciation are shown in bold.

Number	en	sai	ko	tsu	nin	hiki
1	ichi en	issai	ikko	hitotsu	hitori	ippiki
2	ni en	nisai	ni ko	futatsu	futari	ni hiki
3	san en	sansai	san ko	mitsu	san nin	san biki
4	yon en	yonsai	yon ko	yotsu	yo nin	yon hiki
5	go en	gosai	go ko	itsutsu	go nin	go hiki
6	roku en	rokusai	rokko	mutsu	roku nin	roppiki
7	nana en	nanasai	nana ko	nanatsu	nana nin	nana hiki
8	hachi en	hassai	hakko	yatsu	hachi nin	happiki
9	kyū en	kyūsai	kyū ko	kokonotsu	kyū nin	kyū hiki
10	jū en	jussai	jukko	tō	jū nin	juppiki
how many?	ikura	nan sai	nan ko	ikutsu	nan nin	nan biki

Here is a brief explanation of each of these counters and when to use them. An explanation of how they fit into sentences will follow.

en

This is simply used when counting Japanese currency. Note that it is not pronounced “yen”.

sai

This is used to count the age of people and animals. For ages beyond ten, simply express the number as usual, but with the last number pronounced as shown in the table above. Here are some examples:

11	jū issai
12	jū nisai
18	jū hassai
20	hatachi* / nijussai
85	hachijū gosai

* For bonus points, also remember that age 20 is usually expressed as “hatachi”. “Hatachi” is an important age in Japan because it is the age from which people are considered adults. They even have a national holiday on the second Monday in January called “Coming of Age Day” (seijin no hi), where everyone who has turned 20 in the past year attends a special ceremony at their local city office.

ko

The “ko” counter is widely used as a generic counter for non-living things. If all else fails, and you’re counting something that isn’t living, use this. Be sure to include a short pause when there is a double “k” sound, such as in “ikko”.

Any number beyond ten can be created using the regular number pronunciation, but with the last number pronounced as shown in the table above. For example:

11	jū ikko
12	jū niko
20	nijukko
100	hyakko
123	hyaku nijū san ko
456	yon hyaku gojū rokko

tsu

The “tsu” counter is also widely used as a generic counter for non-living things, although usually not for large objects like cars or houses. It is probably more common than “ko”, but is generally used only for numbers up to nine. When there are ten items or more, “ko” is usually used instead.

You will have surely noticed that pronunciation for the “tsu” counter is completely different to the regular pronunciation for numbers. It may seem like a lot of effort to learn an entirely new set of numbers just for one counter, but the “tsu” counter is quite possibly the most common counter of all, and is also very similar to the counter for days (to be introduced in Chapter 6), so it is worth the effort.

nin

This counter is for people. Note that although “one” and “two” have pronunciations that differ from the regular numbers, this is not used for numbers beyond ten, so 11 people is “jyūichi nin”, 12 people is “jyūni nin”, etc.

In addition to being able to be used in combination with nouns that refer to people, such as friends, men, women, students etc., this can also be used as a noun by itself in reference to a group of people. For example, the word “futari” could be used as a counter to mean “two” in the sentence, “There are two students over there”, or it can be used as a noun to mean “two people” in the sentence, “There are two people over there”. Here are these two sentences in Japanese:

There are **two students** over there
asoko ni **futari no gakusei** ga imasu

There are **two people** over there
asoko ni **futari** ga imasu

hiki

This counter can generally be used for most living things that are not people. Technically, there are other counters for some living things, especially birds (wa) and larger animals (tō), but until you have time to learn those, you can get by with just “hiki”.

5.3 Using numbers in a sentence

Simply knowing numbers and counters is certainly helpful, but it’s obviously better if you know how to use them correctly. Let’s now look at how the counters introduced above can be used in a sentence.

New vocabulary

Nouns	
box	hako
boy	otoko no ko
concert	raibu
fish	sakana
girl	onna no ko
hat	bōshi
monkey	saru
shirt	shatsu
shoes	kutsu
size	saizu
zoo	dōbutsuen

Verbs (polite present tense)	
carry (from A to B)	hakobimasu
catch (fishing)	tsurimasu
introduce	shōkai shimasu
order	chūmon shimasu
play, mess around	asobimasu

Yen and age

The yen and age counters will mostly be used on their own to say how much something costs or how old someone is, respectively. This can be done with simple sentences like this:

This is 100 yen
kore wa **hyaku en** desu

How much is this?
kore wa **ikura** desu ka

I am 25 years old
watashi wa **nijū go sai** desu

How old is he?
kare wa **nansai** desu ka

You can also use the particle “de” with the “en” counter to describe how much you bought or sold something for, like so:

I bought this for 3,000 yen
(watashi wa) kore wo **sanzen en de** kaimashita

He sold his phone for 20,000 yen
kare wa keitai wo **niman en de** urimashita

To understand this fully, remember that “de” defines the means used to complete an action. If you think of currency as the means with which a sale is made, it makes sense that “de” is the appropriate particle. The same, of course, applies to other currencies like dollars (doru).

General counters

There are two main ways in which other counters are used in a sentence. The simplest way is to **use them with the particle “no” immediately before the ‘thing’ that is being counted**. Below are some examples, with questions and answers for each counter. Note that full sentence answers are only provided for the sake of demonstrating the usage of counters; you wouldn’t normally answer questions in this manner.

How many hamburgers did you eat?
nan ko no hanbāgā wo tabemashita ka?

I ate two hamburgers
niko no hanbāgā wo tabemashita

—

How many golf balls did you buy?
ikutsu no gorufu bōru wo kaimashita ka?

I bought six golf balls
mutsu no gorufu bōru wo kaimashita

—

How many friends did he go with?
kare wa **nan nin no** tomodachi to ikimashita ka?

He went with three friends
kare wa **san nin no** tomodachi to ikimashita

—

How many dogs did Keiko see?
keiko wa **nan biki no** inu wo mimashita ka?

Keiko saw five dogs
keiko wa **gohiki no** inu wo mimashita

This same pattern can also be used for the yen and age counters, like in the following sentences:

He bought a 500 yen shirt
kare wa **gohyaku en no** shatsu wo kaimashita

I met a 100 year-old woman
hyaku sai no onna no hito ni aimashita

The second main way to use counters in a sentence is to place the number or question word **immediately before the verb, without a particle**. Note that this is generally only used when the ‘thing’ you are counting is the object (as denoted by “wo”) of the sentence, or when you are counting the number of things that exist (as denoted by “ga” and used with the verbs “imasu” and “arimasu”). The reason for this is that since the counter is being placed immediately before the verb and without a particle, there is an inherent relationship between the number and the verb. The things being counted must therefore be directly affected by that verb. Here are some examples:

How many hamburgers did you eat?
hanbāgā wo **nanko** tabemashita ka?

I ate two hamburgers
(hanbāgā wo) **niko** tabemashita

—

How many golf balls did you buy?
gorufu bōru wo **ikutsu** kaimashita ka?

I bought six golf balls
(gorufu bōru wo) **mutsu** kaimashita

—

How many dogs did Keiko see?
keiko wa inu wo **nanbiki** mimashita ka?

Keiko saw five dogs
(keiko wa inu wo) **gohiki** mimashita

Lastly, if you have a sentence with multiple different items that each need counters attached to them, you can do this by separating each item/counter combination with the particle “to”. When doing this, the block of words that refers to the things being counted should be kept intact, including the particles, as shown below:

There are three boys and four girls here

koko ni san nin no otoko no ko to yonin no onna no ko ga imasu

koko ni otoko no ko ga san nin to onna no ko ga yonin imasu

(Give me) two hamburgers and one beer please

futatsu no hanbāgā to hitotsu no bīru wo kudasai

hanbāgā wo futatsu to bīru wo hitotsu kudasai

Exercise

1. Using the counters introduced in this chapter, translate the following sentences into Japanese. Write your answers down and say them out loud.

- a) This hat is 2000 yen
- b) He bought those shoes for 50,000 yen
- c) She is 14 years old
- d) He introduced his 62 year-old father
- e) There are three sizes
- f) Let's order two coffees
- g) I bought six of these
- h) They carried 8 boxes to the car
- i) There were 10,000 people at the concert
- j) She played at the park with five friends
- k) I caught three fish
- l) There are 25 monkeys at the zoo

2. Now do the same with the following questions:

- a) How much is this hat?
- b) How much did he buy those shoes for?
- c) How old is she?
- d) How old is his father?
- e) How many sizes are there?
- f) How many coffees shall we order?
- g) How many of these did you buy?
- h) How many boxes did they carry to the car?
- i) How many people were at the concert?

- j) How many friends did she play with at the park?
- k) How many fish did you catch?
- l) How many monkeys are there at the zoo?

Answers

1.

- a) kono bōshi wa nisen en desu
- b) kare wa goman en de sono/ano kutsu wo kaimashita, OR
kare wa sono/ano kutsu wo goman en de kaimashita
- c) kanojo wa jūyon sai desu
- d) kare wa rokujū ni sai no otōsan wo shōkai shimashita
- e) mitsu/sanko no saizu ga arimasu, OR
saizu ga mitsu/sanko arimasu
- f) kōhī wo futatsu/niko chūmon shimashō, OR
futatsu/niko no kōhī wo chūmon shimashō
- g) kore wo rokko/mutsu kaimashita
- h) karera wa hakko/yatsu no hako wo kuruma ni hakobimashita, OR
karera wa kuruma ni hakko/yatsu no hako wo hakobimashita, OR
karera wa kuruma ni hako wo hakko/yatsu hakobimashita
- i) raibu ni ichiman nin (ga) imashita, OR
ichiman nin ga raibu ni imashita
- j) kanojo wa kōen de gonin no tomodachi to asobimashita, OR
kanojo wa gonin no tomodachi to kōen de asobimashita
- k) (watashi wa) sakana wo san biki tsurimashita, OR
(watashi wa) san biki no sakana wo tsurimashita
- l) dōbutsuen ni nijū go hiki no saru ga imasu, OR
dōbutsuen ni saru ga nijū go hiki imasu

2.

- a) kono bōshi wa ikura desu ka
- b) kare wa ikura de sono/ano kutsu wo kaimashita ka
- c) kanojo wa nansai desu ka
- d) kare no otōsan wa nansai desu ka
- e) ikutsu/nanko no saizu ga arimasu ka, OR
saizu ga ikutsu/nanko arimasu ka

- f) kōhī wo ikutsu/nanko chūmon shimashō ka, OR
ikutsu/nanko no kōhī wo chūmon shimashō ka
- g) kore wo ikutsu/nanko kaimashita ka
- h) karera wa ikutsu/nanko no hako wo kuruma ni hakobimashita ka, OR
karera wa kuruma ni ikutsu/nanko no hako wo hakobimashita ka, OR
karera wa kuruma ni hako wo ikutsu/nanko hakobimashita ka
- i) raibu ni nan nin (ga) imashita ka, OR
nan nin ga raibu ni imashita ka
- j) kanojo wa kōen de nan nin no tomodachi to asobimashita ka, OR
kanojo wa nan nin no tomodachi to kōen de asobimashita ka
- k) (anata wa) sakana wo nan biki tsurimashita ka, OR
(anata wa) nan biki no sakana wo tsurimashita ka
- l) dōbutsuen ni nan biki no saru ga imasu ka, OR
dōbutsuen ni saru ga nan biki imasu ka

I often come to this restaurant
(watashi wa) **yoku** kono resutoran ni kimasu

I eat sushi sometimes
(watashi wa) **tokidoki** sushi wo tabemasu

She watches TV occasionally
kanojo wa **tama ni** terebi wo mimasu

They hardly ever go to the cinema
karera wa **metta ni** eigakan ni ikimasen

I never drink coffee
watashi wa **zenzen** kōhī wo nomimasen

Every...

The easiest way to be more specific about how often something occurs is to use expressions that mean “every ...”. For larger units of time, there are specific words with this kind of meaning. Other units of time and non-standard frequencies can be expressed by saying the period of time followed by “goto ni”, as will be explained shortly. Here are the most common “every ...” words:

every year	maitoshi
every month	maitsuki
every week	maishū
every weekend	maishūmatsu
every day	mainichi
every morning	maiasa
every evening	maiban
every [period of time]	[period of time] goto ni

These words can be used on their own without a particle, and will mostly appear at the beginning of a sentence, after “wa”, or between “wo” and the verb. Here are some examples:

I play basketball every week
 watashi wa **maishū** basuke wo shimasu

There is a meeting every month
maitsuki kaigi ga arimasu

He renews his contract every year
 kare wa **maitoshi** keiyaku wo kōshin shimasu

She watches the news every night
 kanojo wa **maiban** nyūsu wo mimasu

They can also be combined with context-dependent time words like days or months to say things like “every Monday” or “every April”. This is simply done like so:

[‘every’ word] + **no** + [context-dependent time word]

Saying “every Monday”, for example, would therefore be “maishū no getsuyōbi”, which could be more literally translated as “every week’s Monday”. Here are some more examples:

Every Tuesday	maishū no kayōbi
The third of every month	maitsuki no mikka
Every September	maitoshi no kugatsu
Every morning at 7 o’clock	maiasa no shichiji

Like other time word combinations, since these “every” combinations always end in a context-dependent time word, they should be followed by “ni” when used in a sentence, as shown in the examples below:

I play basketball every Sunday
 watashi wa **maishū no nichiyōbi ni** basuke wo shimasu

There is a meeting on the first of every month
maitsuki no tsuitachi ni kaigi ga arimasu

He renews his contract every April

kare wa **maitoshi no shigatsu ni** keiyaku wo kōshin shimasu

She watches the news at 6 o'clock every night
kanojo wa **maiban no rokuji ni** nyūsu wo mimasu

The limitations of these words are that there is no specific 'every' word for smaller units like minutes and hours, and you can only use them when the frequency of something is every *one* week or every *one* month. An alternative that allows more flexibility is to combine a period of time with "goto ni", like so:

[period of time] + goto ni

This allows you to say things like "every hour" or "every two weeks". This can even be used to replace the specific "every" words that start with "mai", so you could say "every week" by saying "isshūkan goto ni" instead of "maishū". The latter is preferable, but the flexibility of "goto ni" makes it a simple alternative that you may find easier to remember in the short term. Here are some examples of "goto ni" being used in a sentence:

There is a test every two weeks
nishūkan **goto ni** tesuto ga arimasu

The alarm rings every five minutes
arāmu wa gofun **goto ni** narimasu

He travels abroad every six months
kare wa rokkagetsu **goto ni** kaigai ni ryokō shimasu

The Olympics are held every four years
orinpikku wa yonen **goto ni** kaisai saremasu²

Number of times per...

The most flexible way to talk about frequency in specific terms is to say how many times something happens in a certain period. This is done like so:

~~~~~  
2 "Saremasu" is the passive form of "shimasu". Basically, "kaisai shimasu" means "to hold", while "kaisai saremasu" means "to be held". The passive form will be explained in more detail in Chapter 12.4.

**[period of time] + ni + [number of times]**

This requires you to know the counter for the number of times something is done, “kai”. The “kai” counter for the numbers one through ten is as follows:

|                 |         |
|-----------------|---------|
| Once            | ikkai   |
| Twice           | nikai   |
| 3 times         | sankai  |
| 4 times         | yonkai  |
| 5 times         | gokai   |
| 6 times         | rokkai  |
| 7 times         | nanakai |
| 8 times         | hakkai  |
| 9 times         | kyūkai  |
| 10 times        | jukkai  |
| How many times? | nankai  |

Like other counters, for numbers beyond ten, the number is pronounced as normal, except with the last digit being expressed as shown in the above table. Also, note that this is very similar to the counter for floors in a building. The floor counter, however, uses a different character when written, and usually has a different pronunciation for the number three (sangai).

If we now use “ni” to connect a number expressed using the “kai” counter with a period of time, we can form phrases like the following:

|                         |                      |
|-------------------------|----------------------|
| Once every three days   | mikkakan ni ikkai    |
| Twice a week            | isshūkan ni nikai    |
| 15 times a month        | ikkagetsu ni jūgokai |
| Once every 5 years      | gonen ni ikkai       |
| Ten times every 6 hours | rojukikan ni jukkai  |
| How many times a day?   | ichinichi ni nankai? |

If the period of time is one day, one week, one month or one year, it is not necessary to say the period expression in full (such as “ichi nen kan”). Instead, the simple word for that unit of time can be used: hi, shū, tsuki or nen. The following expressions are therefore valid:

|                        |                |
|------------------------|----------------|
| Three times a day      | hi ni sankai   |
| Twice a week           | shū ni nikai   |
| Five times a month     | tsuki ni gokai |
| How many times a year? | nen ni nankai? |

When used in a sentence, these expressions are used without a particle, and usually appear after “wa”, or between “wo” and the verb, as shown in the following examples.

How many times a day do you brush your teeth?

(anata wa) **hi ni nankai** ha wo migakimasu ka

I go to Tokyo twice every 6 months

(watashi wa) **sankagetsu ni nikai** tōkyō ni ikimasu

He plays soccer three times every two weeks

kare wa **nishūkan ni sankai** sakkā wo shimasu

She returns to her home town twice a year

kanojo wa **nen ni nikai** jimoto ni kaerimasu

## 6.4 Using expressions of time with nouns

### New vocabulary

|                     |        |
|---------------------|--------|
| economic conditions | keiki  |
| rent                | yachin |

It is also possible to use expressions of time in combination with other words to talk about things of that time, frequency or period. You can do this by connecting the ‘thing’ with the time expression using the particle “no”. When used with “ima”, this allows you to talk about your or someone else’s current situation. Here are some examples:

|                             |                        |
|-----------------------------|------------------------|
| His current job             | kare no ima no shigoto |
| Current economic conditions | ima no keiki           |
| Yesterday’s lunch           | kinō no hirugohan      |

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|                           |                      |
|---------------------------|----------------------|
| This month's rent         | kongetsu no yachin   |
| Every day's breakfast     | mainichi no asagohan |
| The weekly meeting        | maishū no kaigi      |
| A three year contract     | sannenkan no keiyaku |
| A two week break/vacation | nishūkan no yasumi   |





## Chapter 7

# Adjectives, nouns and adverbs

As essential parts of language, we have used adjectives, nouns and a few adverbs throughout this book to help us understand the basics of Japanese grammar. In this chapter, we will take a closer look at each of these parts of speech so that we can use them more accurately and effectively.

The main focus of this chapter is adjectives, as they are the most varied in terms of both their usage, as well as the forms that they take. Additionally, developing a solid understanding of adjectives will actually help us better understand how nouns fit into basic sentences, while also giving us the foundation we need to understand and use adverbs.

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to use adjectives and nouns in informal speech, the past tense and the negative form, as well as further enhance your descriptions with the use of adverbs.

### 7.1 Adjective types

Adjectives in Japanese can be divided into two categories, commonly known as i-adjectives and na-adjectives. The difference between these two types purely relates to syntax, meaning they only differ in how they are used to fit into sentences.

Secondly, as you can see, there are in fact some na-adjectives that end in “i”. These are still classed as na-adjectives, though, because of how they are used in sentences. Unfortunately, on their own, there is no guaranteed rule that we can use to determine whether an adjective ending in “i” is an i-adjective or a na-adjective. For this reason, it may help to learn all na-adjectives by remembering them with the “na” included, for example, “genki na”, or “kirei na”. If you do this, however, you need to be sure to remove the “na” when it’s not needed, which will be explained below.

Also, if you recall from Chapter 4.4, the Japanese words for “like” and “want” are “suki” and “hoshī”, respectively, and they are both adjectives. The “I want...” expression introduced in Chapter 4.2, as well as “kirai”, the word for “hate”, are also adjectives. These are generally treated like any other adjective, with “suki” and “kirai” being na-adjectives, and “hoshī” and “-tai” being i-adjectives. They will be featured throughout this chapter to help further your understanding of their usage.

## 7.2 Using adjectives before nouns

### New vocabulary

|          |          |
|----------|----------|
| bag      | kaban    |
| building | tatemono |
| country  | kuni     |
| food     | tabemono |
| scenery  | keshiki  |

Adjectives can be placed before nouns to add meaning to them, wherever they may appear in a sentence. With i-adjectives, we can just place them immediately before the noun, as shown here:

|                           |                           |
|---------------------------|---------------------------|
| a good person             | ī hito                    |
| a sad person              | kanashī hito              |
| an interesting movie      | omoshiroi eiga            |
| beautiful scenery         | utsukushī keshiki         |
| the car I want            | (watashi no) hoshī kuruma |
| the movie I want to watch | (watashi no) mitai eiga   |

For na-adjectives, however, a “na” needs to be added at the end of the adjective in order to connect it to the noun, like so:

|                  |                              |
|------------------|------------------------------|
| a famous person  | yūmei na hito                |
| a quiet person   | shizuka na hito              |
| a strange place  | hen na basho                 |
| the car I like   | (watashi no) suki na kuruma  |
| the music I hate | (watashi no) kirai na ongaku |

In this case, as long as you can recognize what type of adjective you are dealing with, you just need to know to include “na” if it is a na-adjective.

When an adjective is used before a noun as in the examples above, the combined phrase (adjective + noun) can then be used in a sentence as if it were just another noun. This is the same as English, as the examples below show:

He is a person  
kare wa **hito** desu

He is an interesting person  
kare wa **omoshiroi hito** desu

He is a strange person  
kare wa **hen na hito** desu

I watched a movie  
(watashi wa) **eiga** wo mimashita

I watched an interesting movie  
(watashi wa) **omoshiroi eiga** wo mimashita

I watched a strange movie  
(watashi wa) **hen na eiga** wo mimashita

This is a car  
kore wa **kuruma** desu

This is the car I want

kore wa watashi no **hoshī kuruma** desu

This is the car I want to buy

kore wa watashi no **kaitai kuruma** desu

This is the car I like

kore wa watashi no **suki na kuruma** desu

This is the car I hate

kore wa watashi no **kirai na kuruma** desu

## Exercise

1. Say and write down the following phrases in Japanese.

- a) a cold night
- b) a beautiful country
- c) an ugly building
- d) the bag I want
- e) the house I want to buy
- f) a quiet restaurant
- g) a convenient shop
- h) pretty scenery
- i) the food I hate
- j) the music I like

2. Say and write down the following sentences in Japanese.

- a) I like cold nights
- b) Japan is a beautiful country
- c) That (over there) is an ugly building
- d) The bag I want is expensive
- e) I found the house I want to buy
- f) I went to a quiet restaurant
- g) This is a convenient shop
- h) There is a lot of pretty scenery in Hokkaido

- i) She made the food I hate
- j) We listened to the music I like

## Answers

1.

- a) samui yoru
- b) utsukushī kuni
- c) minikui tatemono
- d) (watashi no) hoshī kaban
- e) (watashi no) kaitai ie
- f) shizuka na resutoran
- g) benri na mise
- h) kirei na keshiki
- i) (watashi no) kirai na tabemono
- j) (watashi no) suki na ongaku

2.

- a) watashi wa samui yoru ga suki desu
- b) nihon wa utsukushī kuni desu
- c) are wa minikui tatemono desu
- d) (watashi no) hoshī kaban wa takai desu
- e) (watashi no) kaitai ie wo mitsukemashita
- f) (watashi wa) shizuka na resutoran ni ikimashita
- g) kore wa benri na mise desu
- h) hokkaidō ni kirei na keshiki ga takusan arimasu
- i) kanojo wa watashi no kirai na tabemono wo tsukurimashita
- j) (watashi tachi wa) watashi no suki na ongaku wo kikimashita

## 7.3 Adjectives at the end of informal sentences

As discussed in Chapter 3.1, Japanese has different levels of politeness. “Desu” is the polite version of “to be”, but in informal language, when a sentence ends in an adjective, the “to be” verb is different according to which type of adjective is being used.

**New vocabulary**

|      |         |
|------|---------|
| baby | akachan |
| town | machi   |

**na-adjectives**

For na-adjectives, “desu” is just replaced by “da” to make it informal. Below are the polite and informal ways of saying different sentences using na-adjectives.

| English          | Polite                           | Informal                       |
|------------------|----------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| I am well        | watashi wa genki desu            | watashi wa genki da            |
| This is strange  | kore wa hen desu                 | kore wa hen da                 |
| Japanese is easy | nihongo wa kantan desu           | nihongo wa kantan da           |
| He is famous     | kare wa yūmei desu               | kare wa yūmei da               |
| I like sushi     | (watashi wa) sushi ga suki desu  | (watashi wa) sushi ga suki da  |
| I hate natto     | (watashi wa) nattō ga kirai desu | (watashi wa) nattō ga kirai da |

**i-adjectives**

For i-adjectives, a polite sentence can be converted into an informal sentence by simply omitting “desu”.

| English                 | Polite                           | Informal                    |
|-------------------------|----------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| That is good            | sore wa ī desu                   | sore wa ī                   |
| I am happy              | watashi wa ureshī desu           | watashi wa ureshī           |
| He is sad               | kare wa kanashī desu             | kare wa kanashī             |
| This movie is boring    | kono eiga wa tsumaranai desu     | kono eiga wa tsumaranai     |
| I want sushi            | (watashi wa) sushi ga hoshī desu | (watashi wa) sushi ga hoshī |
| I want to watch a movie | (watashi wa) eiga ga mitai desu  | (watashi wa) eiga ga mitai  |

One important thing to remember here is that “wa” is not equivalent to “is”. It may look like that in the informal sentences, but that is just your English-speaking brain recognizing a pattern and trying to tell you that words must go in a certain order. In this case, your brain is wrong. Thinking that “wa” means “is” will likely cause you confusion when using other verbs or more complicated sentences. As always, “wa” defines the

topic of the sentence, and the remainder of the sentence is like additional information related to that topic. Nothing has changed.

What this means is that in informal sentences that end in i-adjectives, the verb has effectively disappeared. In reality, it does exist, because a complete sentence absolutely must contain a verb, and all of the above sentences are grammatically complete. The best explanation as to why it doesn't appear is that the verb "to be" is actually included in i-adjectives when they are used in this way (but only then). This is a more accurate assessment, and also explains why i-adjectives have a past tense, as you will see in the next section.

Regardless of the technical reasoning, the important thing to remember is that i-adjectives can end informal sentences without any other verb present, and that "wa", as always, defines the topic of the sentence and does not mean "is".

## Exercise

1. Say and write down the following sentences in informal Japanese.

- a) This is fun
- b) That baby (over there) is cute
- c) Japanese TV is interesting/funny
- d) I want a new car
- e) I want to go to Okinawa
- f) This town is famous
- g) Your house is clean
- h) That man (over there) is strange
- i) I like dogs
- j) I hate noisy people

## Answers

1.

- a) kore wa tanoshī
- b) ano akachan wa kawai
- c) nihon no terebi wa omoshiroi
- d) (watashi wa) atarashī kuruma ga hoshī
- e) (watashi wa) okinawa ni ikitai
- f) kono machi wa yūmei da

- g) (anata no) ie wa kirei da
- h) ano otoko no hito wa hen da
- i) (watashi wa) inu ga suki da
- j) (watashi wa) urusai hito ga kirai da

## 7.4 Adjectives in the past tense

In English, we use the past tense of the verb “to be” to describe something in the past, for example, “That movie *was* interesting”. In Japanese, we do the same if we are using a na-adjective, but i-adjectives are treated differently. Let’s take a look at each now.

### na-adjectives

For na-adjectives, much like we change “is” to “was” in English, we just need to change the verb from “desu” into its past tense form, “deshita”. Note that the “i” sound in “deshita” is usually silent, and is therefore pronounced “deshta”.

That was strange  
sore wa **hen deshita**

He was famous  
kare wa **yūmei deshita**

That restaurant was quiet  
ano resutoran wa **shizuka deshita**

I liked ramen  
(watashi wa) rāmen ga **suki deshita**

I hated yakisoba  
yakisoba ga **kirai deshita**

The informal version of “deshita” is “datta”. Everything else remains the same, hence the less polite way to express the above sentences is as follows:

That was strange  
sore wa **hen datta**

He was famous  
kare wa **yūmei datta**

That restaurant was quiet  
ano resutoran wa **shizuka datta**

I liked ramen  
(watashi wa) rāmen ga **suki datta**

I hated yakisoba  
(watashi wa) yakisoba ga **kirai datta**

## i-adjectives

Unlike na-adjectives, i-adjectives themselves can actually be expressed in the past tense. This means that instead of changing “desu” to “deshita”, we change the adjective itself, and leave the “desu” as is.

To change an i-adjective into the past tense, remove the last “i” and add “katta”. Make sure that you only remove one “i” sound if it is an elongated “ī”. You’ll recall from Chapter 1 that these are actually two consecutive “i” sounds, with the first being attached to a consonant, such as in “shi”, so be sure to leave this sound intact by only removing the last “i”.

|              | Non-past tense | Past tense     |
|--------------|----------------|----------------|
| good         | yoi            | yokatta        |
| bad          | warui          | warukatta      |
| happy        | ureshī         | ureshikatta    |
| sad          | kanashī        | kanashikatta   |
| interesting  | omoshiroi      | omoshirokatta  |
| boring       | tsumaranai     | tsumaranakatta |
| I want...    | hoshī          | hoshikatta     |
| I want to... | -tai           | -takatta       |

To use these in sentences, we just put them where their non-past tense equivalent would go.

That was good  
sore wa **yokatta** desu

That movie was interesting  
sono eiga wa **omoshirokatta** desu

He was sad  
kare wa **kanashikatta** desu

I wanted a dog  
inu ga **hoshikatta** desu

I wanted to watch a movie  
(watashi wa) eiga ga **mitakatta** desu

Remember that since the adjective is already in the past tense, the verb “desu” remains unchanged.

In informal speech, the “desu” is simply left off, just as we saw with i-adjectives in the non-past tense.

That was good  
sore wa **yokatta**

That movie was interesting  
ano eiga wa **omoshirokatta**

He was sad  
kare wa **kanashikatta**

I wanted a dog  
inu ga **hoshikatta**

I wanted to watch a movie  
(watashi wa) eiga ga **mitakatta**

## Exercise

1. Convert each of these i-adjectives into the past tense.

a) ī / yoi

- b) warui
  - c) mazui
  - d) atsui
  - e) atarashī
  - f) furui
  - g) utsukushī
  - h) minikui
  - i) urusai
  - j) kawai
2. Say and write down each of the following sentences in Japanese in **both the polite and informal** forms.
- a) The train was inconvenient
  - b) Until last week, this town was quiet
  - c) In 1970, she was famous
  - d) I liked The Beatles
  - e) Last year, I hated him
  - f) The lake was cold
  - g) Today's lunch was delicious
  - h) The football match was fun
  - i) I wanted a new car
  - j) I wanted to sleep on the sofa

## Answers

1.

- a) yokatta
- b) warukatta
- c) mazukatta
- d) atsukatta
- e) atarashikatta
- f) furukatta
- g) utsukushikatta
- h) minikukatta
- i) urusakatta
- j) kawaikatta

2.

Polite:

- a) densha wa fuben deshita
- b) senshū made, kono machi wa shizuka deshita
- c) 1970 nen ni kanojo wa yūmei deshita
- d) (watashi wa) bītoruzu ga suki deshita
- e) kyonen, (watashi wa) kare ga kirai deshita
- f) mizūmi wa samukatta desu
- g) kyō no hirugohan wa oishikatta desu
- h) futtobōru no shiai wa tanoshikatta desu
- i) atarashī kuruma ga hoshikatta desu
- j) (watashi wa) sofa de netakatta desu

Informal:

- a) densha wa fuben datta
- b) senshū made, kono machi wa shizuka datta
- c) 1970 nen ni kanojo wa yūmei datta
- d) (watashi wa) bītoruzu ga suki datta
- e) kyonen, (watashi wa) kare ga kirai datta
- f) mizūmi wa samukatta
- g) kyō no hirugohan wa oishikatta
- h) futtobōru no shiai wa tanoshikatta
- i) atarashī kuruma ga hoshikatta
- j) (watashi wa) sofa de netakatta

## 7.5 Negatives of adjectives

In English, to say the negative of an adjective, we just use the word “not”, for example, “This is not good”, “That is not interesting”, etc. In Japanese, this too is done differently for na-adjectives and i-adjectives. Let’s take a look.

### na-adjectives

Na-adjectives are easy, as they simply require us to add “janai” to the end of the word without changing anything else.

|                  |               |
|------------------|---------------|
| not healthy/well | genki janai   |
| not strange      | hen janai     |
| not quiet        | shizuka janai |
| not famous       | yūmei janai   |
| don't like       | suki janai    |
| don't hate       | kirai janai   |

## i-adjectives

To convert an i-adjective into the negative, we remove the “i” at the end, and add “kunai”, like so:

| Positive     |         | Negative           |              |
|--------------|---------|--------------------|--------------|
| good         | ī / yoi | not good           | yokunai      |
| bad          | warui   | not bad            | warukunai    |
| happy        | ureshī  | not happy          | ureshikunai  |
| sad          | kanashī | not sad            | kanashikunai |
| I want...    | hoshī   | I don't want...    | hoshikunai   |
| I want to... | -tai    | I don't want to... | -takunai     |

When the last sound before “kunai” is “shi”, the “i” sound after the “sh” is usually silent, so “ureshikunai” would be pronounced “ureshkunai”, and “hoshikunai” would be “hoshkunai”.

Note that these words are also subtly different from the word with the opposite meaning. For example, “not good” is not exactly the same as “bad”. Just as is the case in English, something can be neither good nor bad, but somewhere in between. The same applies for all adjectives of both types.

## Exercise

- Say and write down each of the following negative adjectives in Japanese.
  - not convenient
  - not inconvenient
  - not pretty

- d) not delicious
- e) not awful (taste)
- f) not cold
- g) not interesting/funny
- h) not fun
- i) not new
- j) not cute

## Answers

1.

- a) benri janai
- b) fuben janai
- c) kirei janai
- d) oishikunai
- e) mazukunai
- f) samukunai
- g) omoshirokunai
- h) tanoshikunai
- i) atarashikunai
- j) kawaikunai

## Using negative adjectives

Adjectives in their negative form can actually be used in all the same ways as adjectives in the normal, positive form. What makes life a bit easier is that both i-adjectives and na-adjectives actually become i-adjectives when they are negative. This means they all function in the same way as i-adjectives in the following ways:

- They can be placed immediately before nouns without adding “na”
- They can be used unmodified to end sentences in informal speech
- They can be converted to the past tense by replacing the last “i” with “katta”

Let's now look at each of these.

## Placing negative adjectives before nouns

When na-adjectives are placed before a noun, “na” needs to be inserted in between the adjective and the noun, such as in, “genki na hito”. Negative adjectives, however, can be placed immediately before a noun unmodified, just like all i-adjectives. Here are some examples:

a not good person  
yokunai hito

an uninteresting movie  
omoshirokunai eiga

not beautiful scenery  
utsukushikunai keshiki

the car I don’t want  
watashi no hoshikunai kuruma

the bag I don’t want to buy  
watashi no kaitakunai kaban

—

a not famous person  
yūmei janai hito

a not quiet person  
shizuka janai hito

a not strange place  
hen janai basho

the car I don’t like  
watashi no suki janai kuruma

the food I don't hate  
 watashi no kirai janai tabemono

Some of the phrases above probably sound strange in English, but in Japanese they are quite natural. In English, we sometimes change the sentence around a bit to express the above ideas in a more natural way. For example, we might put “not” somewhere closer to the verb in the sentence, rather than near the adjective, or we might use what’s known as a relative clause (eg. “scenery that is not beautiful”). In Japanese, simply placing the negative adjective before the noun like in the above examples is the most natural solution.

### Using negative adjectives to end sentences in informal speech

Just as i-adjectives can be used to end an informal sentence without using the word “da”, so too can negative adjectives. Here are some examples:

The sashimi is not bad  
 sashimi wa **warukunai**

This movie is uninteresting  
 kono eiga wa **omoshirokunai**

He's not famous  
 kare wa **yūmei janai**

That place isn't strange  
 ano basho wa **hen janai**

I don't like futons  
 (watashi wa) futon ga **suki janai**

Like before, there may not appear to be any verbs in these sentences, but they do exist as a part of the i-adjective formed by the negative ending.

### Converting negative adjectives to the past tense

To form the past tense of a negative adjective, the last “i” is replaced by “katta”. This means that for na-adjectives, “janai” becomes “janakatta”, and the “-kunai” ending of

i-adjectives becomes “-kunakatta”. The past tense of the above sentences in the informal (and polite) form would therefore be:

The sashimi was not bad  
sashimi wa **warukunakatta** (desu)

This movie was uninteresting  
kono eiga wa **omoshirokunakatta** (desu)

He was not famous  
kare wa **yūmei janakatta** (desu)

That place was not strange  
ano basho wa **hen janakatta** (desu)

I didn't like the futon  
(watashi wa) futon ga **suki janakatta** (desu)

## Exercise

1. Say and write down each of the following sentences in Japanese using the designated level of politeness. Note that the first three in particular are phrased in a way that is natural in Japanese, even if they seem odd in English.
  - a) [polite] He bought not delicious pizza
  - b) [informal] I want a not old TV
  - c) [polite] We went to a not famous town
  - d) [polite] They watched a movie I don't like
  - e) [informal] This house isn't clean
  - f) [informal] I don't like cheese
  - g) [informal] He isn't sad
  - h) [informal] Japanese isn't difficult
  - i) [informal] My car was not expensive
  - j) [informal] The test was not easy
  - k) [polite] She wasn't happy
  - l) [polite] It wasn't important

## Answers

1.

- a) kare wa oishikunai piza wo kaimashita
- b) (watashi wa) furukunai terebi ga hoshī
- c) watashi tachi wa yūmei janai machi ni ikimashita
- d) karera wa watashi no suki janai eiga wo mimashita
- e) kono ie wa kirei janai
- f) watashi wa chīzu ga suki janai
- g) kare wa kanashikunai
- h) nihongo wa muzukashikunai
- i) watashi no kuruma wa takakunakatta
- j) tesuto wa kantan janakatta
- k) kanojo wa ureshikunakatta desu
- l) taisetsu janakatta (the meaning of "it" is implied through context - see Chapter 3.6)

## 7.6 Informal questions using adjectives

As was explained in Chapter 4.5, you can convert any sentence into a yes/no question by simply adding "ka" after the verb. When speaking informally, however, questions are usually asked without "ka", making them no different in appearance to regular statements. Instead, a questioning tone is used to indicate that a question is being asked.

For example, if you were to ask someone if they were cold, the polite way to say this is, "samui desu ka". In informal speech, however, you would simply ask "samui?", using a tone that rises at the end. Normally, saying "samui" with a non-questioning tone would be the equivalent of saying "I'm cold", so the tone used in this case greatly affects the meaning of the sentence.

Thankfully, it is usually obvious when a question is being asked, and you will likely be able to instinctively use the correct tone of voice when asking informal questions, so there's no need to worry about this too much. It's just something to be aware of.

## 7.7 Adjective usage summary

The table below summarizes how i-adjectives and na-adjectives differ in terms of usage.

|                             | i-adjectives                           | na-adjectives                 |
|-----------------------------|----------------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| Before nouns                | Use as is (adj + noun)                 | Add “na” (adj + “na” + noun)  |
| End of informal sentences   | Use as is (without “desu”)             | Change “desu” to “da”         |
| Past tense                  |                                        |                               |
| - Polite                    | Replace last “i” with “katta” + “desu” | Change “desu” to “deshita”    |
| - Informal                  | Replace last “i” with “katta”          | Change “desu” to “datta”      |
| Negative                    | Replace last “i” with “kunai”          | Add “janai”                   |
| - Before nouns              | Use negative form as is                | Use negative form as is       |
| - End of informal sentences | Use negative form as is                | Use negative form as is       |
| - Past tense                | Change “kunai” to “kunakatta”          | Change “janai” to “janakatta” |

## 7.8 Using nouns in “to be” sentences

### New vocabulary

|                     |         |                   |            |
|---------------------|---------|-------------------|------------|
| birthday            | tanjōbi | doctor            | isha       |
| brothers / siblings | kyōdai  | national holiday  | shukujitsu |
| capital city        | shuto   | necklace          | nekuresu   |
| couple              | kappuru | salaried employee | sararīman  |
| dentist             | haisha  | tourist           | kankōkyaku |

Once you have mastered the different uses of adjectives, nouns are relatively straightforward. In sentences where the main verb is “to be”, nouns are treated much the same way as na-adjectives. This includes their use at the end of informal sentences, as well as in the past tense, the negative, and the negative past tense. Let’s look at some examples of each of these.

### At the end of informal sentences

When the last element in a sentence before the verb is a noun, and the verb is “to be”, we can turn a polite sentence into an informal one by changing “desu” to “da”.

This is a pen  
kore wa pen **da**

That is my mobile phone  
sore wa watashi no keitai **da**

He is a teacher  
kare wa sensei **da**

She is a fun person  
kanojo wa tanoshī hito **da**

### Past tense

Similarly, when used with a noun, “to be” can be turned into the past tense by changing “desu” to “deshita” in the polite form, or “datta” in the informal form.

Polite:  
She was a good student  
kanojo wa ī gakusei **deshita**

Until 1869, Kyoto was the capital of Japan  
1869 nen made, kyōto wa nihon no shuto **deshita**

Informal:  
Yesterday was my birthday  
kinō wa watashi no tanjōbi **datta**

That was my chocolate!  
sore wa watashi no chokorēto **datta** yo!

### Negative

The noun in a “to be” sentence can be made negative by adding “janai” after it. This can be made polite or informal by either including or excluding “desu”.

That is not my bag  
sore wa watashi no kaban **janai** (desu)

I am not a dentist  
watashi wa haisha **janai** (desu)

He is not a bad person  
kare wa warui hito **janai** (desu)

They are not a couple  
karera wa kappuru **janai** (desu)

### Negative past tense

To turn a negative “to be” sentence into the past tense, change “janai” into “janakatta”. Again, the inclusion or exclusion of “desu” determines the level of politeness.

That was not our bus  
are wa watashi tachi no basu **janakatta** (desu)

That man was not a doctor  
ano otoko wa isha **janakatta** (desu)

Last year was not a bad year  
kyonen wa warui ichinen **janakatta** (desu)

Yesterday was not my birthday  
kinō wa watashi no tanjōbi **janakatta** (desu)

### Exercise

1. Say and write down the following sentences in Japanese using the **polite** form:
  - a) Yesterday was Saturday
  - b) Last year, he was my teacher
  - c) That (over there) isn't a hospital
  - d) This isn't rain
  - e) That wasn't my coffee
  - f) It wasn't a party

2. Say and write down the following sentences in Japanese using the **informal** form:

- a) This is a beautiful necklace
- b) She is your older sister
- c) They are brothers
- d) Takamatsu-san is a salaried employee
- e) They were tourists
- f) He was a good student
- g) This isn't a window
- h) Today is not a national holiday
- i) That (over there) was not a monkey
- j) The shirt wasn't my size

## Answers

1.

- a) kinō wa doyōbi deshita
- b) kyonen, kare wa watashi no sensei deshita
- c) are wa byōin janai desu
- d) kore wa ame janai desu
- e) sore wa watashi no tabemono janakatta desu
- f) pāti janakatta desu

2.

- a) kore wa utsukushī nekuresu da
- b) kanojo wa anata no onēsan da
- c) karera wa kyōdai da
- d) takamatsu-san wa sararīman da
- e) karera wa kankōkyaku datta
- f) kare wa i gakusei datta
- g) kore wa mado janai
- h) kyō wa shukujitsu janai
- i) are wa saru janakatta
- j) shatsu wa watashi no saizu janakatta

## 7.9 Adverbs

### New vocabulary

|                           |              |           |             |
|---------------------------|--------------|-----------|-------------|
| airport                   | kūkō         | not very  | amari       |
| to dance                  | odorimasu    | often     | yoku        |
| extremely (Kansai region) | meccha       | quite     | kanari      |
| extremely (Kanto region)  | chō          | to run    | hashirimasu |
| more, much, much more     | motto        | teacher   | sensei      |
| museum                    | hakubutsukan | workplace | shokuba     |

Adverbs are words like “quickly”, “always” and “very” that are used to add meaning to verbs, adjectives and other adverbs. They are kind of like adjectives that can be used where adjectives can’t, since adjectives can only be used with nouns. Most adverbs even derive from adjectives, and in Japanese, converting an adjective into an adverb is very easy. Here’s how it’s done:

| Adjective type | Conversion to adverb        | Example         |                           |
|----------------|-----------------------------|-----------------|---------------------------|
| i-adjective    | Change the last “i” to “ku” | quick → quickly | hayai → hayaku            |
| na-adjective   | Remove “na” and add “ni”    | quiet → quietly | shizuka (na) → shizuka ni |

These simple conversions are all you need to know in order to use the vast majority of adverbs in Japanese. However, in addition to those that derive from adjectives, there are also a number of adverbs that are standalone words. Here are some of the most useful ones, many of which we have seen before:

|                       |                            |
|-----------------------|----------------------------|
| a lot, many           | takusan                    |
| always                | itsumo                     |
| a little bit          | chotto                     |
| more, much, much more | motto                      |
| never, not at all     | zenzen                     |
| quite                 | kanari                     |
| sometimes             | tokidoki                   |
| very                  | totemo                     |
| not very              | amari (with negative verb) |

You may notice that a few of these are time-related words that were covered in Chapter 6. These are in fact adverbs, and they can be used in the same way that adverbs are. The same is true for many other time-related expressions. This helps explain why the particle used with some time expressions is “ni”, as that is what is used to turn na-adjectives into adverbs.

Also, when the word “i” is converted to its adverb form “yoku”, in addition to meaning “well”, it can also be used to mean “often”.

## Using adverbs

Not all adverbs are as versatile as others. Some, like the word “motto”, meaning “more”, can be used with all three word types - verbs, adjectives and other adverbs - while others, like “quickly”, can only be used with verbs. Although this may sound confusing, there is no need to concern yourself with remembering which adverbs can be used with which word types. Generally, the only reason a given adverb might not work with a certain word type is because it doesn’t make literal sense. For example, “very” cannot be used with verbs, but you are unlikely to mistakenly use it with a verb because it makes no sense to say something like, “He very slept”. Adverbs in Japanese are the same.

That said, the placement of an adverb is affected by the type of word it is modifying. Let’s take a look.

## Modifying verbs

If an adverb is modifying a verb, it can be placed basically anywhere in the sentence, as long as it comes *before* the verb that it relates to. It also will not usually be placed before the topic-defining particle “wa”. Here are some examples:

He **quickly** ran to school / He ran to school **quickly**

kare wa **hayaku** gakkō ni hashirimashita

kare wa gakkō ni **hayaku** hashirimashita

She **quietly** opened the door / She opened the door **quietly**

kanojo wa **shizuka ni** doa wo akemashita

kanojo wa doa wo **shizuka ni** akemashita

The placement of the adverb doesn’t really affect the meaning of the sentence, although since words that appear later in Japanese sentences generally carry more weight, the adverb will be emphasized more when placed immediately before the verb it modifies.

### Modifying adjectives and adverbs

When an adverb is used to modify something other than a verb - that is, an adjective or another adverb - its possible placement is much more restricted. In almost all cases, such adverbs should be placed immediately before the adjective or adverb that they relate to. Here are some examples, with the adverb in bold and the word it modifies underlined:

[Adjective]

This bag is **quite** light

kono kaban wa **kanari** karui desu

[Adverb]

He **very** quickly ran to school / He ran to school **very** quickly

kare wa **totemo** hayaku gakkō ni hashirimashita

kare wa gakkō ni **totemo** hayaku hashirimashita

Since adjectives and adverbs are descriptive words, adverbs that are used to modify them usually specify the degree of the description. For this reason, there are relatively few adverbs that can be used with adjectives and adverbs compared to those that can be used to modify verbs.

### Exercise

1. Say aloud and write down each of these sentences in polite Japanese.
  - a) They danced cutely
  - b) He often goes to the cinema
  - c) She waited quietly in front of the library
  - d) My car was a little bit expensive
  - e) This museum is quite interesting
  - f) I want to go to the airport much earlier

### Answers

1.

- a) karera wa kawaiku odorimashita
- b) kare wa yoku eigakan ni ikimasu

- c) kanojo wa eigakan no mae de shizuka ni machimashita, OR  
kanojo wa shizuka ni eigakan no mae de machimashita
- d) watashi no kuruma wa chotto takakatta desu
- e) kono hakubutsukan wa kanari omoshiroi desu
- f) motto hayaku kūkō ni ikitai desu

## Saying “very”

The most common adverb used with adjectives and other adverbs is, of course, “very”. In Japanese, however, there are two words that mean “very” - one that is used with positive statements, and one that is used with negative ones, which is like saying “not very”. Here are the words for “very” and “not very” in Japanese:

| English  | Japanese | Example      |                 |
|----------|----------|--------------|-----------------|
| very     | totemo   | very hot     | totemo atsui    |
| not very | amari    | not very hot | amari atsukunai |

The important thing to remember here is that “totemo” is used with adjectives in their **positive** form, while “amari” must be used with adjectives in the **negative** form. As explained above, these are usually placed immediately before the adjective or adverb that they affect.

Also, when these are used with the words “suki”, “kirai”, hoshī“ and “-tai”, a better English translation than “very” would be “really”, since this is what we would use with the words “like”, “hate”, and “want” in English. This is simply because these words are adjectives in Japanese, but verbs in English, and the English word “very” cannot be used directly with verbs (eg. “He very likes sushi”). In terms of actual meaning, they are the same. Here are some examples:

He really hates sushi  
kare wa sushi ga totemo kirai desu

I really want to play basketball  
(watashi wa) basuke ga totemo shitai desu

She doesn’t really like vegetables  
kanojo wa yasai ga amari suki janai desu

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For example, it is normal to say “I live in Japan” for the present, or “I lived in Japan” for the past, even though the act of “living” in Japan is, or was, in progress. It is possible to use the continuous tense and say, “I am/was living in Japan”, but this doesn’t have quite the same meaning, and isn’t the standard way of expressing this basic idea in English.

However, actions that are represented by non-continuous verbs in English are usually expressed using continuous tenses in Japanese. The phrase, “I live in Japan”, in Japanese would be, “watashi wa nihon ni **sunde iru**”. To directly translate English and use the present/future tense to say, “watashi wa nihon ni sumimasu”, would instead refer to future plans to live in Japan, not the current situation.

Here are some other verbs that fall into this category, along with example sentences in a mixture of polite and informal speech.

| English verb    | English example                         | Japanese verb | Japanese example                                   |
|-----------------|-----------------------------------------|---------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| to love         | I <b>love</b> you                       | ai suru       | (watashi wa anata wo)<br><b>ai shite iru</b>       |
| to work         | He <b>works</b> at the post office      | hataraku      | kare wa yūbinkyoku de<br><b>hataraitte imasu</b>   |
| to own/have     | I <b>have</b> a blue motorbike          | motsu         | (watashi wa) aoi baiku wo<br><b>motte iru</b>      |
| to have (a pet) | She <b>has</b> 3 dogs                   | kau*          | kanojo wa inu wo sanbiki<br><b>katte iru</b>       |
| to belong       | They <b>belong</b> to the HR department | shozoku suru  | karera wa jinjibu ni<br><b>shozoku shite imasu</b> |

\* The verb “kau”, meaning “to have (a pet)”, looks the same as the word for “buy”, but it is a different word that uses a different kanji when written in Japanese.

Ultimately, the key to using this correctly is to avoid translating from English, and instead think about whether or not the action is of an ongoing nature. For all verbs in Japanese, if the action began at some point in the past, and has not yet finished, then the present continuous tense should be used.

### Exercise

1. Say aloud and write down each of the following sentences in informal Japanese:
  - a) She is writing a book

- b) Taro is reading the newspaper
  - c) I was sleeping on the sofa
  - d) He was using the company's computer
  - e) You're not listening to me
  - f) They're not speaking (in) English
  - g) He wasn't waiting at the station
  - h) Miho wasn't watching
  - i) She has a big dog
  - j) He doesn't love her
2. Think of 5 things that other people are doing right now and describe them using polite Japanese. Try to include information about where each person is doing that activity.

## Answers

- 1.
- a) kanojo wa hon wo kaite iru
  - b) Tarō wa shinbun wo yonde iru
  - c) (watashi wa) sofa de nete ita
  - d) kare wa kaisha no konpyūtā wo tsukatte ita
  - e) anata wa watashi wo kīte inai
  - f) karera wa eigo de hanashite inai
  - g) kare wa eki de matte inakatta
  - h) Miho wa mite inakatta
  - i) kanojo wa ōkī inu wo katte iru
  - j) kare wa kanojo wo ai shite inai
2. Each sentence should include (where possible) the location marked by the particle “de” (or “ni” if describing a destination and an action involving movement like “go” or “visit”), and the verb in the te-form followed by “imasu”.

## 9.3 Commands and requests

### New vocabulary

|                            |             |
|----------------------------|-------------|
| a bit                      | chotto      |
| article                    | kiji        |
| to do ones best, work hard | ganbaru     |
| to hurry                   | isogu       |
| phone number               | denwa bangō |

Another very common use of the te-form is in commanding and requesting people to perform actions, such as, “Come here!”, or “Come here, please”. To do this, simply end the sentence with the verb in the te-form for a command, or add “kudasai” (please) to soften it and make it a request instead. There is usually no topic or subject in these types of sentences because commands and requests, by their very nature, are usually directed at the person being spoken to, hence the person who should perform the action is obvious.

Here are some example sentences:

Look at this!  
kore wo **mite**

Hurry up!  
**isoide**

Come here  
koko ni **kite**

Do your best/Good luck  
**ganbatte**

Please take off your shoes  
kutsu wo **nuide kudasai**

Please wait  
**matte kudasai**

Please wait a bit  
chotto **matte kudasai**

### **Ganbatte!**

The word “ganbatte” is worth mentioning because it is very common, yet there isn’t really an equivalent word in English. It is the te-form of the verb “ganbaru”, which means something like “to do your best”, or “to work hard”. Japanese people are often told that the English translation is “to fight”, and for this reason you might occasionally hear them chanting or yelling “fai-to!” at sporting events.

In any case, “ganbatte” is usually said to a person as a form of encouragement before or during something challenging, such as a competition, an exam, or even just everyday work. Since it is often said before the event, it is sometimes translated to English as “Good luck”, although “Do your best” or “Work hard” is usually more appropriate, since effort, not luck, is what is being encouraged. In its regular form, “ganbaru” or “ganbarimasu” is often said by a person about to take on a challenge, as if to say, “I will do my best”.

A common alternative way to soften commands in colloquial speech that allows you to avoid the formality of the word “kudasai” is to add “ne” after the te-form verb. For example, “chotto matte ne” would be a casual way of saying “wait a second”, while “ganbatte ne” is a more relaxed way to encourage someone. You will likely hear this a lot, but remember that it should only be used in informal settings, or when the person speaking is of a higher standing than the person being spoken to.

### **Exercise**

1. Say aloud and write down each of the following sentences in Japanese:
  - a) Wake up!
  - b) Please return home by 6 o’clock
  - c) Read this article

- d) Please tell (teach) me your phone number
- e) Close the door!
- f) Please speak in Japanese
- g) Wash your hands over there
- h) Please gather in the library at 3 o'clock

## Answers

1.

- a) okite!
- b) rokuji made ni (ie ni) kaette kudasai
- c) kono kiji wo yonde
- d) denwa bangō wo oshiete kudasai
- e) doa wo shimete!
- f) nihongo de hanashite kudasai
- g) asoko de te wo aratte
- h) sanji ni toshokan de atsumatte kudasai

## 9.4 Linking multiple actions together in a sequence

### New vocabulary

|                           |            |
|---------------------------|------------|
| bullet train              | shinkansen |
| Chinese (language)        | chūgokugo  |
| to go for a walk          | sanpo suru |
| head                      | atama      |
| to hit, bump (transitive) | butsukeru  |

|                              |        |
|------------------------------|--------|
| to quit                      | yameru |
| to sell                      | uru    |
| to stand up                  | tatsu  |
| the world                    | sekai  |
| to wear, put on (lower body) | haku   |

We can use the te-form to talk about multiple actions that take place together or in a sequence. When describing multiple actions together, the te-form is used for all of the verbs except the last one. The tense used for the last verb then applies to all of the preceding verbs that appeared in the te-form. There is no limit to the number of actions that can be linked together, and this can be done in virtually any tense, as long as it makes logical sense. Here are some examples:

He went to the convenience store and bought a sandwich  
kare wa konbini ni **itte** sandoicchi wo kaimashita

This morning, I woke up, ate breakfast and cleaned my teeth  
kesa, watashi wa **okite**, asagohan wo **tabete**, ha wo migakimashita

I want to go to Japan and ride the bullet train  
(watashi wa) nihon ni **itte** shinkansen ni noritai desu

When the actions occurring together happen in a sequence, we can further emphasize the order of the different actions by including the particle “kara” after the te-form of the verb. This is like saying “and then” or “before”, as shown in the examples below. Just be aware that this shouldn’t be used too many times in one sentence or it becomes repetitive.

I went to the library and then I went to school  
(watashi wa) toshokan ni **itte kara** gakkō ni ikimashita

Please take your shoes off before going (entering) inside  
kutsu wo **nuide kara** naka ni haitte kudasai

It is also possible to link sentences together when the verb is “desu”, albeit in a fairly limited way. The te-form of “desu” is “de”, and this can be added after a noun in place of “desu” to allow one sentence to lead into another. Unlike other verbs, however, this does not describe actions occurring in a sequence because “desu” only describes the state of being, not an actual action. Here are some examples of “de” being used in place of “desu” to link two sentences together.

This is a pen, and that is a pencil  
kore wa pen **de**, sore wa enpitsu desu

Today is fine (weather), and it will rain tomorrow  
kyō wa hare **de**, ashita ame ga furimasu

## Exercise

1. Say aloud and write down each of the following sentences in informal or polite Japanese, as indicated:
  - a) [Informal] He stood up and hit his head
  - b) [Polite] She put on shoes and went to the mall
  - c) [Informal] We ate dinner and watched a movie, then went for a walk in the park
  - d) [Polite] Next year, I will go to China and study Chinese
  - e) [Informal] Tomorrow, we will go to Akihabara and buy a new TV
  - f) [Informal] They're eating yakiniku and drinking beer
  - g) [Polite] I want to sell my car and buy a motorbike
  - h) [Polite] I want to quit my job and travel the world
  - i) [Polite] Let's go to Shinjuku and do karaoke
  - j) [Informal] Let's return home and go to sleep
  - k) [Polite] This is my car, and that (over there) is his motorbike

## Answers

1.
  - a) kare wa tatte atama wo butsuketa
  - b) kanojo wa kutsu wo haite mōru in ikimashita
  - c) (watashi tachi wa) bangohan wo tabete eiga wo mite kara, kōen de sanpo shita
  - d) rainen (watashi wa) chūgoku ni itte chūgokugo wo benkyō shimasu
  - e) ashita, (watashi tachi wa) akihabara ni itte atarashī terebi wo kau
  - f) karera wa yakiniku wo tabete bīru wo nonde iru
  - g) (watashi wa) kuruma wo utte baiku ga kaitai desu
  - h) (watashi wa) shigoto wo yamete sekai ga ryokō shitai desu
  - i) shinjuku ni itte karaoke wo shimashō
  - j) ie ni kaette neyō
  - k) kore wa watashi no kuruma de, are wa kare no baiku desu

## 9.5 Describing the means by which an action is completed

### New vocabulary

|                |           |
|----------------|-----------|
| to be late     | okureru   |
| candy, sweets  | okashi    |
| to do exercise | undō suru |
| island         | shima     |
| to kick        | keru      |
| to lose weight | yaseru    |

|                           |             |
|---------------------------|-------------|
| to oversleep, sleep in    | nebō suru   |
| to pass (a test)          | gōkaku suru |
| to put on weight, get fat | futoru      |
| rich                      | okanemochi  |
| sick                      | byōki       |

Similarly to how we can link actions together that occur in a sequence, we can also link actions together to imply that one action enabled another to occur, or to describe the means by which an action takes place. In other words, it can be used to show cause and effect, much like saying “I did A by doing B” or “I did A and B happened”. Here are some examples:

He opened the door by kicking it  
kare wa doa wo **kette** akemashita

They became rich by selling cameras  
karera wa kamera wo **utte** okanemochi ni narimashita

She lost weight by exercising every day  
kanojo wa mainichi **undō shite** yasemashita

I ate lots of candy and became sick  
okashi wo takusan **tabete** byōki ni narimashita

In each of these examples, you can see that the first action leads directly to the second action, either as the means by which it occurs (eg. kicking the door open), or as its cause (eg. becoming sick due to eating lots of candy).

You’ll no doubt notice that these sentences appear exactly the same as those in the previous section that showed actions in a sequence. The truth is, both instances describe

actions that occur together or in a sequence; the difference just comes down to the interpretation of the effect of one action on the other.

In Chapter 2, we learned about the particle “de”, and how it is used to define either the location where an action takes place, or the means by which an action is completed. In many ways, the te-form is like the verb version of the particle “de”. They cannot always be used in the same ways, but if you think of the particle “de” as describing the means by which an action takes place, then using a verb in the te-form has the same effect. The only difference is that the means is in the form of a verb, not a noun.

One very common way in which verbs are used together like this is when describing the mode of transportation in the form of a verb. Rather than just saying something like, “I walked to the park”, in Japanese, the verb describing the movement, such as “go” or “come” is usually included as well. The following examples demonstrate this:

I walked to the park  
(watashi wa) kōen ni **aruite** ikimashita

He ran here  
kare wa koko ni **hashitte** kimashita

She rode her bike to school  
kanojo wa gakkō ni jitensha ni **notte** ikimashita

One way in which the te-form is very similar to the particle “de” is that it makes the word order more flexible. Normally, the verb comes at the end of a sentence or clause, but when a verb is in the te-form and used to describe the means by which an action occurs, it is no longer the main verb, and can therefore be moved around like a “noun + de” combination. Here are the above example sentences again with the word order rearranged:

I walked to the park  
(watashi wa) **aruite** kōen ni ikimashita

He ran here  
kare wa **hashitte** koko ni kimashita

She rode her bike to school  
kanojo wa jitensha ni **notte** gakkō ni ikimashita

In all of these examples, the verb in the te-form has been moved closer to the beginning of the sentence, just like might be done with the particle “de”. If we compare the first example to similar sentences where the means of transport is a car, you can see how similar the te-form of verbs is to the particle “de”:

**kuruma de** kōen ni ikimashita  
**aruite** kōen ni ikimashita  
kōen ni **kuruma de** ikimashita  
kōen ni **aruite** ikimashita

As mentioned above, this doesn’t mean that you can always use “de” and the te-form of verbs in the same way. For example, since nouns don’t represent an action, you can’t use a noun with “de” to form a command or a continuous tense, so while it’s fine to say “hashitte kudasai” to ask someone to run, you can’t say “kuruma de kudasai” to tell someone to travel by car; the latter still needs a verb. Because of this, it is somewhat inaccurate to think of “de” and the te-form as being perfectly equal. However, being aware of their similarities should hopefully help you when forming sentences that use the te-form to describe the means by which actions take place.

## Exercise

1. Say aloud and write down each of the following sentences in informal or polite Japanese, as indicated:
  - a) [Polite] I overslept and was late to the meeting
  - b) [Informal] He gained weight by eating cake every day
  - c) [Polite] She broke her computer by dropping it
  - d) [Informal] He took his jacket off and became cold
  - e) [Polite] I will study lots and pass the test
  - f) [Informal] I drank a lot of coffee and (now I) can’t sleep
  - g) [Polite] They ran to the post office
  - h) [Informal] I want to swim to that island over there

## Answers

1.

- a) watashi wa nebōshite kaigi ni okuremashita
- b) kare wa mainichi kēki wo tabete futotta
- c) kanojo wa konpyūta wo otoshite kowashimashita
- d) kare wa uwagi wo nuide samuku natta
- e) (watashi wa) takusan benkyō shite tesuto ni gōkaku shimasu
- f) kōhī wo takusan nonde nerarenai
- g) karera wa yūbinkyoku ni hashitte ikimashita, OR  
karera wa hashitte yūbinkyoku ni ikimashita
- h) ano shima ni oyoide ikitai, OR  
oyoide ano shima ni ikitai

## 9.6 The negative te-form

### New vocabulary

|                                                        |            |
|--------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| to apply, put on (liquids such as creams, paints etc.) | nuru       |
| to forget                                              | wasureru   |
| to sit                                                 | suwaru     |
| sunscreen                                              | hiyakedome |
| to wear, put on (upper body)                           | kiru       |

Verbs in the negative can also be expressed in the te-form. Although the transformation is easy, there are actually two versions of the te-form for negatives, and each have different uses. To keep things simple and avoid confusion, we will only look at one for now - the one that relates most to the te-form uses introduced in this chapter. The other will be explained in Chapter 12.3.1.

To form the first version of the negative te-form of a verb, we just add “de” to the end of the verb in its negative informal tense. The verb ending therefore becomes “naide”, such as in the following examples:

| Verb   | Negative | Negative te-form |
|--------|----------|------------------|
| suru   | shinai   | shinaide         |
| miru   | minai    | minaide          |
| iku    | ikanai   | ikanaide         |
| taberu | tabenai  | tabenaide        |

This version of the negative te-form has two main uses:

- In commands and requests in the negative, eg. Please don't go over there
- To describe actions that didn't (or will not) happen when linking actions together in a sequence, eg. He didn't eat before going to school

Note that the negative te-form is not used with continuous tenses. As explained earlier, to describe something that is not happening, the verb should be used in the regular te-form, with the verb “iru” expressed in the negative. For example, to say “He is not watching TV”, you would say “kare wa terebi wo mite inai”. Much like English, there only needs to be one verb in the negative form to make the whole clause negative, and with continuous tenses, that verb should be “iru”.

Here are some examples of the negative te-form in action:

Don't watch TV!  
terebi wo **minaide**!

Please don't close the door  
doa wo **shimenaide** kudasai

He didn't eat breakfast before going to school  
kare wa asagohan wo **tabenaide** gakkō ni ikimashita

She went to the beach without putting on sunscreen  
kanojo wa hiyakedome wo **nuranaide** umi ni ikimashita

## Exercise

1. Say aloud and write down each of the following sentences in polite Japanese:
  - a) Don't wear that shirt

- b) Don't give chocolate to the dog
- c) Please don't forget your jacket
- d) Please don't sit on this chair
- e) He rode his bicycle without wearing shoes
- f) She didn't wash her hands before eating pizza
- g) I went to bed (slept) without cleaning my teeth
- h) They didn't make a reservation before going to the restaurant

## Answers

1.

- a) sono shatsu wo kinaide
- b) inu ni chokorēto wo agenaide
- c) uwagi wo wasurenaide kudasai
- d) kono isu ni suwaranaide kudasai
- e) kare wa kutsu wo hakanaide jitensha ni norimashita
- f) kanojo wa te wo arawanaide piza wo tabemashita
- g) (watashi wa) ha wo migakanaide nemashita
- h) karera wa yoyaku shinaide resutoran ni ikimashita

## 9.7 The te-form of adjectives

### New vocabulary

|       |            |
|-------|------------|
| dark  | kurai      |
| dirty | kitanai    |
| leg   | ashi       |
| pink  | pinku (na) |

|        |        |
|--------|--------|
| sign   | kanban |
| small  | chīsai |
| smelly | kusai  |

As we learned in Chapter 7, Japanese adjectives are different from English adjectives in one major way - they can be conjugated into different tenses. With that in mind, you probably won't be surprised to learn that adjectives also have a te-form.

Converting adjectives into the te-form is easy. For i-adjectives, we remove the last "i" sound and replace it with "kute". For na-adjectives, we just add "de" on the end instead of "na".

| Adjective type | Te-form                 | Example          |
|----------------|-------------------------|------------------|
| i-adjective    | Remove “i”, add “kute”  | atsui → atsukute |
| na-adjective   | Add “de” (without “na”) | kirei → kirei de |

The i-adjective conversion applies to all types of words that have been converted into a form that is the same as i-adjectives, such as verbs in the “I want to...” form with the “-tai” ending (eg. ikitakute), and negative adjectives ending in “nai” (eg. yokunakute).

Like with verbs, the te-form of adjectives has a number of uses. Two of the main uses of the te-form of adjectives are:

- To apply multiple descriptions to something, eg. The **big, red** dog
- To describe a reason for something, eg. I can’t eat this **because it’s hot**

Let’s take a closer look at each of these.

## Applying multiple descriptions

Multiple adjectives can be strung together in a sentence by expressing all but the last adjective using the te-form. The following example sentences demonstrate this:

That dog (over there) is big and scary  
ano inu wa **ōkikute kowai** desu

Japanese is easy and interesting  
nihongo wa **kantan de omoshiroi** desu

The small, black cat is under the table  
**chīsakute kuroi** neko wa tēburu no shita ni imasu

Note that when doing this, the natural-sounding order of the adjectives won’t always be the same as English. For example, some people may express the last example by saying “kurokute chīsai neko”, or “black, small cat”. This sounds less natural in English because we usually use adjectives of size before colors, not after, but the same isn’t always true in Japanese. This is not really worth worrying about because ultimately, no matter what word order you use, if the words are correct, then the meaning will be understood. Just be aware that the order may differ from English, and as you hear and speak Japanese more, you will develop an intuitive understanding of what sounds most natural.

## Describing a reason

Adjectives can be used in the te-form to describe a reason for something. When this is done, the meaning of the sentence is much like an English sentence that includes “because”. As with other “because”-type sentences, the order of the reason and the outcome is the opposite of how it is usually expressed in English. When using the word “because” in English, it is normal to express the outcome first, followed by “because” and then the reason. In Japanese, however, the reason comes first (in the te-form), and the outcome comes after. The example sentences below, which use an adjective as a reason, should help clarify this.

I can't walk because my leg hurts  
ashi ga **itakute** arukenai

I won't buy these shoes because they're expensive  
kono kutsu wa **takakute** kawanai

I couldn't see the sign because it was dark  
**kurakute** kanban ga mienakatta

I don't want to carry this bag because it's heavy  
kono kaban wa **omokute** mochitakunai

Notice that in each of these, the reason comes first, followed by the outcome. This is generally how outcomes and their reasons, of all types, are expressed in Japanese. We can, however, re-phrase these expressions using the English word “so” in order to match the word order to the Japanese sentence while still expressing the same basic idea. Here are the English sentences re-phrased:

My leg hurts so I can't walk  
These shoes are expensive so I won't buy them  
It was dark so I couldn't see the sign  
This bag is heavy so I don't want to carry it

## Exercise

1. Complete the following table:

| Adjective in English | Standard form | Te-form       | Negative te-form |
|----------------------|---------------|---------------|------------------|
| good                 | ī / yoi       |               | yokunakute       |
| bad                  | warui         | warukute      |                  |
| happy                | ureshī        |               | ureshikunakute   |
| sad                  | kanashī       | kanashikute   |                  |
| hot                  | atsui         |               | atsukunakute     |
| cold                 | samui         | samukute      |                  |
| interesting          | omoshiroi     |               | omoshirokunakute |
| boring               | tsumaranai    | tsumaranakute |                  |
| old                  | furui         |               | furukunakute     |
| new                  | atarashī      | atarashikute  |                  |
| want                 | hoshī         |               | hoshikunakute    |
| I want to...         | -tai          | -takute       |                  |
| well/spirited        | genki (na)    |               | genki janakute   |
| strange              | hen (na)      | hen de        |                  |
| easy                 | kantan (na)   |               | kantan janakute  |
| quiet                | shizuka (na)  | shizuka de    |                  |
| convenient           | benri (na)    |               | benri janakute   |
| famous               | yūmei (na)    | yūmei de      |                  |
| like                 | suki (na)     |               | suki janakute    |
| hate                 | kirai (na)    | kirai de      |                  |

2. Say aloud and write down each of the following sentences in polite Japanese:

- a) She bought a pink, cute bag
- b) They entered the dark, scary house
- c) Your shoes are dirty and smelly
- d) This is my new, expensive watch
- e) I ate lots of sushi because it was delicious
- f) I quit my job because I want to travel
- g) I don't want to watch this movie because it's boring
- h) He goes to that shop every day because it is convenient

## Answers

1.

| Adjective in English | Standard form | Te-form             | Negative te-form         |
|----------------------|---------------|---------------------|--------------------------|
| good                 | ī / yoi       | <b>yokute</b>       | yokunakute               |
| bad                  | warui         | warukute            | <b>warukunakute</b>      |
| happy                | ureshī        | <b>ureshikute</b>   | ureshikunakute           |
| sad                  | kanashī       | kanashikute         | <b>kanashikunakute</b>   |
| hot                  | atsui         | <b>atsukute</b>     | atsukunakute             |
| cold                 | samui         | samukute            | <b>samukunakute</b>      |
| interesting          | omoshiroi     | <b>omoshirokute</b> | omoshirokunakute         |
| boring               | tsumaranai    | tsumaranakute       | <b>tsumaranakunakute</b> |
| old                  | furui         | <b>furukute</b>     | furukunakute             |
| new                  | atarashī      | atarashikute        | <b>atarashikunakute</b>  |
| want                 | hoshī         | <b>hoshikute</b>    | hoshikunakute            |
| I want to...         | -tai          | -takute             | <b>-takunakute</b>       |
| well/spirited        | genki (na)    | <b>genki de</b>     | genki janakute           |
| strange              | hen (na)      | hen de              | <b>hen janakute</b>      |
| easy                 | kantan (na)   | <b>kantan de</b>    | kantan janakute          |
| quiet                | shizuka (na)  | shizuka de          | <b>shizuka janakute</b>  |
| convenient           | benri (na)    | <b>benri de</b>     | benri janakute           |
| famous               | yūmei (na)    | yūmei de            | <b>yūmei janakute</b>    |
| like                 | suki (na)     | <b>suki de</b>      | suki janakute            |
| hate                 | kirai (na)    | kirai de            | <b>kirai janakute</b>    |

2.

- a) kanojo wa pinku de kawai kaban wo kaimashita
- b) karera wa kurakute kowai ie ni hairimashita
- c) anata no kutsu wa kitanakute kusai desu
- d) kore wa watashi no atarashikute takai tokei desu
- e) sushi wa/ga oishikute (watashi wa) takusan tabemashita
- f) (watashi wa) ryokō shitakute shigoto wo yamemashita
- g) kono eiga wa/ga tsumaranakute (watashi wa) mitakunai desu
- h) ano mise wa benri de (kare wa) mainichi ikimasu



## Chapter 10

# The Magic of Noun Phrases

This chapter is where we really take things to the next level. You probably haven't heard of noun phrases before, but they are an essential part of any language, and complex noun phrases allow us to communicate with much more detail. In this chapter, we'll look at what noun phrases are, how they fit into sentences, and also cover a number of ways that noun phrases can be formed in Japanese. Once you understand everything in this chapter, you will have the foundations to understand almost anything the Japanese language will throw at you.

### 10.1 What are noun phrases?

As you know, nouns are words that represent things, whether they be physical or abstract. A noun phrase is just a sequence of words that together, as a whole, represent things in the same way that a single noun does. They are phrases that act as nouns grammatically.

The following are all noun phrases:

- car
- a car
- a blue car

- the blue car over there
- the blue car over there that's being washed by the guy wearing the red hat

These are all noun phrases because they all represent a thing - a car. "Car", in this case, is what is known as the **head noun**, and the only difference between each example is the amount of additional detail that is attached to this head noun. All of them can be used as a single block to fit into a sentence in exactly the same way as a plain old noun. Let's try it.

- I bought a car last week
- I bought a blue car last week
- I bought the blue car over there last week
- I bought the blue car over there that's being washed by the guy wearing the red hat last week

What this means is that if we know how to form noun phrases, we can add a lot more detail to our sentences. It allows us to include more information about every single noun, and then just slot that into a sentence without changing anything else. As the examples above show, it doesn't matter if we're just talking about "a car", or "the blue car over there that's being washed by the guy wearing the red hat", as long as we are using a noun phrase, we can insert it into a sentence in exactly the same way.

We have actually used some noun phrases in Japanese already, albeit very simple ones. Technically, a noun on its own is a noun phrase, but we have also created larger noun phrases when we joined two nouns together with "no" to say things like "watashi no kuruma" (my car). The same is true when we use an adjective (or two) before a noun, like when we say "aoi kuruma" (blue car). We can also combine these two to say, "watashi no aoi kuruma" (my blue car), and this also constitutes a single noun phrase.

There are, however, more ways to form noun phrases. Below are the main ones covered in this book:

- Determiner only - "This is my car"
- Adjective that describes a 'thing' - "This is a blue car"
- Verb that adds extra information - "This is the car that I bought"
- Verb as the action itself - "I saw him buying a car"
- Location preposition - "The car over there is blue"

We've already covered the first two, and you should have no problems using them in sentences. For the rest of this chapter, we will focus on the other three ways listed above, which will greatly increase the depth of expression you're capable of in Japanese.

## 10.2 Forming noun phrases using verbs that add extra information

### New vocabulary

|                         |            |
|-------------------------|------------|
| colleagues              | dōryō      |
| Japanese bar/restaurant | izakaya    |
| people                  | hito tachi |
| reason                  | riyū       |
| sake, alcohol           | osake      |

Using verbs to create noun phrases is particularly powerful because by combining verbs with nouns, we can actually turn almost complete sentences into noun phrases. These in turn can then be inserted into other, longer sentences like any other noun or noun phrase. Consider this example:

He bought some bread at the supermarket.

If we want to talk more about the bread in this sentence, without starting a new sentence, we can convert the entire sentence into a noun phrase built around the word “bread”, and then use that noun phrase as part of a longer sentence. The above sentence converted into a noun phrase looks like this:

The **bread** (that) he bought at the supermarket

As you can see here, by taking a complete sentence and rearranging it a little, we can turn it into a noun phrase. This can then be inserted into a longer sentence like so:

I like the bread (that) he bought at the supermarket.

In Japanese, turning a basic sentence into a noun phrase is relatively easy. Here's the original sentence again with a Japanese translation using polite language:

He bought some bread at the supermarket  
kare wa sūpā de pan wo kaimashita

Now, this is what the equivalent noun phrase looks like:

The bread (that) he bought at the supermarket  
kare ga sūpā de katta **pan**

To create this noun phrase, we have altered the original sentence in three ways:

- Put the head noun (pan) at the end, after the verb
- Changed the verb into the informal form (katta)
- Changed the particle “wa” to “ga”

Here is a quick explanation of each of these changes:

### **Putting the head noun at the end**

For any noun phrase, the head noun - the thing that we're talking about - is the last word in the noun phrase. This is always true, regardless of how many other words or what type of elements are included in the phrase. Even when using adjectives or other nouns, the head noun comes last. For example, if talking about a car, whether we say “aoi kuruma”, “watashi no kuruma”, “watashi no aoi kuruma”, or “kare ga katta kuruma”, the head noun, “kuruma”, always comes at the end.

### **Changing the verb into the informal form**

Except in rare, overly polite cases where the verb might remain in a polite tense, a verb in a noun phrase is always expressed in the informal form of whatever tense is being used. This does not, however, make the noun phrase informal. Any verbs that appear within a noun phrase are not the main verb of the sentence and are there for purely functional reasons, so politeness is not an issue. Instead, the politeness of a sentence is dependent mostly on the main verb at the end of the sentence. As long as the main verb in each clause is polite, the whole sentence will be polite too.

### Changing the particle from “wa” to “ga”

Not all noun phrases will contain these particles, but when they do, “ga” should always be used. The reason for this is that the particle “wa” defines the topic of a sentence, but a noun phrase alone is not enough to form a complete sentence. If something is not a complete sentence, it cannot have a topic, and “wa” should not be used. Since a noun phrase is not a complete sentence, “ga” should be used instead.

—

We can now put this into a sentence as if it were any other noun:

I like the bread that he bought at the supermarket  
 watashi wa **kare ga sūpā de katta pan** ga suki desu

The bread that he bought at the supermarket is over there  
**kare ga sūpā de katta pan** wa asoko ni arimasu

We ate the bread that he bought at the supermarket  
 watashi tachi wa **kare ga sūpā de katta pan** wo tabemashita

As you can see here, the noun phrase can be treated as a single block, and just be followed by whichever particle is appropriate within that sentence. As mentioned above, the fact that we use the informal form of the verb inside the noun phrase does not affect the overall politeness of the sentence. The main verb - the one at the end - determines how polite a sentence is, so all of the above examples are in the polite form.

### Using different head nouns

In our example above, we took a basic sentence, extracted the word “bread”, and built a noun phrase around that word. However, there are other elements in the sentence that we can build noun phrases around. Here are some of the different noun phrases that can be created from our original sentence, “He bought some bread at the supermarket”:

- The **bread** (that) he bought at the supermarket
- The **supermarket** where he bought the bread
- The **person** who bought the bread at the supermarket
- The **reason** (why) he bought the bread at the supermarket

In the first three examples, we have extracted “the bread, “the supermarket, and “the person” (he), respectively, and created a noun phrases that centers on those things. In the fourth sentence, we have actually added an extra element - the reason - but the concept is the same. In all cases, we can insert the full noun phrase into a sentence and still retain all of the extra information about the chosen element.

When we do this in English, we usually use the word “that” or question words like “where”, “who”, “why” and “which” to connect the head noun to the rest of the information. Sometimes we leave these words out to save time and because we can, but we always have the option to use one of these words because that is how English connects the verb to the head noun.

This is where Japanese is nice and easy. No matter which element you build your noun phrase around, no extra words are needed. All you have to do is make the three changes listed above: put the noun at the end, use the informal verb form, and change “wa” to “ga” when necessary.

Let’s take a look at how each of the alternative noun phrases above are formed in Japanese.

The **person** who bought the bread at the supermarket  
sūpā de pan wo katta **hito**

The **supermarket** where he bought the bread  
kare ga pan wo katta **sūpā**

The **reason** (why) he bought the bread at the supermarket  
kare ga sūpā de pan wo katta **riyū**

The structure here is basically the same as when we used “bread” as the head noun. All we have had to do is take out the head noun element (in the first sentence, “hito” is used as a substitute for the personal pronoun “he”) and put it at the end after the verb. We can now insert these noun phrases into other sentences like any other noun phrase. Let’s try it using the example where the head noun is “hito”:

I don’t like the person who bought the bread at the supermarket  
watashi wa **sūpā de pan wo katta hito** ga suki janai desu

The person who bought the bread at the supermarket is over there  
**sūpā de pan wo katta hito** wa asoko ni imasu

We saw the person who bought the bread at the supermarket  
 watashi tachi wa **sūpā de pan wo katta hito** wo mimashita

Reading the last example, you may notice that there are two possible interpretations. “At the supermarket” could refer to where the person bought the bread, or it could refer to where the person was seen. This ambiguity is present in both English and Japanese, and is a result of the fact that both verbs in the sentence (buy and see) can be associated with a location, and because there is a certain amount of freedom that exists with word order.

This ambiguity is sometimes avoidable, but not always. If the location refers to the main verb - in this case “see” - then the word order can be changed so that the meaning is more clear. For example, in English, we could say, “At the supermarket, we saw the person who bought the bread”. By putting “at the supermarket” at the beginning, it is separated from the noun phrase, and therefore must relate to the main verb; the ambiguity is removed.

In the example above, however, the location refers to where the person bought the bread, and must therefore be grouped together with the rest of the noun phrase that defines the bread, since noun phrases cannot be split up. The only way a sentence like this can be changed is to re-order the words within the noun phrase. However, this can't really be done in English. The best we can do is change the noun phrase to, “the person who, at the supermarket, bought the bread”, but this is obviously quite unnatural.

Fortunately, Japanese offers us a bit more freedom. Because of the flexibility in word order afforded to us by particles, it is perfectly fine to change the noun phrase to, “pan wo sūpā de katta hito”. By putting the location in the middle of the noun phrase, it can no longer be interpreted as part of the main sentence, so the ambiguity is removed.

That said, you don't want to be thinking about these kinds of minor technicalities when you're speaking Japanese; that will only cause you to over-think things, which is not recommended. The point is simply that certain ambiguities will arise in Japanese, just as they do in English. The flexibility of Japanese grammar sometimes allows us to avoid these kinds of ambiguities, but like many other things, context will usually be enough to make the intended meaning clear. Just be aware that ambiguities do exist, and when context doesn't help to clarify things, you can always ask.

In Chapter 11.1, the particle “*yorī*” was introduced as a way to define the basis for a comparison, such as in the following sentence:

Today is hotter than yesterday  
*kyō wa kinō yorī atsui desu*

One further application of this, which has more flexibility, is to combine “*yorī*” with a noun phrase ending in the word “*hō*”. “*Hō*” roughly translates as “the way of”, although such a direct translation would rarely be used in English. The above sentence could be re-phrased using “*hō*” as follows:

Today is hotter than yesterday  
*kinō yorī kyō no hō ga atsui desu*

Although the English translation is the same in both cases, there is a subtle difference in Japanese. In the first example, where “*hō*” isn’t used, “*kyō*” is defined as the topic, which therefore places greater emphasis on what follows; that is, that *yesterday* is the day that today is hotter than. In the second example, however, “*kyō no hō*” is followed by “*ga*”, so there is a greater emphasis on the fact that *today* is the hotter day.

Ultimately, it does not make much difference, but the “*hō*” expression has other uses that make it more flexible. For starters, we can remove “*kinō yorī*” from the second sentence above, and still keep the comparative meaning, like so:

Today is hotter  
*kyō no hō ga atsui desu*

The use of “*hō*” allows us to say that today is hotter, without specifying what today is hotter than. Of course, for this to make sense, it has to be understood from context what today is being compared to.

The biggest advantage of “*hō*”, however, is that it makes it easier to compare other things, like verbs and adjectives. It allows us to say things like:

It would be better to wait here than to go inside  
*naka ni hairu yorī, koko de matta hō ga ī desu*

To fully understand how to use this expression, we need to know how to combine different phrase types with each of “*yor*i” and “*hō ga*”.

“*Yori*” can be placed after almost any type of phrase without altering the phrase at all, as long as the phrase type that comes before “*yor*i” is consistent with what comes after it. The only rule is that when a verb is used immediately before “*yor*i”, it should always be expressed in the present/future tense.

The following table shows how “*hō*” can be combined with different phrase types:

| Word type            | Noun phrase ending in <i>hō</i>                     | Example              |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| <b>Noun</b>          | [noun] + <i>no hō</i>                               | <i>kyō no hō</i>     |
| <b>I-adjective</b>   | [adjective] + <i>hō</i>                             | <i>atsui hō</i>      |
| <b>Na-adjective</b>  | [adjective] + <i>na hō</i>                          | <i>shizuka na hō</i> |
| <b>Positive verb</b> | [verb in informal past tense] + <i>hō</i>           | <i>shita hō</i>      |
| <b>Negative verb</b> | [verb in informal present/future tense] + <i>hō</i> | <i>shinai hō</i>     |

The most important point to take away from this table is that when comparing actions, the *past tense* should be used for verbs in their positive form, while the *present/future tense* should be used for verbs in their negative form. The reason for this, and for why the verb before “*yor*i” should be in the present/future tense, is quite complicated and doesn’t need to be fully understood. However, if you would like a deeper understanding, the text box below provides a brief explanation.

### Verb tenses in the “**yorī...hō ga**” expression

In general, when talking about an action that will be done, there will be a time when that action is in the past. In the “**yorī...hō ga**” expression, the description that follows “**hō ga**” applies to that future time, so the past tense should be used for the verb before it. When talking about an action that is not done, however, there is never a time when the action is in the past. The action is in a perpetual state of non-completion, and the description that follows “**hō ga**” applies to that ongoing state. Negative verbs before “**hō ga**” should therefore be expressed using the present/future tense.

The same applies to the verb before “**yorī**”. Since the final description applies to the alternative action (the one before “**hō**”), in that context, the action before “**yorī**” is also never completed, and should therefore be expressed in the present/future tense.

For a more thorough explanation of this, refer to Appendix 1: Understanding verb tenses in noun phrases.

Here are some examples of this expression:

I prefer cold weather  
(watashi wa) samui tenki **no hō ga** suki desu

When it comes to kitchens, spacious is easier to use than cramped  
daidokoro wa semai **yorī** hiroi **hō ga** tsukaiyasui desu

Simple is better than complicated  
fukuzastu **yorī** shinpuru **na hō ga** ī desu

It's raining, so it would be better to go to the movies than play outside  
ame ga futte iru kara, soto de **asobu yorī**, eigakan ni **itta hō ga** ī

This smells strange, so I think it would be better not to eat it  
kore wa hen na nioi ga suru kara, **tabenai hō ga** ī to omoimasu

One additional thing to keep in mind is that although the phrase type that comes before “yori” needs to be consistent with what comes after it, it does not necessarily need to be consistent with the phrase type immediately before “hō”. The following sentence is one such example:

It would be better to go by car than by bus  
basu **yori** kuruma de itta **hō** ga ī desu

In this case, the mode of transport is being compared, not the action itself, so although the “yori...hō ga” pattern is still used, the things being compared are independent from “hō ga”.

## 12.5.8 Should - hazu, beki

### New vocabulary

|             |           |
|-------------|-----------|
| exam        | shiken    |
| frequently  | hinpan ni |
| information | jōhō      |
| next        | tsugi     |

|                      |              |
|----------------------|--------------|
| should (expectation) | hazu         |
| should (obligation)  | beki         |
| turn (in a sequence) | ban          |
| to trust             | shinrai suru |

In Japanese, there are a couple of different expressions that can be translated into English to mean “should”, but they are not interchangeable. Consider these two sentences:

He should be able to go to the meeting  
You should go to the meeting

Although both sentences use the word “should”, they have fundamentally different meanings. The first sentence expresses an expectation regarding the current situation; that is, the expectation that ‘he’ will come to the meeting. In the second sentence, however, “should” is used to say what action is in the person’s best interests, almost as if the person has an obligation to go to the meeting.

In Japanese, this difference is important, as the word used to mean “should” is different in each case.

**hazu**

When a person is describing their expectation, the Japanese equivalent to the word “should” is “hazu”. This word is a noun and is mostly used as the head noun of a noun phrase and followed by “desu” or “da”. The word before “hazu” can be a verb expressed in any tense, an adjective, or even a noun followed by “no”, as shown in the following examples:

It should be here  
koko ni **aru hazu** desu

I should be able to play tennis on Saturday  
(watashi wa) doyōbi ni tenisu ga **dekiru hazu** desu

He should have been able to go to the meeting  
kare wa kaigi ni **iketa hazu** desu

Okinawa should be hot  
okinawa wa **atsui hazu** da

Tomorrow's exam should be easy  
ashita no shiken wa **kantan na hazu** da

It should be my turn next (literally: Next should be my turn)  
tsugi wa **watashi no ban no hazu** da

**beki**

When a person is describing what action is in their own or someone else's best interest, or what they are obligated to do, the word “beki” is used. This fits into sentences in a similar way as “hazu”, as it usually appears as the head noun of a noun phrase, except it can only be used after a verb in the informal present tense (dictionary form). To describe what somebody should have done in the past, “desu” should be expressed in the past tense. Similarly, for negatives, the verb should remain unchanged in its positive form, with “janai” being added after “beki” instead. Here are some examples:

You should go to tomorrow's meeting  
(anata wa) ashita no kaigi ni iku **beki** desu

I should read the newspaper more frequently, shouldn't I?  
(watashi wa) shinbun wo motto hinpan ni yomu **beki** da yone?

You should have waited until 5 o'clock  
(anata wa) goji made matsu **beki datta**

Even if they're cheap, you shouldn't buy things you don't need  
yasukutemo, iranai mono wo kau **beki janai**

When used with “beki”, the verb “suru” is an exception in that the “ru” is usually dropped. The resulting phrase is “su beki”, as shown in the following examples:

You should practice Japanese every day  
mainichi nihongo wo renshū **subeki** desu

We shouldn't trust old information  
(watashi tachi wa) furui jōhō wo shinrai **subeki janai** desu

You may occasionally hear a Japanese person say “suru beki”, and you can get away with using this yourself, but it is technically incorrect.

### 12.5.9 Describing an incomplete list of activities - tari ... tari suru

#### New vocabulary

|               |              |
|---------------|--------------|
| to climb      | noboru       |
| to do laundry | sentaku suru |
| Mount Fuji    | fuji san     |

In Chapter 11.1, we learned about the particles “ya” and “nado”, which are used together to describe a vague or incomplete list of things. The same kind of vague list can be built for actions by using the “-tari” verb ending. Consider this example:

We did some shopping, saw a movie, drank tea, etc.  
(watashi tachi wa) kaimono wo **shitari**, eiga wo **mitari**, ocha wo **nondari** shimashita.

Here, the speaker is talking about several things that they did, while also implying that they did other things as well. Much like sentences using “ya” and “nado”, this kind of sentence is deliberately vague.

The “-tari” verb ending is formed in the same way as the informal past tense, with the addition of “ri”, as shown below:

| Verb type      |            | Formation of -tari ending | Example     |
|----------------|------------|---------------------------|-------------|
| Add-on         |            | stem + tari               | tabetari    |
| Vowel-changing | u, tsu, ru | -ttari                    | kattari     |
|                | bu, mu, nu | -ndari                    | asondari    |
|                | ku         | -itari                    | kītari      |
|                | gu         | -idari                    | oyoidari    |
|                | su         | -shitari                  | hanashitari |
| Irregular      | suru       | shi + tari                | shitari     |
|                | iku        | ittari                    | ittari      |
|                | kuru       | ki + tari                 | kitari      |

For verbs in the negative form, the “nai” ending is changed to “nakattari”. For verbs expressed in the continuous form, the “-te iru” ending is changed to “-te itari”.

The pattern to follow when using this expression is as follows:

[action]-tari, [action]-tari, ..., [action]-tari + suru

There is no limit to the number of activities that can be listed using this expression. However, like “ya” and “nado”, since this is a deliberately vague expression, the number of activities is usually limited to three or four. It is also possible and not uncommon to list just one activity.

The important part to remember is that the sentence is not complete until the verb “suru” is added in the appropriate tense, which can be basically anything. You will sometimes hear “tari” used without “suru” at the end, and this is acceptable in certain contexts, but generally, “suru” needs to be included in order for the phrase to be a complete sentence. Here are some more examples:

Today, I cleaned the house, did the laundry, etc.

kyō, ie wo **sōji shitari**, fuku wo **sentaku shitari** shimashita

I want to go to Japan and climb Mount Fuji, ride the bullet train, etc.  
nihon ni itte, fuji san wo **nobottari**, shinkansen ni **nottari** shitai

I love music, and I am always (doing things like) dancing  
watashi wa ongaku ga daisuki de, itsumo **odottari** shite imasu

### 12.5.10 Discussing plans - **tsumori**

In both English and Japanese, there are different ways to express our plans based on how certain it is that those plans will go ahead. While we don't often think about it, in English, we tend to use the word "will", or say things like "I'm going to the mall tomorrow" when our plans are certain. If, on the other hand, our plans are fairly certain but there is still a chance - even a small one - that they will not eventuate, we tend to insert phrases like, "I'm planning to..." or "I intend to..." to express that lower level of certainty, no matter how small.

In Japanese, definite plans are, as you know, expressed by simply using the present/future tense. Less concrete plans can be expressed by adding the word "tsumori" after a verb in the informal present/future tense. This forms a noun phrase that usually comes at the end of a sentence followed by "desu" or "da". Here are some examples:

I plan to go to the mall tomorrow  
ashita (watashi wa) mōru ni iku **tsumori** desu

I intend to leave home at 6am  
asa roku ji ni ie wo deru **tsumori** da

I planned to buy a new shirt, but there wasn't enough time  
atarashī shatsu wo kau **tsumori** deshita ga, jikan ga nakatta desu

As the last example shows, even when talking about the plans you had for the past, the verb (in this case "kau") is expressed in the present/future tense. The past tense use of "deshita" makes the whole clause a reference to the past.

### 12.5.11 Expressing uncertainty - **kamo shiremasen**

An easy and useful way to add a degree of uncertainty to any phrase is to add "kamo shiremasen", or "kamo shirenai", at the end of the sentence. This is similar to inserting a word like "might" or "could be" into an English sentence. It is also often used as a way to

be more indirect when saying “no” to someone, which is important in Japanese culture, where directness is often considered impolite.

This expression can be added after any noun phrase or clause, with clauses mostly ending in verbs in their informal form. Here are some examples:

I might not be able to go  
(watashi wa) ikenai **kamo shiremasen**

There might be a convenience store over there  
asoko ni konbini ga aru **kamo shirenai**

That might be the case  
sō **kamo shirenai**

This is very handy when you are not 100% certain of something, or even when you want to speak in a vague or indirect way. Since Japanese is generally a vague and non-specific language, and directness is not often well received, this expression is very common.

## 12.5.12 How to do things - yarikata

### New vocabulary

|                   |                |
|-------------------|----------------|
| to be mistaken    | machigatte iru |
| to make a mistake | machigaeru     |
| to show           | miseru         |

Any verb can be turned into a noun that means “how to ...” or “the way to...”. This is done by adding “kata”, which loosely translates as “way”, to the verb stem. Here is how “kata” is added to each verb type:

| Word type           |      | How to...      | Example     |
|---------------------|------|----------------|-------------|
| Add-on verb         |      | stem + kata    | tabekata    |
| Vowel-changing verb |      | stem(i) + kata | tsukurikata |
| Irregular verb      | suru | shi + kata     | shikata     |
|                     | iku  | iki + kata     | ikikata     |
|                     | kuru | ki + kata      | kikata      |

These can then be used in a sentence like any other noun, as these examples show:

I don't know how to eat this  
kore no **tabekata** ga wakarimasen

He showed me how to open the window  
kare ga mado no **akekata** wo misete kuremashita

I've forgotten how to go to the airport  
kūkō he no **ikikata** wo wasuremashita

You're doing it wrong (literally: Your way of doing it is mistaken)  
(anata no) **yarikata** ga machigatte iru yo

Please teach me how to practice karate  
karate no **renshū shikata** wo oshiete kudasai

The verb “suru” on its own is rarely expressed in this way as “shikata”. The verb “yaru”, also meaning “do”, is usually used instead. However, for verbs that consist of a word followed by “suru”, like “renshū suru”, only “shikata” is appropriate.

### 12.5.13 Trying - shiyō to suru, shite miru

#### New vocabulary

|                         |                 |
|-------------------------|-----------------|
| ATM                     | ATM (ei tī emu) |
| to break (intransitive) | kowareru        |
| to restart (a machine)  | saikidō suru    |
| to withdraw             | orosu           |

In English, the word “try” has two main meanings:

1. To test or evaluate something to see what the result is, eg. Sushi is delicious. Try it!
2. To attempt to do or achieve something, eg. He tried to run 10km but stopped at 5km.

This difference is important because in Japanese, they are completely separate concepts that are expressed in completely different ways. Let's take a look at each of these:

### Testing or evaluating something

To say that you or someone else is trying something to see what the result will be, the verb is expressed in the te-form followed by the verb “miru”, like so:

[verb(te)] + miru

This is literally like saying, “Do and see”, meaning that you will do the action, and see what the result is. This can also be used simply to mean “do and see”, even if the word “try” would not be appropriate.

Here are some examples:

Sushi is delicious. Try it!  
sushi wa oishī yo. **tabete mite!**

Did you try restarting your computer?  
konpyūta wo **saikidō shite mimashita** ka

Let's try turning the lights off  
denki wo **keshite miyō**

In the English translations of all of the above sentences, the word “try” could be removed, and the entire sentence re-phrased to say “do and see”. Although it may not always sound natural, it is a useful way determine which “try” expression to use if you are ever unsure.

### Describing an attempt

To express an attempt to do or achieve something, the action being attempted is expressed using the same verb ending as the “Let's...” expression, followed by “to suru”, as shown in the following table:

| Verb type      | To try to...        | Example      |
|----------------|---------------------|--------------|
| Add-on         | stem + yō + to suru | miyō to suru |
| Vowel-changing | stem(ō) + to suru   | kikō to suru |

| Irregular |                 |               |
|-----------|-----------------|---------------|
| do        | shiyō + to suru | shiyō to suru |
| go        | ikō + to suru   | ikō to suru   |
| come      | koyō + to suru  | koyō to suru  |

The verb “suru” at the end can be expressed in any tense or level of politeness that makes sense. Here are some examples:

He tried to run 10km but stopped at 5km  
kare wa jukkiri **hashirō to shita** kedo, go kiro de yameta

I’m trying to open the window  
mado wo **akeyō to shite imasu**

I tried to withdraw money, but the ATM is broken  
okane wo **orosō to shita** kedo, ATM ga kowarete iru

Although it may look like it, this verb ending does not give the sentences the meaning, “Let’s try”. The “Let’s...” interpretation of the “-yō” or “-ō” verb ending is simply the most accurate way to translate it into English when it is used on its own. When followed by “to suru”, however, it forms a set expression meaning “try to”. If we want to say, “Let’s try to...”, we can do so by using the “shiyō” form of “suru” at the end of the phrase, like so:

Let’s try to fix the car  
kuruma wo **naosō to shiyō**

This kind of expression is not very common, however, as it implies that you don’t really expect to succeed. Instead, you would more likely use a more positive statement like, “kuruma wo naosō” (Let’s fix the car), or even the other “try” expression, “kuruma wo naoshite miyō” (Let’s fix the car and see).

#### 12.5.14 Negative questions - shimasen ka, janai no?

In English, we sometimes ask questions using a verb in the negative form, such as, “Won’t you come with me?” or, “Didn’t you see him yesterday?”. The same kinds of

questions are often asked in Japanese, usually either as invitations, or when the person asking the question is expecting the answer to confirm that the action being described didn't happen (eg. "No, I didn't see him"). In the case of invitations, although the verb is expressed negatively, it is very much a positive invitation - that is, the person asking the question is hoping that the response will be positive. Here are some examples of negative questions:

Won't you go and see a movie with me on Friday?  
kin'yōbi ni watashi to eiga wo mi ni **ikanai?**

Didn't you buy bread yesterday?  
kinō pan wo **kawanakatta no?**

Won't you lend me your car?  
(watashi ni) kuruma wo **kashite kuremasen ka**

A particularly common group of negative questions is regular statements followed by a questioning, "janai desu ka". A person would use this to seek confirmation of what they already believe ("Isn't the party tomorrow?"), as opposed to asking a simple question ("Is the party tomorrow?"). Particularly with verbs and i-adjectives, this is commonly preceded by "n", the contraction of the sentence-ending particle "no" (see Chapter 11.1). Here are some examples:

Isn't the party tomorrow?  
pāti wa ashita **janai desu ka**

Wouldn't it be better to go?  
itta hō ga **in janai?**

Isn't my jacket on the bed?  
watashi no uwagi wa beddo ni **arun janai no?**

## 12.5.15 Before/after doing... - mae ni, ato ni

### New vocabulary

|               |             |
|---------------|-------------|
| a bit more    | mō chotto   |
| details       | shōsai      |
| report        | repōto      |
| to save money | chokin suru |

To describe when one action occurs relative to another, we can use the words “mae ni” and “ato ni” to form noun phrases meaning “before” and “after”, respectively. These words can be attached to verbs in the informal form, or connected to nouns with the particle “no”. The following table shows how these words can be used to form noun phrases:

| Word type   | Before                                           | After                                  |
|-------------|--------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| <b>Noun</b> | [noun] + no mae ni                               | [noun] + no ato ni                     |
| <b>Verb</b> | [verb in informal present/future tense] + mae ni | [verb in informal past tense] + ato ni |

Here are some examples of these expressions:

Please read the report before the meeting  
kaigi **no mae ni** repōto wo yonde oite kudasai

Before I left the house, I hung out the laundry  
ie wo **deru mae ni**, sentakumono wo hoshite okimashita

Before we buy a new house, let's save a bit more money  
atarashī ie wo **kau mae ni**, mō chotto chokin shite okimashō

After my lunch break, I need to go and renew my passport  
hiruyasumi **no ato ni**, pasupōto wo kōshin shi ni ikanakereba narimasen

After the match ended, we all (everyone) went to karaoke  
shiai ga **owatta ato ni**, minna de karaoke ni ikimashita

After I have spoken with her, I will send you the details via email  
 kanojo to **hanashita ato ni**, shōsai wo mēru de (anata ni) okurimasu

The important thing to remember is that no matter whether we are talking about the future or the past, the verb before “mae” should always be in the informal present/future tense, and the verb before “ato” should always be in the informal past tense. The reason for this is that in Japanese, unlike English, it is not relevant when the first action occurred in relation to now. All that matters is when the action occurred relative to the other action.

If, for example, we say “gakkō ni iku mae ni, terebi wo mimashita”, the act of watching TV happened before going to school. Relative to the timing of watching TV, the act of going to school is in the future, hence the present/future tense should be used. On the other hand, if we say “gakkō ni itta ato ni, terebi wo mimashita”, then relative to the timing of watching TV, the act of going to school is in the past, so the past tense is used. For a more thorough explanation of why verb tenses differ from English in these situations, see Appendix 1: Understanding verb tenses in noun phrases.

### 12.5.16 For/in order to - tame ni

#### New vocabulary

|                 |           |
|-----------------|-----------|
| ferris wheel    | kanransha |
| to save (money) | tameru    |

The expression “tame ni” can be added after a noun or verb to define the purpose or reason for a particular action.

#### With nouns

When used with a noun, “tame ni” defines who or what the action is done *for*, and is used in a sentence like so:

[person/thing] + no tame ni

Here are some examples:

Let's buy this book **for our mother**  
 kono hon wo **haha no tame ni** kaimashō

Did you make this **for me**?  
kore wo **watashi no tame ni** tsukutta no?

I went to Tokyo **for** a concert  
(watashi wa) **raibu no tame ni** tōkyō ni ikimashita

### With verbs

When used with a verb, “tame ni” takes the meaning of “in order to” or “so that”. In other words, it defines what purpose the action is being done *for*. The part of the sentence that comes before “tame ni” will therefore usually describe a goal, while the part that follows it describes the action to be taken in order to achieve that goal.

The action taken to achieve the goal can be expressed in any tense or level of politeness, as is appropriate. The verb describing the goal, however, should always be expressed in the present/future tense, as shown below:

[goal, using verb in present/future tense] + tame ni + [action taken to achieve the goal]

Here are some examples:

In order **to become a doctor**, I will study a lot  
(watashi wa) isha ni **naru tame ni**, takusan benkyō shimasu

I need to save money **to buy a new computer**  
atarashī konpyūta wo **kau tame ni** okane wo tamenai to ikenai

We waited an hour **to ride the ferris wheel**  
**kanransha ni noru tame ni** ichijikan machimashita

## 12.5.17 Whether or not - kadōka

### New vocabulary

|            |              |
|------------|--------------|
| address    | jūsho        |
| to answer  | kotaeru      |
| to confirm | kakunin suru |
| correct    | tadashī      |

One useful application of the question particle “ka” is to combine it with “dōka” to effectively say “whether or not”. This can be added basically anywhere the particle “ka” might be used, although the verb before the first “ka” is usually expressed in the informal form. “Kadōka” is then often followed by a phrase equivalent to something we might say before “whether or not” in English, such as, “I don’t know...” or “I will ask him...”. The following examples demonstrate this:

I don’t know whether or not it will rain tomorrow  
ashita ame ga furu **kadōka** wakarimasen

I don’t know whether or not they won  
karera ga katta **kadōka** wakarimasen

I asked him whether or not he is coming, but he didn’t answer  
kare ga kuru **kadōka** kīte mita kedo, kotaete kurenakatta

Please confirm whether or not your address is correct  
(anata no) jūsho ga tadashī **kadōka** kakunin shite kudasai

### 12.5.18 Too... - sugiru

#### New vocabulary

|         |         |
|---------|---------|
| luggage | nimotsu |
| meat    | niku    |

In English, when we want to describe something as being excessive in some way, we use the word “too” before the appropriate adjective. Similarly, when we want to say that someone has performed a certain action excessively, we add a phrase like “too much” or “too far”, as in the sentences, “He bought too much” or “He went too far”.

In Japanese, the same idea can be expressed for both adjectives and verbs by attaching the word “sugiru” to the end of the word. “Sugiru” is itself an add-on verb, meaning it can be expressed in different tenses and with different levels of politeness. The following table shows how “sugiru” can be attached to each word type:



## Appendix 1

# Understanding verb tenses in noun phrases

There is an important difference between how Japanese and English treat verbs in noun phrases. Consider the following sentences:

When Yoshi **arrived** in Tokyo, he went to the hotel  
yoshi wa tōkyō ni **tsuita** toki, hoteru ni ikimashita

When Yoshi **arrives** in Osaka, please call me  
yoshi ga ōsaka ni **tsuita** toki, (watashi ni) denwa shite kudasai

In the first example, the words “arrive” and “tsuku” are in the past tense in both English and Japanese. In the second example, however, “arrive” is in the present tense, but the word “tsuku” is in the past tense. The reason for this is because the timing that relates to verbs in conditional clauses and noun phrases is different in each language.

In English, the important piece of timing information is the timing of the action *relative to the present moment*. If the action took place in the past, the past tense is used. If the action will take place in the future, the present tense is usually used. It may seem

odd that the present tense is used for future actions, but this is just one of the quirks of the English language, and is the reason that many non-native English speakers would mistakenly express the second sentence above as, “When Yoshi will arrive in Tokyo, please call me”.

Regardless, in Japanese, the important piece of timing information is the timing of the action *relative to the main verb* in the sentence. In the first example, the main action is the act of going to the hotel. Since Yoshi’s arrival in Tokyo happened before he went to the hotel, from the perspective of the main action, his arrival occurred in the past, so the past tense is used. Similarly, in the second example, relative to the time that the person should call “me”, Yoshi will have already arrived in Osaka. The act of arriving will be in the past relative to that point in time, so the past tense is used.

This difference in perspective applies to noun phrases of all types, and all verb tenses. Here is an example from Chapter 10.4, slightly modified for the sake of comparison:

I saw that he **was eating** sushi  
(watashi wa) kare ga sushi wo **tabete iru** no wo mimashita

In this case, the English sentence uses the past continuous tense for “eat”, but in Japanese, “taberu” is expressed in the present continuous tense. This is because ‘he’ was in the process of eating sushi at the time that ‘I’ saw him.

A more clear example that shows these different perspectives is when using the words “mae” and “ato” to say “before” and “after”. Consider these sentences from Chapter 12.5.15:

Before I left the house, I hung out the laundry  
ie wo **deru mae ni**, sentakumono wo hoshite okimashita

After I have spoken with her, I will send you the details via email  
kanojo to **hanashita ato ni**, shōsai wo mēru de (anata ni) okurimasu

In the first example, both actions described in the sentence occurred in the past, but because the word “mae” is used to form a noun phrase describing when ‘I’ left the house, the verb in that noun phrase - “deru” - needs to be expressed from the perspective of main verb in the sentence. At the time that ‘I’ hung out the laundry, the act of leaving the house was in the future, so “deru” needs to be expressed in the present/future tense.

The opposite situation occurs in the second example. The overall sentence refers to the future, but at the time that the main verb in the sentence - “okurimasu” - takes place, the act of speaking with “her” will be in the past. The verb “hanasu” should therefore be expressed in the past tense.

Another example is this one from Chapter 12.5.7, where the past tense is used even though the action being referred to is in the present or future:

It would be better to wait here than to go inside  
naka ni hairu yori, koko de **matta hō** ga ī desu

This is a bit trickier to make sense of, but essentially, the main verb here is “desu”, and this is used to describe the act of ‘waiting here’ as good (“ī”). The timing that this description applies to is actually a hypothetical future, where we are looking back and evaluating the outcome of having waited. At that hypothetical future time, the act of waiting is in the past, so the past tense is used for that verb.

By contrast, the act of ‘going inside’ will not have occurred at that future time. Instead, it will be in a perpetual state of non-completion, not occurring in the past, present or future. For this reason, the dictionary form is used to refer to the act of ‘going inside’ in general terms.

The same reasoning can be applied to why the negative present/future tense is used when a negative verb appears before “hō”, such as in this example, also from Chapter 12.5.7:

This smells strange, so I think it would be better not to eat it  
kore wa hen na nioi ga suru kara, **tabenai hō** ga ī to omoimasu

Here, too, the act of ‘not eating’ does not occur at any time in the past, present or future. It is therefore described in general terms, which is done using the negative of the dictionary form.

In summary, the tense used for verbs that appear within noun phrases is sometimes different in English and Japanese because the perspective that applies to these actions is different. While in English we almost always talk about things from the perspective of the present, in Japanese sentences, verbs that appear within noun phrases should be expressed from the perspective of the main action in that sentence.



# Appendix 2

## Verb dictionary (English - Japanese)

This dictionary contains all of the verbs that appear in the examples and exercises in this book. Japanese verbs are presented in their dictionary form (informal present tense) and in the polite present tense to assist with verb type identification. Verbs that are part of a transitive/intransitive verb pair (refer to Chapter 8.7) are marked with a [t] for transitive and [i] for intransitive.

| English                                     | Dictionary form<br>(informal present tense) | Polite present tense |
|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| answer                                      | kotaeru                                     | kotaemasu            |
| appear (in a match, on TV etc.)             | deru                                        | demasu               |
| apply (liquids such as creams, paints etc.) | nuru                                        | nurimasu             |
| appreciate                                  | kansha suru                                 | kansha shimasu       |
| arrive                                      | tsuku                                       | tsukimasu            |
| ascend [i]                                  | agaru                                       | agarimasu            |
| ask                                         | kiku                                        | kikimasu             |
| be                                          | da                                          | desu                 |
| be (living)                                 | iru                                         | imasu                |

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| English             | Dictionary form<br>(informal present tense) | Polite present tense |
|---------------------|---------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| be (non-living)     | aru                                         | arimasu              |
| be audible          | kikoeru                                     | kikoemasu            |
| be born             | umareru                                     | umaremasu            |
| be careful          | ki wo tsukeru                               | ki wo tsukemasu      |
| be found [i]        | mitsukaru                                   | mitsukarimasu        |
| be late             | okureru                                     | okuremasu            |
| be mistaken [i]     | machigau                                    | machigaimasu         |
| be on time          | ma ni au                                    | ma ni aimasu         |
| be surprised        | bikkuri suru                                | bikkuri shimasu      |
| be visible          | mieru                                       | miemasu              |
| become              | naru                                        | narimasu             |
| become empty        | suku                                        | sukimasu             |
| begin [i]           | hajimaru                                    | hajimarimasu         |
| belong              | shozoku suru                                | shozoku shimasu      |
| borrow              | kariru                                      | karimasu             |
| break [i]           | kowareru                                    | kowaremasu           |
| break [t]           | kowasu                                      | kowashimasu          |
| bump [t]            | butsukeru                                   | butsukemasu          |
| bump into [i]       | butsukaru                                   | butsukarimasu        |
| buy                 | kau                                         | kaimasu              |
| call                | denwa suru                                  | denwa shimasu        |
| cancel              | kyanseru suru                               | kyanseru shimasu     |
| carry               | motsu                                       | mochimasu            |
| carry (from A to B) | hakobu                                      | hakobimasu           |
| catch (a cold)      | hiku                                        | hikimasu             |
| catch (fishing)     | tsuru                                       | tsurimasu            |
| change              | kaeru                                       | kaemasu              |
| charge (a battery)  | jūden suru                                  | jūden shimasu        |
| chase               | oikakeru                                    | oikakemasu           |
| choose              | sentaku suru                                | sentaku shimasu      |
| clean               | migaku                                      | migakimasu           |

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| English                | Dictionary form<br>(informal present tense) | Polite present tense |
|------------------------|---------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| clean                  | sōji suru                                   | sōji shimasu         |
| climb                  | noboru                                      | noborimasu           |
| close [i]              | shimaru                                     | shimarimasu          |
| close [t]              | shimeru                                     | shimemasu            |
| collect [t]            | atsumeru                                    | atsumemasu           |
| come                   | kuru                                        | kimasu               |
| come and pick up       | mukae ni kuru                               | mukae ni kimasu      |
| come on [i]            | tsuku                                       | tsukimasu            |
| complete               | kansei suru                                 | kansei shimasu       |
| confirm                | kakunin suru                                | kakunin shimasu      |
| cook                   | ryōri suru                                  | ryōri shimasu        |
| cost [i]               | kakaru                                      | kakarimasu           |
| dance                  | odoru                                       | odorimasu            |
| decide [t]             | kimeru                                      | kimemasu             |
| depart                 | shuppatsu suru                              | shuppatsu shimasu    |
| die                    | shinu                                       | shinimasu            |
| do                     | suru                                        | shimasu              |
| do                     | yaru                                        | yarimasu             |
| do laundry             | sentaku suru                                | sentaku shimasu      |
| do one's best          | ganbaru                                     | ganbarimasu          |
| drink                  | nomu                                        | nomimasu             |
| drive                  | untēn suru                                  | untēn shimasu        |
| drop [t]               | otosu                                       | otoshimasu           |
| dry [i]                | kawaku                                      | kawakimasu           |
| eat                    | taberu                                      | tabemasu             |
| email                  | mēru suru                                   | mēru shimasu         |
| end                    | owaru                                       | owarimasu            |
| enter [i]              | hairu                                       | hairimasu            |
| exercise               | undō suru                                   | undō shimasu         |
| extinguish [t]         | kesu                                        | keshimasu            |
| fall (rain, snow etc.) | furu                                        | furimasu             |

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| English                 | Dictionary form<br>(informal present tense) | Polite present tense |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| fall [i]                | ochiru                                      | ochimasu             |
| finish                  | owaru                                       | owarimasu            |
| fix                     | naosu                                       | naoshimasu           |
| fly                     | tobu                                        | tobimasu             |
| forget                  | wasureru                                    | wasuremasu           |
| gather [i]              | atsumaru                                    | atsumarimasu         |
| get fat                 | futoru                                      | futorimasu           |
| get sunburnt            | hiyake suru                                 | hiyake shimasu       |
| get to know             | shiriau                                     | shiriaiimasu         |
| give                    | ageru                                       | agemasu              |
| give (towards yourself) | kureru                                      | kuremasu             |
| give up                 | akirameru                                   | akiramemasu          |
| go                      | iku                                         | ikimasu              |
| go and pick up          | mukae ni iku                                | mukae ni ikimasu     |
| go for a walk           | sanpo suru                                  | sanpo shimasu        |
| go off, go out [i]      | kieru                                       | kiemasu              |
| go shopping             | kaimono suru                                | kaimono shimasu      |
| go up [i]               | agaru                                       | agarimasu            |
| graduate                | sotsugyō suru                               | sotsugyō shimasu     |
| hang out (clothes etc.) | hosu                                        | hoshimasu            |
| have                    | motsu                                       | mochimasu            |
| have (a pet)            | kau                                         | kaimasu              |
| have (non-living)       | aru                                         | arimasu              |
| hit [i]                 | butsukaru                                   | butsukarimasu        |
| hit [t]                 | butsukeru                                   | butsukemasu          |
| hold                    | motsu                                       | mochimasu            |
| hold (events etc.)      | kaisai suru                                 | kaisai shimasu       |
| hurry                   | isogu                                       | isogimasu            |
| include                 | fukumu                                      | fukumimasu           |
| introduce               | shōkai suru                                 | shōkai shimasu       |
| jump                    | tobu                                        | tobimasu             |

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| English                      | Dictionary form<br>(informal present tense) | Polite present tense |
|------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| kick                         | keru                                        | kerimasu             |
| know                         | shiru                                       | shirimasu            |
| learn                        | manabu                                      | manabimasu           |
| leave [i]                    | deru                                        | demasu               |
| lend                         | kasu                                        | kashimasu            |
| listen                       | kiku                                        | kikimasu             |
| live (reside)                | sumu                                        | sumimasu             |
| lose                         | makeru                                      | makemasu             |
| lose weight                  | yaseru                                      | yasemasu             |
| love                         | ai suru                                     | ai shimasu           |
| make                         | tsukuru                                     | tsukurimasu          |
| make a mistake [t]           | machigaeru                                  | machigaemasu         |
| make a phone call            | denwa suru                                  | denwa shimasu        |
| make a reservation           | yoyaku suru                                 | yoyaku shimasu       |
| marry                        | kekkon suru                                 | kekkon shimasu       |
| meet                         | au                                          | aimasu               |
| meet (for the first time)    | deau                                        | deaimasu             |
| mess around                  | asobu                                       | asobimasu            |
| move [i]                     | ugoku                                       | ugokimasu            |
| move [t]                     | ugokasu                                     | ugokashimasu         |
| need                         | iru                                         | irimasu              |
| open [i]                     | aku                                         | akimasu              |
| open [t]                     | akeru                                       | akemasu              |
| order                        | chūmon suru                                 | chūmon shimasu       |
| oversleep, sleep in          | nebō suru                                   | nebō shimasu         |
| own                          | motsu                                       | mochimasu            |
| pass (a test)                | gōkaku suru                                 | gōkaku shimasu       |
| pick up                      | toru                                        | torimasu             |
| place (an object)            | oku                                         | okimasu              |
| place an order               | chūmon suru                                 | chūmon shimasu       |
| play (a stringed instrument) | hiku                                        | hikimasu             |

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| English                                         | Dictionary form<br>(informal present tense) | Polite present tense |
|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| play, mess around                               | asobu                                       | asobimasu            |
| play football                                   | futtobōru suru                              | futtobōru shimasu    |
| practice                                        | renshū suru                                 | renshū shimasu       |
| put (an object) on                              | oku                                         | okimasu              |
| put in [t]                                      | ireru                                       | iremasu              |
| put on (liquids such as creams,<br>paints etc.) | nuru                                        | nurimasu             |
| put on (lower body)                             | haku                                        | hakimasu             |
| put on (upper body)                             | kiru                                        | kimasu               |
| put on weight                                   | futoru                                      | futorimasu           |
| put out [t]                                     | dasu                                        | dashimasu            |
| put up with                                     | taeru                                       | taemasu              |
| quit                                            | yameru                                      | yamemasu             |
| raise [t]                                       | ageru                                       | agemasu              |
| read                                            | yomu                                        | yomimasu             |
| receive                                         | morau                                       | moraimasu            |
| remember                                        | oboeru                                      | oboemasu             |
| renew                                           | kōshin suru                                 | kōshin shimasu       |
| reply                                           | henji suru                                  | henji shimasu        |
| respect                                         | sonkei suru                                 | sonkei shimasu       |
| restart (a machine)                             | saikidō suru                                | saikidō shimasu      |
| return (home) [i]                               | kaeru                                       | kaerimasu            |
| return (something) [t]                          | kaesu                                       | kaeshimasu           |
| ride                                            | noru                                        | norimasu             |
| ring                                            | naruru                                      | narimasu             |
| run                                             | hashiru                                     | hashirimasu          |
| save (money)                                    | tameru                                      | tamemasu             |
| save money                                      | chokin suru                                 | chokin shimasu       |
| say                                             | iu                                          | īmasu                |
| search                                          | sagasu                                      | sagashimasu          |
| see (spot, notice)                              | mikakeru                                    | mikakemasu           |
| sell                                            | uru                                         | urimasu              |

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| English                   | Dictionary form<br>(informal present tense) | Polite present tense |
|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| send                      | okuru                                       | okurimasu            |
| send email                | mēru suru                                   | mēru shimasu         |
| show                      | miseru                                      | misemasu             |
| shut [t]                  | shimeru                                     | shimemasu            |
| sit                       | suwaru                                      | suwarimasu           |
| ski                       | sukī suru                                   | sukī shimasu         |
| sleep                     | neru                                        | nemasu               |
| smell (emit a smell)      | nioi ga suru                                | nioi ga shimasu      |
| speak                     | hanasu                                      | hanashimasu          |
| spend (money, time) [t]   | kakeru                                      | kakemasu             |
| spot (see)                | mikakeru                                    | mikakemasu           |
| stand (up)                | tatsu                                       | tachimasu            |
| start [i]                 | hajimaru                                    | hajimarimasu         |
| stay (at accommodation)   | tomaru                                      | tomarimasu           |
| stop                      | yameru                                      | yamemasu             |
| study                     | benkyō suru                                 | benkyō shimasu       |
| swim                      | oyogu                                       | oyogimasu            |
| take                      | toru                                        | torimasu             |
| take (a photograph/video) | toru                                        | torimasu             |
| take (a shower)           | abiru                                       | abimasu              |
| take (money, time) [i]    | kakaru                                      | kakarimasu           |
| take (money, time) [t]    | kakeru                                      | kakemasu             |
| take off (clothes)        | nugu                                        | nugimasu             |
| take out [t]              | dasu                                        | dashimasu            |
| talk                      | hanasu                                      | hanashimasu          |
| teach                     | oshieru                                     | oshiemasu            |
| tell                      | oshieru                                     | oshiemasu            |
| thank                     | kansha suru                                 | kansha shimasu       |
| there is (living)         | iru                                         | imasu                |
| there is (non-living)     | aru                                         | arimasu              |
| think (opinion)           | omou                                        | omoimasu             |
| throw out                 | suteru                                      | sutemasu             |

# RICHARD WEBB

| English           | Dictionary form<br>(informal present tense) | Polite present tense |
|-------------------|---------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| touch             | sawaru                                      | sawarimasu           |
| travel            | ryokō suru                                  | ryokō shimasu        |
| trust             | shinrai suru                                | shinrai shimasu      |
| turn off [t]      | kesu                                        | keshimasu            |
| turn on [t]       | tsukeru                                     | tsukemasu            |
| understand        | wakaru                                      | wakarimasu           |
| use               | tsukau                                      | tsukaimasu           |
| visit             | hōmon suru                                  | hōmon shimasu        |
| wait              | matsu                                       | machimasu            |
| wake up           | okiru                                       | okimasu              |
| walk              | aruku                                       | arukimasu            |
| wash              | arau                                        | araimasu             |
| watch             | miru                                        | mimasu               |
| wear (lower body) | haku                                        | hakimasu             |
| wear (upper body) | kiru                                        | kimasu               |
| win               | katsu                                       | kachimasu            |
| withdraw          | orosu                                       | oroshimasu           |
| work              | hataraku                                    | hatarakimasu         |
| work              | shigoto suru                                | shigoto shimasu      |
| work hard         | ganbaru                                     | ganbarimasu          |
| write             | kaku                                        | kakimasu             |

## Appendix 3

# Verb dictionary (Japanese - English)

This dictionary contains all of the verbs that appear in the examples and exercises in this book. Japanese verbs are presented in their dictionary form (informal present tense) and in the polite present tense to assist with verb type identification. Verbs that are part of a transitive/intransitive verb pair (refer to Chapter 8.7) are marked with a [t] for transitive and [i] for intransitive.

| Dictionary form<br>(informal present tense) | Polite present tense | English                         |
|---------------------------------------------|----------------------|---------------------------------|
| abiru                                       | abimasu              | take (a shower)                 |
| agaru                                       | agarimasu            | ascend, go up [i]               |
| ageru                                       | agemasu              | raise [t]                       |
| ageru                                       | agemasu              | give                            |
| ai suru                                     | ai shimasu           | love                            |
| akeru                                       | akemasu              | open [t]                        |
| akirameru                                   | akiramemasu          | give up                         |
| aku                                         | akimasu              | open [i]                        |
| arau                                        | araimasu             | wash                            |
| aru                                         | arimasu              | be, there is, have (non-living) |

# RICHARD WEBB

| Dictionary form<br>(informal present tense) | Polite present tense | English                                    |
|---------------------------------------------|----------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| aruku                                       | arukimasu            | walk                                       |
| asobu                                       | asobimasu            | play, mess around                          |
| atsumaru                                    | atsumarimasu         | gather [i]                                 |
| atsumeru                                    | atsumemasu           | collect [t]                                |
| au                                          | aimasu               | meet                                       |
| benkyō suru                                 | benkyō shimasu       | study                                      |
| bikkuri suru                                | bikkuri shimasu      | be surprised                               |
| butsukaru                                   | butsukarimasu        | hit, bump into [i]                         |
| butsukeru                                   | butsukemasu          | hit, bump [t]                              |
| chokin suru                                 | chokin shimasu       | to save money                              |
| chūmon suru                                 | chūmon shimasu       | order, place an order                      |
| da                                          | desu                 | be                                         |
| dasu                                        | dashimasu            | put out, take out [t]                      |
| deau                                        | deaimasu             | meet (for the first time)                  |
| denwa suru                                  | denwa shimasu        | call, make a phone call                    |
| deru                                        | demasu               | leave [i], appear (in a match, on TV etc.) |
| fukumu                                      | fukumimasu           | include                                    |
| furu                                        | furimasu             | fall (rain, snow etc.)                     |
| futoru                                      | futorimasu           | put on weight, get fat                     |
| futtabōru suru                              | futtabōru shimasu    | play football                              |
| ganbaru                                     | ganbarimasu          | do one's best, work hard                   |
| gōkaku suru                                 | gōkaku shimasu       | pass (a test)                              |
| hairu                                       | hairimasu            | enter [i]                                  |
| hajimaru                                    | hajimarimasu         | begin, start [i]                           |
| hakobu                                      | hakobimasu           | carry (from A to B)                        |
| haku                                        | hakimasu             | wear, put on (lower body)                  |
| hanasu                                      | hanashimasu          | speak, talk                                |
| hashiru                                     | hashirimasu          | run                                        |
| hataraku                                    | hatarakimasu         | work                                       |
| henji suru                                  | henji shimasu        | reply                                      |
| hiku                                        | hikimasu             | catch (a cold)                             |

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| Dictionary form<br>(informal present tense) | Polite present tense | English                       |
|---------------------------------------------|----------------------|-------------------------------|
| hiku                                        | hikimasu             | play (a stringed instrument)  |
| hiyake suru                                 | hiyake shimasu       | get sunburnt                  |
| hōmon suru                                  | hōmon shimasu        | visit                         |
| hosu                                        | hoshimasu            | hang out (clothes etc.)       |
| iku                                         | ikimasu              | go                            |
| ireru                                       | iremasu              | put in [t]                    |
| iru                                         | imasu                | be, there is (living)         |
| iru                                         | irimasu              | need                          |
| isogu                                       | isogimasu            | hurry                         |
| iu                                          | īmasu                | say                           |
| jūden suru                                  | jūden shimasu        | charge (a battery)            |
| kaeru                                       | kaerimasu            | return (home) [i]             |
| kaeru                                       | kaemasu              | change                        |
| kaesu                                       | kaeshimasu           | return (something) [t]        |
| kaimono suru                                | kaimono shimasu      | go shopping                   |
| kaisai suru                                 | kaisai shimasu       | hold (events etc.)            |
| kakaru                                      | kakarimasu           | take (money, time), cost [i]  |
| kakeru                                      | kakemasu             | spend, take (money, time) [t] |
| kaku                                        | kakimasu             | write                         |
| kakunin suru                                | kakunin shimasu      | confirm                       |
| kansei suru                                 | kansei shimasu       | complete                      |
| kansha suru                                 | kansha shimasu       | appreciate, thank             |
| kariru                                      | karimasu             | borrow                        |
| kasu                                        | kashimasu            | lend                          |
| katsu                                       | kachimasu            | win                           |
| kau                                         | kaimasu              | have (a pet)                  |
| kau                                         | kaimasu              | buy                           |
| kawaku                                      | kawakimasu           | dry [i]                       |
| kekkon suru                                 | kekkon shimasu       | marry                         |
| keru                                        | kerimasu             | kick                          |
| kesu                                        | keshimasu            | turn off, extinguish [t]      |

# RICHARD WEBB

| Dictionary form<br>(informal present tense) | Polite present tense | English                   |
|---------------------------------------------|----------------------|---------------------------|
| ki wo tsukeru                               | ki wo tsukemasu      | be careful                |
| kieru                                       | kiemasu              | go off, go out [i]        |
| kikoeru                                     | kikoemasu            | be audible                |
| kiku                                        | kikimasu             | listen, ask               |
| kimeru                                      | kimemasu             | decide [t]                |
| kiru                                        | kimasu               | wear, put on (upper body) |
| kōshin suru                                 | kōshin shimasu       | renew                     |
| kotaeru                                     | kotaemasu            | answer                    |
| kowareru                                    | kowaremasu           | break [i]                 |
| kowasu                                      | kowashimasu          | break [t]                 |
| kureru                                      | kuremasu             | give (towards yourself)   |
| kuru                                        | kimasu               | come                      |
| kyanseru suru                               | kyanseru shimasu     | cancel                    |
| ma ni au                                    | ma ni aimasu         | be on time                |
| machigaeru                                  | machigaemasu         | make a mistake [t]        |
| machigau                                    | machigaimasu         | be mistaken [i]           |
| makeru                                      | makemasu             | lose                      |
| manabu                                      | manabimasu           | learn                     |
| matsu                                       | machimasu            | wait                      |
| mēru suru                                   | mēru shimasu         | email, send email         |
| mieru                                       | miemasu              | be visible                |
| migaku                                      | migakimasu           | clean                     |
| mikakeru                                    | mikakemasu           | spot, see                 |
| miru                                        | mimasu               | watch                     |
| miseru                                      | misemasu             | to show                   |
| mitsukaru                                   | mitsukarimasu        | be found [i]              |
| morau                                       | moraimasu            | receive                   |
| motsu                                       | mochimasu            | hold, carry, own, have    |
| mukae ni iku                                | mukae ni ikimasu     | go and pick up            |
| mukae ni kuru                               | mukae ni kimasu      | come and pick up          |
| naosu                                       | naoshimasu           | fix                       |
| naru                                        | narimasu             | ring                      |

| English                         | Japanese        |
|---------------------------------|-----------------|
| good<br>(skillful or tasty)     | umai            |
| good evening                    | konbanwa        |
| good morning                    | ohayō gozaimasu |
| good night                      | oyasuminasai    |
| goodbye                         | sayonara        |
| good-looking                    | kakkoī          |
| graduation<br>ceremony          | sotsugyōshiki   |
| grandchild                      | mago            |
| grandchild<br>(someone else's)  | omagosan        |
| grandfather<br>(someone else's) | ojisan          |
| grandfather<br>(your own)       | sofu            |
| grandmother<br>(someone else's) | obāsan          |
| grandmother<br>(your own)       | sobo            |
| green                           | midori          |
| guitar                          | gitā            |
| hair                            | kami no ke      |
| half                            | hanbun          |
| hamburger                       | hanbāgā         |
| hand                            | te              |
| happy                           | ureshī          |
| hat                             | bōshi           |
| hate                            | kirai (na)      |
| he                              | kare            |
| head                            | atama           |
| headphones                      | iyahon          |
| heavy                           | omoi            |
| hello                           | konnichiwa      |

| English                     | Japanese                                                     |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| here                        | koko                                                         |
| home                        | ie                                                           |
| home town                   | jimoto                                                       |
| homework                    | shukudai                                                     |
| hospital                    | byōin                                                        |
| host family                 | hosuto famirī                                                |
| hot                         | atsui                                                        |
| hot dog                     | hotto doggu                                                  |
| hotel                       | hoteru                                                       |
| house                       | ie                                                           |
| how                         | dōyatte                                                      |
| how many                    | ikutsu                                                       |
| how much                    | ikura                                                        |
| HR department               | jinjibu                                                      |
| hurts                       | itai                                                         |
| husband<br>(other person's) | goshujin                                                     |
| husband<br>(your own)       | shujin                                                       |
| I                           | watashi (see also:<br>watakushi, boku,<br>atashi, ore, uchi) |
| ice cream                   | aisu kurīmu                                                  |
| I'm okay,<br>no thank you   | kekkō                                                        |
| important                   | taisetsu (na)                                                |
| in front                    | mae                                                          |
| in that way                 | sō                                                           |
| in that way (over<br>there) | ā                                                            |
| in this way                 | kō                                                           |
| in what way                 | dō                                                           |
| inconvenient                | fuben (na)                                                   |
| information                 | jōhō                                                         |

| English                 | Japanese    |
|-------------------------|-------------|
| inside                  | naka        |
| instruction manual      | setsumeisho |
| interesting             | omoshiroi   |
| Internet                | intānetto   |
| island                  | shima       |
| jacket                  | uwagi       |
| January                 | ichigatsu   |
| Japan                   | nihon       |
| Japanese (language)     | nihongo     |
| Japanese bar/restaurant | izakaya     |
| Japanese food           | washoku     |
| job                     | shigoto     |
| July                    | shichigatsu |
| June                    | rokugatsu   |
| key                     | kagi        |
| kilometers              | kiro        |
| kind                    | yasashī     |
| kitchen                 | daidokoro   |
| lake                    | mizūmi      |
| last                    | saigo       |
| last month              | sengetsu    |
| last week               | senshū      |
| last year               | kyonen      |
| later                   | atode       |
| laundry                 | sentakumono |
| left                    | hidari      |
| left hand side          | hidari gawa |
| leg                     | ashi        |
| letter                  | tegami      |
| library                 | toshokan    |
| light                   | karui       |

| English           | Japanese                                               |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| lights            | denki                                                  |
| like              | suki (na)                                              |
| London            | rondon                                                 |
| loud              | urusai                                                 |
| love              | daisuki                                                |
| luggage           | nimotsu                                                |
| lunch             | hirugohan                                              |
| magazine          | zasshi                                                 |
| mall              | mōru                                                   |
| man               | otoko no hito                                          |
| many              | takusan                                                |
| marathon          | marason                                                |
| March             | sangatsu                                               |
| match             | shiai                                                  |
| May               | gogatsu                                                |
| me                | watashi (see also: watakushi, boku, atashi, ore, uchi) |
| meat              | niku                                                   |
| meeting           | kaigi                                                  |
| middle of the day | hiru                                                   |
| milk              | miruku, gyūnyū                                         |
| minutes           | fun                                                    |
| mobile phone      | keitai (denwa)                                         |
| model             | moderu                                                 |
| mom               | haha                                                   |
| Monday            | getsuyōbi                                              |
| money             | okane                                                  |
| monkey            | saru                                                   |
| morning           | asa                                                    |
| mother            | okāsan                                                 |
| motorbike         | baiku                                                  |
| Mount Fuji        | fuji san                                               |

| English                   | Japanese      |
|---------------------------|---------------|
| mountain                  | yama          |
| mouse                     | nezumi        |
| movie                     | eiga          |
| movie theatre             | eigakan       |
| much                      | takusan       |
| music                     | ongaku        |
| name                      | namae         |
| national holiday          | shukujitsu    |
| natto                     | nattō         |
| naughty                   | dame (na)     |
| necessary                 | hitsuyō (na)  |
| necklace                  | nekuresu      |
| never                     | zenzen        |
| new                       | atarashī      |
| news                      | nyūsu         |
| newspaper                 | shinbun       |
| next                      | tsugi         |
| next month                | raigetsu      |
| next to                   | tonari        |
| next week                 | raishū        |
| next year                 | rainen        |
| nice to meet you          | hajimemashite |
| night                     | yoru          |
| nine                      | kyū           |
| no                        | īe            |
| no                        | iya           |
| no thank you,<br>I'm okay | kekkō         |
| nobody                    | daremo        |
| noise                     | oto           |
| noisy                     | urusai        |
| none of them              | doremo        |

| English                           | Japanese     |
|-----------------------------------|--------------|
| not allowed                       | dame (na)    |
| not very                          | amari        |
| not yet                           | mada         |
| nothing                           | nanimo       |
| November                          | jūichigatsu  |
| now                               | ima          |
| nowhere                           | dokomo       |
| October                           | jūgatsu      |
| office                            | ofisu        |
| okay                              | daijōbu (na) |
| old                               | furui        |
| older brother                     | ani          |
| older brother<br>(someone else's) | onīsan       |
| older sister                      | ane          |
| older sister<br>(someone else's)  | onēsan       |
| Olympics                          | orinpikku    |
| on top of                         | ue           |
| one                               | ichi         |
| one of them                       | doreka       |
| online                            | netto de     |
| order                             | chūmon       |
| ouch                              | itai         |
| outside                           | soto         |
| over there                        | asoko        |
| painting                          | e            |
| parents<br>(other person's)       | goryōshin    |
| parents (your own)                | ryōshin      |
| park                              | kōen         |
| particles                         | joshi        |
| part-time job                     | arubaito     |

| English        | Japanese     |
|----------------|--------------|
| party          | pāti         |
| passport       | pasupōto     |
| pasta          | pasuta       |
| pen            | pen          |
| pencil         | enpitsu      |
| people         | hito tachi   |
| person         | hito         |
| phone          | denwa        |
| phone number   | denwa bangō  |
| photograph     | shashin      |
| piano          | piano        |
| picture        | e            |
| pink           | pinku (na)   |
| pizza          | piza         |
| plan           | tsumori      |
| please         | kudasai      |
| policeman      | keisatsukan  |
| possible       | kanō (na)    |
| post office    | yūbinkyoku   |
| postcard       | hagaki       |
| practice       | renshū       |
| present (gift) | purezento    |
| pretty         | kirei (na)   |
| previous       | mae no       |
| Prime Minister | sōri daijin  |
| project        | purojekuto   |
| quiet          | shizuka (na) |
| rain           | ame          |
| ramen          | rāmen        |
| reason         | riyū         |
| red            | akai         |
| refrigerator   | reizōko      |

| English           | Japanese        |
|-------------------|-----------------|
| remote control    | rimokon         |
| rent              | yachin          |
| report            | repōto          |
| reservation       | yoyaku          |
| restaurant        | resutoran       |
| rich              | okanemochi (na) |
| right             | migi            |
| road              | michi           |
| room              | heya            |
| route, the way    | michi           |
| rubbish           | gomi            |
| sad               | kanashī         |
| sake (alcohol)    | osake           |
| salaried employee | sararīman       |
| salt              | shio            |
| sandwich          | sandoicchi      |
| Saturday          | doyōbi          |
| scary             | kowai           |
| scenery           | keshiki         |
| school            | gakkō           |
| science           | kagaku          |
| scissors          | hasami          |
| sea               | umi             |
| seafood           | shīfūdo         |
| season            | kisetsu         |
| seat              | seki            |
| see you later     | mata ne         |
| September         | kugatsu         |
| seven             | shichi, nana    |
| she               | kanojo          |
| shirt             | shatsu          |
| shitsumon         | question        |

| English                 | Japanese   |
|-------------------------|------------|
| shoes                   | kutsu      |
| shop                    | mise       |
| shopping                | kaimono    |
| should<br>(expectation) | hazu       |
| should (obligation)     | beki       |
| show (TV/radio)         | bangumi    |
| shower                  | shawā      |
| siblings, brothers      | kyōdai     |
| sick                    | byōki (na) |
| sign                    | kanban     |
| simple                  | shinpuru   |
| six                     | roku       |
| size                    | saizu      |
| sky                     | sora       |
| small                   | chīsai     |
| small (cramped)         | semai      |
| smartphone              | sumaho     |
| smell                   | nioi       |
| smelly                  | kusai      |
| snow                    | yuki       |
| soccer                  | sakkā      |
| sofa                    | sofa       |
| somebody                | dareka     |
| something               | nanika     |
| sometime                | itsuka     |
| somewhere               | dokoka     |
| son<br>(someone else's) | musukosan  |
| son (your own)          | musuko     |
| song                    | uta        |
| sorry                   | gomennasai |
| sound                   | oto        |

| English                   | Japanese     |
|---------------------------|--------------|
| South Korea               | kankoku      |
| souvenir                  | omiyage      |
| spacious                  | hiroi        |
| Spanish (language)        | supeingo     |
| sport                     | supōtsu      |
| spring                    | haru         |
| spy                       | supai        |
| staff                     | sutaffu      |
| stamp                     | kitte        |
| station                   | eki          |
| steak                     | sutēki       |
| steel                     | tekkō        |
| still                     | mada         |
| stomach                   | onaka        |
| store                     | mise         |
| straight                  | massugu (na) |
| strange                   | hen (na)     |
| strong                    | tsuyoi       |
| student                   | gakusei      |
| summer                    | natsu        |
| Sunday                    | nichiyōbi    |
| sunglasses                | sangurasu    |
| sunscreen                 | hiyakedome   |
| supermarket               | sūpā         |
| sweets                    | okashi       |
| swimming pool             | pūru         |
| swing<br>(play equipment) | buranko      |
| table                     | tēburu       |
| tall                      | takai        |
| tea                       | ocha         |
| teacher                   | sensei       |
| teeth                     | ha           |

| English                      | Japanese          |
|------------------------------|-------------------|
| ten                          | jū                |
| tennis                       | tenisu            |
| test                         | tesuto            |
| thank you                    | arigatō           |
| thank you (polite)           | arigatō gozaimasu |
| that                         | sore              |
| that (over there)            | are               |
| that<br>(over there, polite) | achira            |
| that (polite)                | sochira           |
| that kind of                 | sonna             |
| that kind of<br>(over there) | anna              |
| that x                       | sono              |
| that x (over there)          | ano               |
| the day before<br>yesterday  | ototoi            |
| then, and then               | soshite           |
| there                        | soko              |
| they                         | karera            |
| things                       | mono              |
| this                         | kore              |
| this (polite)                | kochira           |
| this kind of                 | konna             |
| this month                   | kongetsu          |
| this morning                 | kesa              |
| this week                    | konshū            |
| this x                       | kono              |
| this year                    | kotoshi           |
| three                        | san               |
| throat                       | nodo              |
| Thursday                     | mokuyōbi          |
| ticket                       | chiketto          |

| English                 | Japanese         |
|-------------------------|------------------|
| time                    | jikan            |
| today                   | kyō              |
| toilet                  | toire            |
| tomorrow                | ashita           |
| tonight                 | kon'ya           |
| tour                    | tsuā             |
| tourist                 | kankōkyaku       |
| town                    | machi            |
| train                   | densha           |
| trash                   | gomi             |
| travel                  | ryokō            |
| tree                    | ki               |
| Tuesday                 | kayōbi           |
| turn<br>(in a sequence) | ban              |
| TV                      | terebi           |
| two                     | ni               |
| ugly                    | minikui          |
| umm                     | anō, etto        |
| unacceptable            | ikenai, ikemasen |
| underneath              | shita            |
| United Kingdom          | igirisu          |
| university              | daigaku          |
| us                      | watashi tachi    |
| vacation                | yasumi           |
| vegetables              | yasai            |
| very                    | totemo           |
| visa                    | biza             |
| voice                   | koe              |
| volleyball              | barē, barēbōru   |
| wallet                  | saifu            |
| want                    | hoshī            |

| English                  | Japanese       |
|--------------------------|----------------|
| warm                     | atatakai       |
| water                    | mizu           |
| way (route)              | michi          |
| we                       | watashi tachi  |
| weather                  | tenki          |
| Wednesday                | suiyōbi        |
| weekend                  | shūmatsu       |
| well (health-wise)       | genki (na)     |
| what                     | nan            |
| what                     | nan, nani      |
| what day?                | nan'yōbi       |
| what kind of             | donna          |
| what month?              | nangatsu       |
| when                     | itsu           |
| where                    | doko           |
| which                    | dore           |
| which (polite)           | dochira        |
| which x                  | dono           |
| whichever                | doredemo       |
| white                    | shiroi         |
| who                      | dare           |
| why                      | dōshite, nande |
| wife<br>(someone else's) | okusan         |
| wife (your own)          | tsuma          |
| wind                     | kaze           |
| window                   | mado           |
| wine                     | wain           |
| winter                   | fuyu           |
| woman                    | onna no hito   |
| work                     | shigoto        |
| world                    | sekai          |

| English                             | Japanese         |
|-------------------------------------|------------------|
| year after next                     | sarainen         |
| year before last                    | ototoshi         |
| years                               | nen              |
| yellow                              | kīroi            |
| yen                                 | en               |
| yes                                 | hai              |
| yesterday                           | kinō             |
| you                                 | anata            |
| younger brother<br>(someone else's) | otōtosan         |
| younger brother<br>(your own)       | otōto            |
| younger sister<br>(someone else's)  | imōtosan         |
| younger sister<br>(your own)        | imōto            |
| you're welcome                      | dō itashimashite |
| zoo                                 | dōbutsuen        |



# Appendix 5

## Non-verb dictionary (Japanese - English)

This dictionary contains all of the vocabulary that appears in the examples and exercises in this book, except verbs. For a Japanese-English verb dictionary, see Appendix 3.

| Japanese    | English                      |
|-------------|------------------------------|
| ā           | in that way<br>(over there)  |
| abunai      | dangerous                    |
| achira      | that<br>(over there, polite) |
| adobaisu    | advice                       |
| afurika     | Africa                       |
| aisu kurīmu | ice cream                    |
| akachan     | baby                         |
| akai        | red                          |
| aki         | autumn                       |
| amari       | not very                     |
| ame         | rain                         |

| Japanese          | English                      |
|-------------------|------------------------------|
| amerika           | America                      |
| anata             | you                          |
| ane               | older sister                 |
| ani               | older brother                |
| anna              | that kind of<br>(over there) |
| ano               | that x (over there)          |
| anō               | umm                          |
| aoi               | blue                         |
| arāmu             | alarm                        |
| are               | that (over there)            |
| arigatō           | thank you                    |
| arigatō gozaimasu | thank you (polite)           |

# RICHARD WEBB

| Japanese          | English                          |
|-------------------|----------------------------------|
| arubaito          | part-time job                    |
| asa               | morning                          |
| asagohan          | breakfast                        |
| asatte            | day after tomorrow               |
| ashi              | leg                              |
| ashita            | tomorrow                         |
| asoko             | over there                       |
| atama             | head                             |
| atarashī          | new                              |
| atashi            | I, me (for women/<br>girls only) |
| atatakai          | warm                             |
| ATM (ē tī emu)    | ATM                              |
| atode             | later                            |
| atsui             | hot                              |
| baiku             | motorbike                        |
| ban               | turn (in a sequence)             |
| bangohan          | dinner                           |
| bangumi           | show (TV/radio)                  |
| barē, barēbōru    | volleyball                       |
| basu              | bus                              |
| basuke, basuketto | basketball                       |
| bōru              |                                  |
| beddo             | bed                              |
| beki              | should (obligation)              |
| benri (na)        | convenient                       |
| bīru              | beer                             |
| biza              | visa                             |
| boku              | I, me (for men/boys<br>only)     |
| bōru              | ball                             |
| bōshi             | hat                              |
| bunka             | culture                          |

| Japanese         | English                         |
|------------------|---------------------------------|
| buranko          | swing<br>(play equipment)       |
| byō              | seconds, counter<br>for seconds |
| byōin            | hospital                        |
| byōki (na)       | sick                            |
| chichi           | dad                             |
| chiketto         | ticket                          |
| chīsai           | small                           |
| chīzu            | cheese                          |
| chokorēto        | chocolate                       |
| chotto           | a bit                           |
| chūgoku          | China                           |
| chūgokugo        | Chinese (language)              |
| chūmon           | order                           |
| daidokoro        | kitchen                         |
| daigaku          | university                      |
| daijōbu (na)     | okay, fine                      |
| daisuki          | love                            |
| dame (na)        | not allowed,<br>naughty         |
| dare             | who                             |
| daredemo         | anybody                         |
| dareka           | somebody                        |
| daremo           | everybody, nobody               |
| demo             | but                             |
| denki            | lights                          |
| densha           | train                           |
| denwa            | phone                           |
| denwa bangō      | phone number                    |
| dēto             | date (romantic)                 |
| dō               | in what way                     |
| dō itashimashite | you're welcome                  |

# 80/20 JAPANESE

| Japanese   | English                      |
|------------|------------------------------|
| doa        | door                         |
| dōbutsuen  | zoo                          |
| dochira    | which (polite)               |
| doitsu     | Germany                      |
| doko       | where                        |
| dokodemo   | anywhere                     |
| dokoka     | somewhere                    |
| dokomo     | everywhere,<br>nowhere       |
| donna      | what kind of                 |
| dono       | which x                      |
| dore       | which                        |
| doredemo   | whichever                    |
| doreka     | one of them                  |
| doremo     | all of them, none of<br>them |
| dōryō      | colleagues                   |
| dōshite    | why                          |
| dōyatte    | how                          |
| doyōbi     | Saturday                     |
| e          | painting, picture            |
| eakon      | air conditioner              |
| eiga       | movie                        |
| eigakan    | cinema, movie<br>theatre     |
| eigo       | English (language)           |
| eki        | station                      |
| en         | yen, counter for yen         |
| enpitsu    | pencil                       |
| erebēta    | elevator                     |
| etto       | umm                          |
| fuben (na) | inconvenient                 |
| fuji san   | Mount Fuji                   |

| Japanese    | English                         |
|-------------|---------------------------------|
| fuku        | clothes                         |
| fukuzatsu   | complicated                     |
| fun (kan)   | minutes, counter<br>for minutes |
| furansu     | France                          |
| furoba      | bathroom                        |
| furui       | old                             |
| futtobōru   | football                        |
| fuyu        | winter                          |
| gakkō       | school                          |
| gakusei     | student                         |
| genki (na)  | fine, well<br>(health-wise)     |
| getsuyōbi   | Monday                          |
| ginkō       | bank                            |
| gitā        | guitar                          |
| go          | five                            |
| gogatsu     | May                             |
| gogo        | afternoon                       |
| gomennasai  | sorry                           |
| gomi        | garbage,<br>rubbish, trash      |
| gorufu      | golf                            |
| goryōshin   | parents<br>(other person's)     |
| goshujin    | husband<br>(other person's)     |
| ... goto ni | every...<br>(period of time)    |
| gyūnyū      | milk                            |
| ha          | teeth                           |
| hachi       | eight                           |
| hachigatsu  | August                          |
| hagaki      | postcard                        |

# RICHARD WEBB

| Japanese      | English              |
|---------------|----------------------|
| haha          | mom                  |
| hai           | yes                  |
| haisha        | dentist              |
| hajime        | beginning            |
| hajimemashite | nice to meet you     |
| hako          | box                  |
| hanbāgā       | hamburger            |
| hanbun        | half                 |
| haru          | spring               |
| hasami        | scissors             |
| hayai         | fast, early          |
| hazu          | should (expectation) |
| hen (na)      | strange              |
| heya          | room                 |
| hi            | day                  |
| hidari        | left                 |
| hidari gawa   | left hand side       |
| hiki          | counter for animals  |
| hikōki        | airplane             |
| hima (na)     | bored, free          |
| hima na toki  | free time            |
| hinpan ni     | frequently           |
| hiroi         | spacious             |
| hiru          | middle of the day    |
| hirugohan     | lunch                |
| hito          | person               |
| hito tachi    | people               |
| hitsuyō (na)  | necessary            |
| hiyakedome    | sunscreen            |
| hon           | book                 |
| hoshī         | want                 |
| hosuto famirī | host family          |
| hoteru        | hotel                |

| Japanese         | English                            |
|------------------|------------------------------------|
| hotto doggu      | hot dog                            |
| ī                | good                               |
| ichi             | one                                |
| ichigatsu        | January                            |
| ie               | house, home                        |
| īe               | no                                 |
| igirisu          | United Kingdom                     |
| ikenai, ikemasen | unacceptable                       |
| ikura            | how much                           |
| ikutsu           | how many                           |
| ima              | now                                |
| imōto            | younger sister<br>(your own)       |
| imōtosan         | younger sister<br>(someone else's) |
| intānetto        | Internet                           |
| inu              | dog                                |
| isha             | doctor                             |
| isogashī         | busy                               |
| isu              | chair                              |
| itai             | ouch, hurts                        |
| itsu             | when                               |
| itsudemo         | any time                           |
| itsuka           | sometime                           |
| itsumo           | always                             |
| iya              | no                                 |
| iyahon           | headphones                         |
| izakaya          | Japanese bar/<br>restaurant        |
| ji               | counter for hour<br>of the day     |
| jikan            | time, counter<br>for hours         |
| jimoto           | home town                          |

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| Japanese      | English         |
|---------------|-----------------|
| wain          | wine            |
| wanpīsu       | dress           |
| warui         | bad             |
| washoku       | Japanese food   |
| watakushi     | I, me (formal)  |
| watashi       | I, me           |
| watashi tachi | we, us          |
| yachin        | rent            |
| yakyū         | baseball        |
| yama          | mountain        |
| yasai         | vegetables      |
| yasashī       | kind            |
| yasui         | cheap           |
| yasumi        | break, vacation |
| yoi           | good            |
| yon           | four            |
| yoru          | night           |
| yoyaku        | reservation     |
| yūbinkyoku    | post office     |
| yūenchi       | amusement park  |
| yuka          | floor           |
| yuki          | snow            |
| yūmei (na)    | famous          |
| zasshi        | magazine        |
| zenbu         | everything      |
| zenzen        | never           |
| zettai ni     | definitely      |
| zō            | elephant        |